

SARVODAYA IN A COMMUNIST STATE

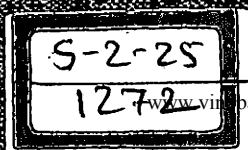
*Socio-Economic Study of
Gandhi Movement in Kerala*

SACHIDANAND

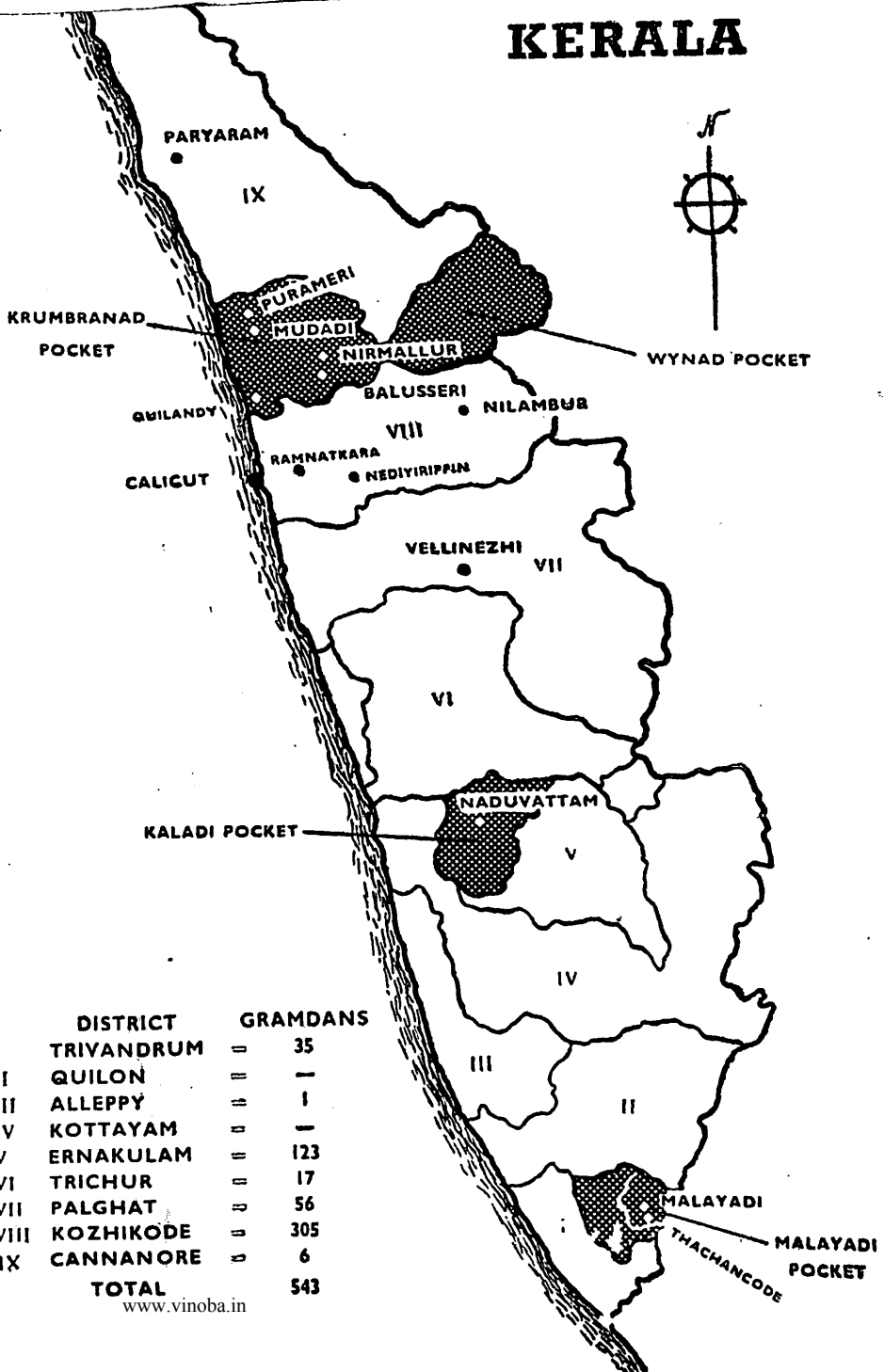
D. K. GABRIEL

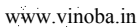


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KERALA





SARVODAYA IN A COMMUNIST STATE

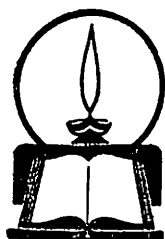
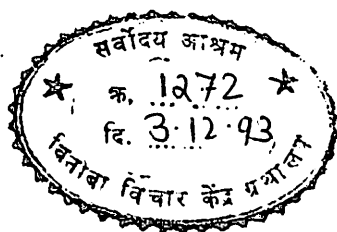
*A Socio-Economic Study of
Gramdan Movement in Kerala*

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By
SACHIDANAND

Foreword by
D. R. GADGIL



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FOREWORD

I first met the author of this publication in January, 1957, at Koraput. It was clear even at first glance that he represented an unusual type. Here was a youthful Sadhu who had retained both his cheerfulness and his critical faculty. That he had many other exceptional qualities became clear on closer acquaintance. Therefore, when, many months later, he suggested the possibility of his embarking on a study tour of Kerala, I was glad to offer all the help that I could. The result of the tour and the study is embodied in this publication; and it has like the author, many unusual attributes.

The tour was conducted when Kerala was still governed by a cabinet belonging to the Communist Party of India and had, on that account, attracted universal attention. However, at the same time, it was reported that the Gramdan movement had made particularly impressive progress in the State. It was this that, with his background of work at Koraput, attracted Shri Sachidanand to Kerala. Once in the State, with a characteristic thoroughness, he visited and studied on the spot not only the Gramdan villages, but also all other types of efforts at rural reconstruction, official, semi-official, and non-official that were being undertaken in the State and were in progress. He had the great advantage of being an authentic Sarvodaya worker himself and of having introduction and access to all workers and all locations. Of this, he made full use and there is little of factual or descriptive material in relation to the attempts at rural reconstruction, set down in this study which is not based on personal observation or scrutiny. The author, though well

educated, cannot in the usual sense of the term be called a social scientist. He can also lay no claim to being objective, in the sense of not having an individual frame of reference and of not judging men and events according to a personal scale of valuations. However, the frame and the values are clearly evident and the reader can make due allowance for them while reading the comments and the explanations. Equally the book is not just reportage by somebody not involved in the schemes or experiments. Shri Sachidanand has, at an early stage, accepted a way of life and dedicated himself to certain types of effort. He is, therefore, fully involved in and personally concerned with the attempts and the experiments, the programmes and the schemes which he observes and analyses. The study is thus neither just factual description, nor a social scientist's account nor even evaluation by outside agency, though it has in part the attributes of all three. It attempts to set out facts, to analyse situations and trends and also to evaluate results. But this is done by one who has worked at similar efforts from the inside and is moved by shared ideals.

In presenting the study, Shri Sachidanand faced many difficulties. Some of these related to arrangement, emphasis, or presentation. To a certain extent, it was possible to give help externally to enable him to get over these. However, the major difficulty faced was of how to give a faithful picture and a useful analysis and to draw correct conclusions without entering into details of personal circumstance and behaviour. The publication is made up, in the main, of what might be called case studies. A case study in the hands of a social scientist can usually be presented in anonymous terms and except perhaps to a small group its subjects can remain unidentifiable. No such way out was possible in this respect as the number of cases was small, well-known and easily identifiable. There was no question of being able to conceal personal identity. Once this was accepted, it became clear that a considerable amount of the reporting and analysis would inevitably read like personal criticism. Shri Sachidanand took the decision, I feel, correctly, that this could not be avoided and that a frank statement of his personal views, though critical, was preferable, in this context,

to an attempt to hide identities or to camouflage reality through oblique statements which could mislead, or, at least, not convey the meaning in full. Of course, the way out, in such a matter, that a Sanyasi can follow without reproach is not necessarily open to every reporter or student.

The chief merits of the publication follow from the exceptional circumstances and equipment of the author, and also from his wide coverage and outlook. The result is a publication in which, within a brief compass, are studied critically samples of the many-sided rural programmes and activities that are being attempted in all parts of India. We also incidentally get a vivid picture of the rural economy of the State with a considerable amount of meaningful sociological detail associated with the evaluation of the various programmes. As a result, apart from getting a comparative view of the merits of the various approaches the reader is enabled to obtain some appreciation of the human, individual and group, difficulties that all approaches encounter equally.

Gokhale Institute of
Politics and Economics,
Poona 4
25th March 1961

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D. R. GADGIL

INTRODUCTION

Author's spiritual relationship with Vinoba dates back to 1945 when at Nalwadi Ashram, Wardha he was initiated into social work through a short course in tannery. But it was only later that he got sensitized to the rural socio-economic phenomena through nine years of devoted village work in his native border district of Punjab famous for its virile peasantry where he was actively engaged in building up of the co-operatives, strengthening of the Panchayats, raising of schools and community services, dealing simultaneously with the problems of tenants and the menace of criminals, receiving all along a mixed response of help and hurdles from the administration, admiration and condemnation from the political parties but a warm response from the people throughout his work.

The Gramdan movement finally pulled him out of his village work in 1955. Absorbed for four months by Vinoba in his entourage during his Andhra trek in 1955-56, he joined at Koraput (Orissa) in April 1956, worked as an editor of *Gramdan* — an English monthly and left in 1958 to regain his freedom of expression both in thought and action.

The author had seen from the closest quarters the Sarvodaya Philosophy at work on an all-India level at Koraput under a Congress Government and felt inclined to see how Sarvodaya wheels go round in a Communist State where a party with equally competent ideology was at the helm of affairs. Equally strong was the urge to see the movement at work at a provincial level under the local leadership since in Koraput things were somewhat different. Moreover, does the Gramdan

ideology uncork a fresh spring of potentialities amongst the social workers, the people and the administrators? Do the ideas have any effectiveness in action or are they merely a luxury of ageing intellects? Is the ideology a sheer faith expressed in talk and print or are there any achievements which can be the true indices? All these questions drove the author to take up the study of Gramdan movement in Kerala which was also the next below Koraput on the All-India Gramdan scoreboard.

The idea received the patronage of Prof. D. R. Gadgil, Director, Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics, Poona whom the author knew more closely when the learned Economist visited Koraput early 1957 and left a very good impression on the entire development team by his objective, scientific approach and keen analysis of the problems facing the Sarvodaya planners at Koraput.

The author reached Kerala in the first week of November, 1958, anticipating the Grant-in-aid from the Gokhale Institute which followed in the middle of December, 1958. Some indifference and reluctance were encountered for this study from the responsible Sarvodaya quarters in the beginning which later on gave way in the course of time through mutual understanding. All the necessary information has been gathered in most cordial manner with cross checking from critical quarters and the people involved. First fortnight was spent in collecting the information about the field *i.e.*, where, why and how of things through written or printed material and the general resources of the provincial headquarters of Sarvodaya Mandal at Calicut. The villaging took two months. The connected studies in the libraries took nearly two and a half months and then finally the pen pushing part of the job took another two and a half months which included, selecting, screening, sifting, tabulating and processing the material in such a coherent humanised manner as to transform Economics into literature.

In all, 21 centres were visited. One Sarvodaya Mandal meeting, one seminar and two Gramdan work Camps organized by Gandhi Smarak Nidhi were attended. The social worker at the field level was the main source of information but to

correct the exaggerations, critical quarters were equally approached and a sample study of the people involved was also carried out through a set of questions sometimes in the presence of the worker but often in his absence through a reliable interpreter offered by the worker himself for the purpose. Some difficulty was experienced at a place or two regarding cross-checking of the information supplied by the worker for lack of interpreters. Where official figures differed from those available with the worker in the field, the latter were relied upon. Only at one centre the worker objected to critical enquiry; otherwise, the document mirrors what workers or the people had to say or wanted to be said. Few workers had the fondness for statistical study of their own work. Some wanted orientation into it while others had an aversion to the statistical grasp of their own work. As such, within one or two days' stay at each centre what could be drawn out has been chiselled to make it presentable in a pleasant style.

The Sarvodaya Mandal entirely, Gandhi Smarak Nidhi almost equally, Khadi Commission partially and C. D. Block personnel remotely through a top-level understanding, stood committed to the Gramdan follow-up work. The role of each agency has been evaluated to the extent of responsibility shouldered by it.

The Gramdan idea has a different meaning in Kerala due to its peculiar rural setting and sociology. The villages here are not nucleated but scattered habitations. In Orissa, cent per cent population of a revenue village was required to qualify itself for Gramdan but in Madras 80 per cent of the population or 50 per cent of the land were required to get a village or a contiguous village hamlet legally declared as Gramdan. The signatories, it is understood, relinquish their individual rights over property and declare the community ownership of their land, etc. so pooled under Gramdan. A part of the pooled land is left for community cultivation, the rest is generally redistributed amongst the population. The cottage industries programme is activized and the community is mobilized to solve its problems on a co-operative basis of management.

But in Kerala, a contiguous area of any 20 families or more has been accepted as a basis for the declaration of Gramdan. The idea has not gained any legal recognition due to the complicated nature of the problem but the co-operative bye-laws are said to have been modified on the lines taken up by the Madras Government regarding the Gramdan villages there.

The attempt has been made herein to help the workers note their achievements and grasp their problems and the lay readers, agencies and the academies understand the practical aspects of the movement in a particular state. The work will certainly be found lacking in the academicism of research for various reasons. Firstly, the author is a raw hand in that line. Secondly, the workers engaged in the movement lacked that perspective. Thirdly, the time was too short and the author was all alone to go into the details of things and cover the whole range of field work. Without academic considerations, methodology or technique, the author has tried to tell the reader what he himself as an independent detached observer felt curious to know and found available in the field. He has confined himself more or less to the description and discussion of the concrete situations.

The comments wherever made are not intended to interfere with activities but to clarify and broaden the horizons. The severity at places is born sheerly out of sincerity and not in the least out of ill will against any person or institution. Sizing up of personalities in a movement based on the goodness of the individual seemed almost unavoidable to the writer. Above all, his faith in Vinoba and the Gramdan movement is quite strong but not so blind as to atrophy the attitude of critical enquiry into the growth of the movement.

It was stated during the course of study that it was too early to evaluate the growth and development of Gramdans which were only two years old in Kerala. In answer it will be quite fitting to quote Mr. Albert Mayer who says, "The real test of an organization's ability is getting a job well started and winding it up without too much fooling around since almost anyone could run a job during the middle stages."

The whole material has been divided into five parts. Part 1 deals with the physical, social, economic, historical and political characteristics of Kerala. During the field study, camps and discussions with the workers and others involved in the Gramdan work majority of them were found not to have an adequate understanding of the facts about Kerala's economy. As such, they were proving incompetent to serve as catalytic agents to help the people understand their problems through a detailed study of the economic environment. More pages have, therefore, been devoted to that aspect to help the local workers particularly and the lay readers and others broadly. Part 2 informs about the visit and views of the founder of the movement, declaration of Gramdans and a brief covering of the agencies that took up directly or indirectly the Gramdan follow up work. Parts 3 and 4 deal with the experiments taken up in agriculture and non-agriculture sector respectively and constitute the heart of the study. The last *i.e.*, Part 5 carries the critical evaluation of the experiment as a whole, of the organizations and agencies involved and weighs comparatively the general traits and trends of the movement.

The whole effort may be considered as a clearance of road-blocks between the field and the institutions interested or engaged in rural development, between the movement and the laity. A trial has been made to pull out the maximum information within the minimum possible resources. The deficiencies in presentation can both be due to the author's personal ignorance as well as lack of information provided by the field workers and other agencies involved in the movement. If the attempt could stimulate the thinking of Sarvodaya workers, rural economists and planners, all the rigours involved in the work would be duly rewarded.

The author expresses his deep gratitude to the Sarvodaya leaders specially Shri Kelappan, Shri Ikkanda Warriar, Shri Shyamji Sundardass for their very helpful attitude towards his work. He is equally indebted to the editor of *Bhoodan Kahlam* — a Malayalam weekly — for laying at his disposal the record of Vinoba's prayer speeches (in Hindi) delivered in Kerala. Shri R. K. Menon, Shri Gopinath Nair, and Shri Ram-

chandran Potty who have been greatly helpful to introduce him to the core of the movement deserve his hearty thanks. Shri S. V. Govindan, the author's colleague in Vinoba's Andhra trek (Padyatra) in 1955-56 has been too kind to him to lend his help right from the initial to the final stage of work in procuring all necessary information out of the material printed in Malayalam. It is, in fact, a joint enterprise of all the friends working in the Gramdan field and the author feels indebted to all for the direct or indirect help rendered in this work. He however, earnestly expects to be excused for straightforwardness which may hurt the ego of a few at this stage but will help the cause and the country in the long run.

Last of all, the author is highly grateful for the generous help rendered by Prof. John G. McNeely, the Visiting Professor from A. and M. College, Texas, U.S.A., Shri D. P. Apte, the Registrar, and Prof. D. K. Bedekar, the Managing Editor of *Artha Vijnana*, (all the three from the Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics, Poona) and Shri P. H. Patwardhan, Ex-Editor, *Bhoodan* — English Weekly, who reviewed the manuscript and contributed considerably in compressing and editing the material.

In the end, no emphasis will be too great to state that but for the guidance and help of Prof. D. R. Gadgil the author would have been greatly handicapped in this free lance adventure in field study.

The author is indeed very grateful to Shri Viswanathan who has served as a host at Mitraniketan District Trivandrum, Kerala during the course of writing, making his library, typewriter and the typist Shri Sasidharan Nair available for work.

THE AUTHOR

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ERRATA

<i>Page</i>	<i>Line</i>	<i>Read</i>	<i>for</i>
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17	37	acres	crores
18	8	1000 acres	100 acres
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27	31	Know-how	know how
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126	84	procured	produced
136	11	lie	lies
		boats	beats

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137	7	sq. yards	sq. ft. yards
	10	seva	sevak
144	33	engaged in	engaged is
145	7	Cooperative	Crop
155	29	villages	villages.
174	11	alerted	altered
183	11	moneyed class	money class
—	13	social	socail
187	24	Chapter 10	Chapter 11
193	26	individuals	individual
198	last line	Reform and Cooperative	Reform Cooperative

Correction

On page 184 the order of first two paragraphs under heading V should be reversed.

PART 1

A Glance at Kerala

CHAPTER 1

On the Sands of Time

WHAT STRANGE tales would history unfold if only the gifts of speech were allowed to the sands snoring at the shores of Kerala along its 360 mile long coast. As the breeze goes rustling through the feathery coconut leaves and the waves helplessly dash along the shores, one ponders how the ascendant naval powers and many an old kingdom lies ship-wrecked along these sandy coasts. The world trade, travel and history rubbed their shoulders here. King Solomon's sandalwood, ivory, apes and peacocks went to ancient Israel from Kerala. Ships from China, Java, Abyssinia, Zanzibar, Hedjaz, Egypt and Carthage anchored here to load beautiful gems, gorgeous fabrics, fragrant sandalwood, cardamom, pepper, coir, and cinnamon to carry them on to the different world markets.

For centuries, Kerala, surrounded by world market forces, was India's window on the world to see the surging waves of new historical trends on the globe, which sent travellers from its distant corners. A few of them have cared to leave a record of their impressions. Hieun Tsang (629-645), Al Beruni (970-1039) and Marco Polo (1271-1294) speak highly of its balmy temperate climate, its rich spices, busiest harbours, and good rulers who "permit the exercise of every kind of religion and yet it is strictly forbidden to talk, dispute or quarrel on that subject".

St. Thomas, the apostle landed here at Cranganur in A.D. 52 and planted Christianity for the first time in India. Here came the Jews after the final desolation of Jerusalem in A.D. 69.

Thomas Cama landed here from Syria with Syrian Christians. The first mosque in India also rose here at Cranganur. The first European ship touched here at Calicut on May 20, 1498 when Vasco da Gama could finally explore the much sought-after sea-route to India after Columbus had gone astray.

Pointing to a vine on the tree, your host in Kerala will tell you that this pepper drew the European Imperialists to our land. It was not an understatement for Tippu, who actually pulled down all the pepper vines along the coast near Calicut and cut down the tufts of Hindus to secure his kingdom in South India. The Dutch knocking out the Portuguese exported annually about 2 million pounds of pepper from these coasts and in the height of commercial rivalry had a beautiful Portuguese cathedral at Cochin converted into a warehouse to store pepper throwing away the 'Book and the civilization mission' at the altar of trade. The British who chased the Dutch made an improvement; they had the nave of this cathedral blown up on the plea that it occupied too much space. The tower of the church was used as a flag staff and a lighthouse.

The European private interests started from here to build up kingdoms much bigger than their Kings (pushed back to the palaces by the parliaments) had at home, till India rose in revolt in 1857. The East India Company and the mutineers lost. The British Parliament won, from whom Indian people patiently learnt the lessons of democracy by paying their tuitions through shiploads of merchandise and trade carried to the extreme favour of British economy whereas all the plunder that passed through Khyber taught little to India. And the lesson had been so thoroughly learnt that the Kerala Communists rose smoothly to power through the ballot for the first time in the history of communism.*

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2. *Travels of Marco Polo*
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*The Communist Ministry was dismissed on 31st July, 1959 under proclamation by the President of India due to a State-wide agitation against the Ministry that had passed some progressive legislative Acts.

CHAPTER 2

The Land of Coconuts

THE STATE has its name Malabar derived from the word Malayala (meaning hills to sea waves) since physically it tapers off from the *hills* (Malaya) in the east to the *sea waves* (Ala) in the west. In between lies 'the land of coconuts' which is the literal meaning of Kerala. Looking like a silk worm on map, it is corrugated geographically on east by the towering salubrious Western Ghats (with Anamudi peak as the highest point in India, south of Himalayas — height 8840 feet) and on the west the lowest contour is marked by the rippling green Arabian sea. As such, Kerala has its sunrise always from the hill-tops and sun-set always in the sea. The south-west and north-east Monsoons are whipped down by the Ghats showering an average annual rainfall of 200 inches in the hills, 118" at Kozhikode (Calicut) in the north and decreasing south-ward to 68" at Trivandrum, bringing the average for the state to 120". The rainy season extending from June to November is the longest here. Humidity during the season is 90%. The rest of the year comes under the summer season. The mercury moves between 70° to 90° F. during the year. Due to the closeness of the sea and the mountains the climate is temperate even though the state lies between 8° to 12° north of equator. Winter is a mere imagination for the people here.

40 miles in breadth on an average, Kerala is India's smallest State, holds about 360 miles of India's coastline on the south-west coast, and is only 15,035 sq. miles in area. The present

state of Kerala as it emerged officially on November 1, 1956 on the recommendations of S.R.C. holds 1,35,00,000 (Census 1951) Malayalam speaking citizens, young and old, formerly split into three parts, i.e. two princely States of Travancore and Cochin and the Malabar district of Madras State. The State has a population equal to Canada. It is a 24 hours' journey across the state, length-wise. The train runs mostly along the coast, the western ghats dominating the view all along. Forty-one rivers move drowsily, east to west, from Ghats to the sea like a woof through the warp intercepting the vegetation after every 10 miles or so and provide immense scope for generation of hydro-electric power. Physically the state can be divided into three regions.

The Coastal Region

Along the coastal strip are the deltas of the dead slow rivers, canals, lakes, lagoons, and back-waters with coconut palm growing like grass on the banks. Human life shifts between the aquatic and the botanical. The scenic effect is grand all along. The boatmen and fishermen are as prominent in the daily life as the farmers. Coconut not only adds the poetic charm to the region through its feathery leaves and tall stately stem but constitutes the major hub of Kerala's economy. Salt, shells and shark from the sea, coir and commerce on the land are the main pursuits along the coast where harbours of Cochin, Alleppey and Trivandrum also provide employment to many. The density of population in this region is at places as high as 2,500 persons per square mile.

The Midland

In the midland lie the undulating hilly tracts of red laterite soil where lakes of verdure presented by the plain paddy fields alternate with coconut and arecanut gardens and groves on the elevated terrain with pepper vines, plantains, jack fruits, cashew-nut, tapioca and sugarcane as co-sharers of land. Cashew-nut factories and bamboo and mat-making crafts employ a large section of working class population here.

The Hilly Region

In the cooler climate of the western Ghats maintaining an

average elevation of 3,000 feet lie the hill stations, power stations, tea, coffee and rubber plantations. Kanan Devan, a British concern wields one lakh acres and is the biggest tea estate here. In spite of the indiscriminate felling of the forests holding nearly 600 species of timber forming 25% of the total geographical area of the state, wild life, i.e., tigers and elephants along with the hill tribes of Paniyas, Kanikars, and Irulas, etc. are still asserting their rights to live and let live. The revenue from the forests is about Rs. 10.00 per acre in the State while it is only Rs. 3.00 in India as a whole. Plantations, timber, collection of the forest produce and cattle-breeding provide employment to the people in these thinly populated but comparatively cooler areas where one feels a relief from the monotony of coconuts dominating the scene in the midland and the coastal region.

CHAPTER 3

Kerala is Different

WHEN A local administrator discusses Kerala in general with a visitor to the state he pleads with confidence and ease that Kerala is different. One is left to discover the truth. Actually the more one knows the delicacies of the social fabric here, the sooner one is convinced that actually Kerala is in many ways different from other parts of India.

The Village System

The first distinct feature is its outstanding natural beauty no doubt, but the village system obtaining in the state is surprisingly different from the rest of India. Even a low flying aeroplane may not be able to discover its countryside except its schools and churches (equally prominent in geography as well as politics). There is no compact village population as such. Detached homesteads sparingly sprinkled throughout the land, blink through the lush evergreen vegetation. The broad big fanning leaves of plantains, vertically rising pepper vines, large spreading jack-fruit, umbrella like graceful areca, tall stately coconut with its arching tips of majestic leaves spreading out at the top, entirely cover the homesteads separated from each other by the hedges of hibiscus and lantana, with ferns and creepers twining through the hedge-rows. Excepting the towns nowhere does one find the roofs crowded together lining along the lanes and roads to give the nucleated picture of a village.

Against India's percentage of 82.7 per cent, Kerala* has 86.8 per cent population, spread out in 2 million homesteads artificially grouped into 4,615 villages merely on paper by revenue administration which has failed to define the word 'village'. *Amsom* and *desham*, the rural territorial divisions equivalent of an Indian village or an *ilaqa* are interchangeable and an outsider is baffled to make anything out of the mess. A single village holds 18,000 population at times. In the Second Five Year Plan of Kerala, the number of villages is stated as 4,615. In 'Kerala At a Glance' issued by the Department of Statistics it is shown as 1,633. Both are Government of Kerala Publications. Former comes in 1958 the latter in 1959. There is no margin for printer's devil.

The Panchayat System

There is one Panchayat Act operative in Travancore-Cochin and another in Malabar areas. At places, the Panchayat area coincides with the revenue villages, elsewhere it does not. The population under a single Panchayat ranges from 10,000 to 25,000 persons housed over an area of 10 to 12 miles. And these Panchayats, with no judicial powers to exercise, serve only as a revenue collecting and administrative wing of the Government set up and do not have any element of local autonomy. They play a little role to bring about an integrated social structure at the village level.

Highest Density of Population

Kerala is one of the most densely populated areas in the world. India's density of population is 312 persons per sq. mile, but Kerala has 904 persons — the highest density in India. Neighbouring Madras State has 598 persons and Mysore State has 261 persons per sq. mile. During the last fifty years the population has doubled itself, the rate of growth of population was +22.8 per cent during the last decade. (Figures for India were 13.4 per cent for the same period.)

The Matriarchal (Marumakkattayam) System

One most important peculiarity is its matriarchal system.

* Statistical information in subsequent sections is drawn from the *Second Five Year Plan, Kerala* — Government of Kerala.

This system determines inheritance through the female line. The issues of a lady inherit the property of her brother and not of her husband. It is a joint family affair whereby the eldest male member of the family called *Karanavan* wields control over the domestic economy without any partition. Only in 1933, through the Marumakkattayam Act and the Namboodiri Act, legal provisions have been made for partition and adopt patriarchal pattern which is gradually replacing the old system due to the increasing sense of individual freedom.

Status of Women

Due to the matriarchal system women have been held supreme in the social and economic set-up. Numerically too they are larger in number than the males. For every 1000 males India as a whole has 947 females but Kerala has 1027 females. As such out of a population of 13,551,549, there are 6,868,668 (50.7%) females and 6,682,861 (49.3%) males. In all the occupations except commerce and transport, women outnumber men.

The Food Deficit

Coming from mothers to motherland, Kerala is unfortunately one of the most chronically deficit States in food in India. Against a total annual requirement of 20 lakh tons, the region has an average annual rice output of only 10 lakh tons.

A Dollar-mine

But paradoxically enough Kerala is a *mine of dollars*. Almost 50 per cent of the cultivated area is under permanent cash crops, like coconut, arecanut, rubber, tea, coffee, cashewnut, cardamom, lemon grass and pepper, etc. which need little recurring labour and are all dollar earners making Kerala inseparable from a thriving foreign trade. The total value of agricultural exports during 1955-56 was nearly Rs. 47 crores. Obviously, Kerala is more a land of plantations than of crops. Apart from that, it is a mine of precious stones. In the southern parts, a little of digging at times yields precious stones fetching thousands of rupees to the middle-men, a crumb is thrown to the poor landholder by these trading bullies.

Coconut

One fifth of Kerala's total population depends entirely on the coconut tree including fibre for which Kerala enjoys the monopoly. One-third (*i.e.*, 50 crores of rupees) of the total national income of Kerala comes from coconut. 70 per cent of the total Indian production of coconut both in acreage and quantity is in Kerala.

Love for the Letters

Highest literacy is the pride of Kerala where 50 per cent males and 31.65 per cent females are literate. Literacy amongst females here is 3 times more than in Bombay or Madras State but 10 times that of Rajasthan. There are 28 lakh students (1/5th of the total population) on rolls in 12 thousand schools and colleges with 6,775 primary schools working on double shift. About 77,652 teachers in all (the second largest group after industrial labour numbering 121,747) working in the state, are now paid direct by the State government to dissuade the private managements (mostly of Christians, Nayar Service Societies and other private organizations) from paying less to the teachers and showing fictitious payments instead. The missionaries and the Maharajas of Travancore and Cochin have played a significant role in the sphere of education. In their princely states the literacy was as high as nearly 70 per cent.

The Caste

Kerala has the most complicated social fabric. Brahmins placed highest in the social spiral have been the most orthodox people in India. Surprisingly enough Shankaracharya — the renowned exponent of Advaita philosophy in India, who was himself a Namboodiri — was declared an outcaste by the forefathers of the present Namboodiris and Swami Vivekananda had to call this region 'a mad house of India'.

As such the caste has been and still continues to be a strong social factor. The Nairs who were the martial wing of the body politic represent the feudal interests in the State. There are nearly 420 castes in a descending order, starting from the Namboodiri Brahmins and ending at the Pulayas — the lowest caste. The privileges decreased in the downward scale till the lowest

man was a mere slave. The low castes were not allowed the use of the public streets. They were to stop 60 steps away from the higher castes. The low caste ladies were not allowed to wear anything above the waist while facing the castes higher to them. A change has come within this living generation in the countryside but the psychological effects are not yet lost.

It was only in 1843 that slavery was abolished in the State by the intervention of the British Government which had by that time enslaved almost the whole of India. The slaves were bought and sold for Rs. 6.00 to 18.00 during the good old days. After the abolition of slavery, the caste system tightened itself still more till it broke loose by the Christian conversions, education and Temple Entry Satyagraha by Gandhiji at Guruvayoor and Vaickam. The Temple Entry Act was passed by the princely states as late as 1936. Those notions will die with the surviving old generation but the younger one is coming up well for a social change.

Christianity

Out of every 100 Indian Christians 35 live in Kerala even though the Christian population in India is 2.30 per cent. 29 lakh Christians in this State constitute 22 per cent of its total population. More than 90 per cent Christians here are converts of the last two centuries mainly reclaimed from the scheduled castes and tribes and have been provided with facilities for good housing, schools and churches which in the past resulted in a considerable social and economic change in the state and is at present a political factor to reckon with. St. Thomas, the apostle who landed in India in the first century had almost failed where 16 centuries later the foreign priests patronized by the successive European ruling traders succeeded. 'Economic aid' for this civilizing mission has been pouring in like water in the state from foreign missions and Y.M.C.A.'s of America, and still continues pouring in. Since the scheduled castes and tribes still numbering 13.4 lakhs, constituting 10 per cent of the state population, are the real proletariat as well as the 'Catchment Area' for the Christian conversions, Kerala is also a testing ground of not only the 'Bible' on one hand and

'The Capital' of Karl Marx on the other but of the major political parties in India also.

Graveyard of Ministries

On the integration of Travancore Cochin on 1st July, 1949, the Congress held a total number of seats in the legislature but the general elections of 1952 sprang a surprise when no single party could claim absolute majority but Congress could form a ministry only through patch up work. Fresh elections followed in 1954 which in quick succession brought on stage short-lived P.S.P. and Congress ministries to be superseded by President's rule which implemented the S.R.C. Report to carve out Kerala as it is mapped at present. General elections in 1957 saw the rise of communists into power by a majority of 2 seats which is now in power. The party position during the last three elections held in 1952, 1954 and 1957 is shown as under :

	1952.	1954	1956
Congress	44	45	43
T. Tamilnad Congress	8	12	—
P.S.P.	12	19	9
Communists	25	28	65
Revolutionary Socialist Party	6	9	—
Kerala Socialist Party	1	3	—
Muslim League	—	—	8
Independents	12	1	1
Anglo-Indian (nominated)	1	1	1
	109*	118*	127*

* (Number of seats increased due to redemarcation of constituencies).

The way the ministries rose and fell during the last ten years is shown below :

Ministry headed by	Party	Strength in house	In	Out	Stay in power in months
(a) On Integration of T. Cochin States					
1. T. K. Narayan Pillai	Congress	Total	7/49	1950	8
2. C. Kesavan	„	„	1950	2/52	24
(b) After General Elections, 1952					
3. A. J. John	„	44 out	3/52	9/53	18
4. „ Caretaker Govt.	„	of 118	9/53	3/54	7
(c) After Fresh Ele- ctions in 3/54					
5. Pattom Thanu Pillai	PSP	(19 out of 118 through alliance with Congress).	3/54	2/55	11
6. P. Govind Menon	Congress	45 out of 118	3/55	3/56	12
7. President's rule	—	—	4/56	4/57	12
(d) After General Elections, 1957					
8. E. M. S. Namboodiripad	Communist	65 out of 127	4/57	to date	Over 27

* Dismissed by President on 31-7-1959 under Section 356 of the Constitution.

All these elections have registered a clear tendency towards communism which is due to a multitude of factors. Nairs and Christians have been traditionally hostile to each other. When Christians walked into Congress, Nairs more or less monopolised the P.S.P. Those fed up with the communal polarisa-

tion in the political parties sought refuge in the communist party which has a fair number of persons with quite a good upbringing and have comparatively more of agility in handling the situations than its cadres in other provinces. Apart from this, pressure of population, poverty, a high incidence of education, break-down of joint families under Tarawads and illams and lack of central controlling authority in the changed family structure have made people feel that Communists only are in a fit position to offer a stable government. Indoctrinated into strong party feelings through a series of elections, fresh and general, the people have become more political minded. 29 dailies in this smallest state representing all the communal and political sections of the state keep on pampering into the fury of politics. Platform also is kept warm by demagogues to pull up or pull down a party or politicians. Communal consciousness is mixed up with class or political consciousness. The situation on the whole is quite stimulating. The party in power is well saddled. Those thrown out of power are unduly grinding their teeth and have failed, it appears, to accept the verdict of the electorate sportively.

In the next chapter we will take up Kerala's economy.

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CHAPTER 4

Kerala's Economy

Now LET us walk along with the people and study their life through percentages. To begin with 1.2 per cent of India's land area, 3.8 per cent of India's population, 9.2 per cent of its literates, 35 per cent of its Christians, 2.7 per cent of its Hindus, 6.2 per cent of its Muslims, 3.3 per cent of India's national income are there within Kerala. Inside Kerala 62 per cent of the people are Hindus, 22 per cent Christians and 16 per cent Muslims locally known as Moplahs. Ten per cent of Kerala's population are scheduled castes and tribes. Here are found churches, mosques and temples jostling in the same locality commanding universal respect from all.

Occupational Structure

Rural Kerala with its straggling villages accommodates 86.9 per cent of the State's total population. Out of every 100 persons in the state, 53.6 live directly on agriculture and 46.4 live on non-agricultural occupations. Out of the State's total area of 15 thousand sq. miles, 7410 sq. miles are under agriculture, 3800 sq. miles are under forest and 3790 sq. miles are uncultivable. 33.3 per cent of the total population live in the villages on non-agricultural occupations. Allowing 20.3 per cent as teachers, carpenters, masons, barbers, washermen and village craftsmen, the rest *i.e.* 13 per cent are non-agricultural villagers forming superstructure over the inner core of agrarian enterprise since the advent of foreign trade on these coasts. This

speaks of the havoc wrought on agriculture and allied village industries by middlemen through private credit, marketing and purchase of dollar earning produce in the absence of any proper marketing, warehousing and credit facilities in the vast stretches of the country-side nominally divided in 4,615 villages (with an average population of 2,550 persons and 470 families) for administrative convenience, there being nothing like a village in Kerala.

Out of 53.6 per cent depending on agriculture, 1.5 per cent are rentiers, 19 per cent cultivate their own lands, 12 per cent cultivate unowned lands and 21.1 per cent of the total population are agricultural labourers who form 39.3 per cent of the agricultural population of Kerala.

Ploughshare pierces the soil in February-March for the first crop. Sowing is over by April. Weeding continues till June till the farmers and labourers wield the sickle in July-August. Similar operations start for the second crop in September and they end by February. The working day varies with the season and the operation. Ploughing, sowing and harvesting have a 4 hours day. Digging, bunding, and cultivating as also coconut harvesting have a 6 hours day. Weeding and transplanting have an 8 hours day. During the period of rains, i.e., 15th May to 15th August there are only 6 working days per month. From August 15th, to February 15th, there are 20 working days per month. The next months i.e., February 15 to May 15 are full working months.

Agriculture

The per capita extent of cultivated land is 30 cents. Due to a rapid increase in population it has shrunk from 53 cents in 1921 to the present limit. As such, the holdings are uneconomic. Out of a total of 26.70 lakh holdings, 14.84 lakhs (or nearly 55.6 per cent) are less than one acre in size, covering 8.1 per cent of the total area and are just attached to the house sites. 88 per cent holdings are less than 5 acres and cover only 33 per cent of the total area. Only 1.4 per cent holders own more than 31.8 per cent of the area with average holding above 25 crores. The land is mostly neglected. There is little investment on improvement of fertility of land or soil conservation—2.

vation. All over the state, the cultivated areas are mostly unterraced.

The per capita income from agriculture is Rs. 118.25. The figures for principal crops with their areas, average yield and total production etc. for the year 1955-56 run as per Table I.

Table I AGRICULTURAL PRODUCTION IN KERALA

Name of the crop	Area in 100 acres	Average yield in lbs. maunds & seers	Income per acre Rs. np,	Production in 1000 tons	Value in crores of Rs.
1. Paddy	1954	1557 19-0	212/00	1358	41.1
2. Coconut	1107	2800 nuts -	466/00	310*	49.4
3. Arecanut	144	45000 „ -	645/81	648*	9.9
4. Tapioca	558	6298 77-0	139/75	1569	7.8
5. Pepper	214	283 3-21	331/75	27	7.1
6. Plantains	116	6005 73-10	732/75	311	8.5
7. Cashewnut	93	1349 16-18	408/62	56	3.8
8. Ginger	69	32 0-16	434/81	1	3.0
9. Ginger	26	1120 13-32	1077/-	13	2.8
10. Sugarcane	18	40693 496-10	722/-	327	1.3
11. Groundnut	33	950 11-24	242/44	14	0.8
12. Pulses	111	343 4-7	36/-	17	0.4
13. Rubber	160	294 3-24	425/-	21	6.8
14. Tea	99	679 8-11	1434/31	30	14.2
15. Coffee	41	164 2-0	390/25	3	1.6
	4743				158.8
Minor crops	723				21.2
Total value of agricultural production.					180.0

* In crores of nuts.

[from Kerala II Plan p. 3]

The income per acre from rubber, tea and coffee is Rs. 753.00, from coconut Rs. 466.00 and from general agriculture it is Rs. 355.00. Highest acreage (1954 thousand acres) is under paddy. Next comes coconut (1107 thousand). Tapioca is third in acreage (558 thousand), but first in tonnage. Highest value is that of coconut *i.e.*, 49.4 crores forming

nearly one third of the total agricultural production. Paddy contributes 41.4 crores *i.e.*, one fourth. Tea stands third in value with 14.2 crores. Two thirds of world's production in cardamom and ginger, one half of world production in pepper, 93 per cent of Indian production in cashewnut, 66 per cent of Indian production in coconut and 60 per cent of Indian production in areca is from Kerala. Rubber production here forms 97 per cent of the total Indian production.

Rice

Grown chiefly on flat irrigated or swamp lands twice a year in April and September, rice forms the staple diet of the people. With rains sufficiently abundant for the first crop, the second crop sown in September is irrigated by water channels of perennial flow. At places the river waters lifted by power are let into channels for irrigation. First irrigation work dates back to 1942 when Burma rice was no more available due to Japanese occupation of Burma. The farmer is generally found content with a yield of 14 maunds per acre.

Tapioca

Introduced from South America during the last century, tapioca is one of the essential articles of food here. Save it from cattle and it will look after itself in any and every soil of Kerala. That is why one finds it on untterraced hills with a steep gradient even of 50° to 60°. Stem cut into pieces about 4 to 6 inches long is planted some 2 feet apart and grows about 6 to 8 feet high, matures within 9 to 10 months yielding per acre almost 3 to 10 tons of roots similar to Shakar Kandi (*Ipomoea Batata*). It is boiled and taken with rice or fish. Macaroni rice is also manufactured by mixing in it some more of food contents through an industrial plant. Devised as a substitute for rice, this rice called Macaroni has not gained popularity deserved by it in this food deficit area.

Fish

Kerala ranks second amongst the states in India in per capita consumption of fish. The fisherman's ballyhoo to call his customers by the riverside is too familiar to the village folk. The fish vendor with his palm leaf umbrella-hat is a loser in

his higgling with the children who always insist on 'extra's. But on the coastline, fishing is quite an important industry. Unfortunately, the fisher-folk are the most backward class socially and economically. They invariably work for middlemen who own nets and boats. For the major part of the year they are unemployed due to adverse weather conditions in the sea.

Dairy, Poultry and Live-stock

Fodder crops are conspicuous by their absence in Kerala. The cattle seem to be unwelcome guests to this state. The per capita milk consumption here is 2 ounces per day, the lowest in India which has 5.5 ounces daily per capita consumption. There are only 30 milch cattle per 1,000 persons. Poultry is popular not for consumption but for a large export of eggs even to foreign countries.

There is only one buffalo or bullock pair per 13.6 acres. Most of the operations are done by hand or hired bullock power. There are 167 head of cattle per 1,000 persons. Live-stock population including goats and sheep etc., is 42 per acre or 271 per sq. mile. There is thus little chance of sufficient availability of farm-yard manure.

The Kalpa Vriksha

Apart from its poetry the coconut tree is an emblem of utility and is verily called in Kerala the *Kalp-Vriksha* — the tree that fulfills every longing. Except clothing it meets almost all the needs of human life. Poor man's housing is entirely from coconut leaves, so is the thatching of middle class houses. The leaves torn in the middle are intertwined to form into sheets which, placed in double layer, resist wind and shower and are a poor man's asbestos. The shell of the nut is used for kitchen spoons or serves as blacksmith's fuel or domestic firewood.

The liquid content of the nut is the best beverage, the solid content called Copra holds food content and fat and serves as substitute for milk and butter in local use. But most of the dried copra and coconut oil is a commercial commodity and hence exported.

Coming to the husk, it is put to an excellent use through coir, the primary cottage industry in the state, peculiarly indigenous and unique in the coastal region due to the peculiar

natural conditions prevalent there for decomposing the pulp of the husk in the saline ponds and backwaters.

The fibrous husk or rind of the coconut being uneatable is readily stripped from the nut while yet green by striking it on the point of a stake or iron spike fastened upright on the ground. It is collected from all over the state at Rs. 15/- to 20/-* per thousand husks (Rs. 4.00 per maund) and transported and supplied to the coastal regions by middlemen at the rate of Rs. 20/- to 25/- per thousand (4.50 to 5.00 per maund). Here it is at once steeped in salt or brackish water. Secured in nets or bamboo stakes it lies for 9 to 10 months until the softer portion of the husk rots away and the fibre alone remains. This process costs Rs. 2.50 per 1,000 husks (50 nPs. per maund) and is carried along the Kerala coasts, polluting the air at times.

After it is taken out, it is beaten with a small thick stick to separate and clean the fibre. This operation known as retting costs about Rs. 9.00 per thousand or Rs. 35.00 per candy (20 maunds) or about Rs. 1.75 per maund. The fibre is then dispersed in cottages, to be spun into different varieties of yarn (average spinning charge is Rs. 1.50 per maund) or pressed like cotton for shipping into bales weighing 200 lbs. or so. Upto this stage the entire process is unmechanised and a cottage industry. But this yarn sold at about Rs. 9.00 to 10.00 per maund is converted into finished goods like mats, ropes and cables by the different factories set up in the state or abroad. There are 138 such coir factories employing nearly 14,310 workers within Kerala. Cables from coir bear exposure to salt water better than anything else. No insect will ever touch it. It has a favourable world market.

Coir, as such, is the primary cottage industry of the state. Three million *i.e.*, one fifth of Kerala's population are dependent upon the coconut tree including fibre. As such, coconut is the nerve fibre of Kerala's economy. It is not without reason that indiscriminate import of copra and coconut oil is resisted by its people (70 per cent of India's coconut is produced by Kerala). Fortunately, fibre making is not mechanised. Otherwise, it would shake the very foundations of Kerala's economy. But it is

unfortunate that the whole industry is entirely in the hands of middlemen, who have organized the entire operation in their own interest and little goes to the actual worker who constitutes the spine of the whole industry from beginning to end in the cottage stage.

The Urban and the Industrial Sector

The state is divided into nine following districts. Beginning from north to south, they are :

- | | |
|------------------------|---------------|
| 1. Cannanore | 6. Kottayam |
| 2. Palghat | 7. Alleppey |
| 3. Kozhikode (Calicut) | 8. Quilon |
| 4. Trichur | 9. Trivandrum |
| 5. Ernakulam | |

The population of each district is between 15 to 22 lakhs. Out of the total population of 135 lakhs almost 18 lakhs constitute the urban population forming 13.2 per cent of the whole. Only 3 cities, Trivandrum, Alleppey and Kozhikode (Calicut)

Table II INDUSTRIAL EMPLOYMENT

Type	No. of factories	No. of workers
Cotton textiles	195	18,123
Cashewnut	164	41,636
Coir	138	14,310
Tea	129	5,759
Bricks and Tiles	127	10,752
Saw mills	75	4,246
Rice	73	1,872
Oil	69	2,840
Rubber Estates and Factories	61	2,168
Others. (Food, non-food printing and automobile, etc. employing less than 2000 workers (each))	318	20,041
Total	1349	1,21,747



have a population above one lakh and hold one fourth of Kerala's urban population. The rest are spread over 85 towns. The state has a well-knit road system. Road mileage is 0.72 miles per square mile. Even though the state has 46.4 per cent non-agricultural population, only 0.8 per cent of the total population are employed in industry. There are 1,349 big and small factories in all, employing a total of 121,747 workers out of which 40 per cent are women. Average establishment per factory is 90 workers. Following are the most important industries with their number and workers employed shown against them.

Income Levels

Capital formation being low, the investment in the few large scale industries run in the state has been made by persons from outside. Income levels of the families in the state compared to India are as under :

Annual family income Rs.	• Percentage of families	
	Kerala	India
Below Rs. 600/-	51	20.4
600/- to 1200/-	34	31.2
1200/- to 1800/-	8	21.1
1800/- to 3000/-	4	} 27.3
Above Rs. 3000/-	3	

The table shows how poverty is proportional to the natural beauty of Kerala. How deceptive is natural beauty! Half the population earns below five annas per head. Only 15 per cent of the total population earn above 62 nPs. per head per day i.e., Rs. 100.00 per month per family.

Regional and Per Capita Income

Kerala's per capita income is Rs. 217.9 against India's Rs. 252.00. If we exclude Rs. 7.3 out of India's per capita income which comes from Railways and Communications, a central head, it comes down to Rs. 244.7. Compared item to item, Kerala has Rs. 11.5 more income per capita out of agriculture. But in small enterprises, mining and industries it has Rs. 35.00

less than India's income per capita. Following is the break up of Kerala's national income and income per capita compared with India's income per capita for 1955-56 at current prices.

Table III KERALA'S INCOME AND ITS PER CAPITA INCOME COMPARED TO INDIA FOR 1955-56 AT CURRENT PRICES

Origin	Kerala's national income	Per capita income		
	Rs. crores	Kerala	India	Difference
1. Agriculture, Animal Husbandry and ancillary activities	173.1	118.6	107.1	+ 11.5
2. Commerce and Transport	57.5	39.4	38.9	+ .5
3. House property	18.0	12.3	11.8	+ .5
4. Fishery	2.3	1.6	1.3	+ .3
5. Organized Banking and Insurance	3.1	2.1	2.0	+ .1
6. Professions, arts and domestic services	26.7	18.3	18.3	nil
7. Forestry	2.5	1.7	1.8	- .1
8. Small enterprises	11.2	7.7	25.1	- 17.4
9. Factory Establishments	8.9	6.1	21.2	- 15.1
10. Government Service	14.6	10.0	14.6	- 4.6
11. Mining	0.2	0.1	2.6	- 2.5
12. Communications and Railways	—	—	7.3	- 7.3
Total	318.1	217.9	252.0	- 34.1

A brief study of Kerala's rural setting and sociology may also not be out of place. We proceed to deal with it in the following chapter.

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CHAPTER 5

The Rural Setting and Sociology

LET us walk down the road to study some socio-economic features of a Kerala village.

The village historian will narrate that the whole strip of land known as Kerala was claimed from the sea by Parsu Ram to settle his Brahmanical colony against the Kshatriyas. Dispersal was thought over as a strategy by Nairs, the martial genius of this typical undulated terrain with its temperate climate. The village historian will continue that the territorial divisions followed the caste groups: Namboodris in Gramams and Nairs in Taras.

Tarawad — consisting of descendants from a common ancestress—was the organization of the Nairs. When it grew unwieldy, it was divided in Tarazhis (mother's line). The eldest male member (Karanavan) managed the property and all members were entitled to maintenance. Matrilineal descent and inheritance, the exogamous rule and impartiality of the property were three structural principles involved in Tarawad lineage system run on joint family lines even though the members spread out in a number of villages and houses.

Illam or grammam of the Namboodiris — the counterpart of Tarawad — was on patriarchal lines. With eldest son only to perpetuate the family the number remained constant. The younger sons had sambhandams or liaison with the ladies of high castes of Kshatriyas or Nairs and their progeny did not constitute the membership of the Illam.

The military-cum-farming units at the base called Tara was a settlement of nearly 400 families of a cross section of inter-dependent groups (castes) united by bonds of Dharma and mutual kinship. It served the interests of all the hereditary occupationalists, artisans and unskilled labourers by coordinating the activities of all for the smooth functioning of the community life. Mutual co-operation was the watchword of the village life.

Territorially, the divisions in the ascending scale standing as Tara, Desham, Nad and the kingdom were headed by the headman, kuttam, Nadavazhi and the Raja respectively.

The Raja had no claims for revenue. Life moved around the temple since deity was considered to be the lord of the lands. Practically, land was a private property of persons called Janmis who were from higher castes upto Nairs. To that extent it may be said that system of land holding reflected the hierarchy of the caste system. Nairs constituted considerable bulk of population and formed the militia of the country. Later on, when military occupation was thrown into background they took to agriculture. Subcastes among Nairs were non-cultivating tenants. Izhavas (Thiyas) were tenants. Then came the artisans and those down were serfs on the lands of the upper strata. Co-operative life was in evidence in all agricultural operations, on the occasion of marriages and death, thatching of roofs and temple festivals.

Christians who grew mostly in the south and Moplahs (Muslims) in the north remained outside the pale of caste system and generally took to non-agricultural vocations. Temples also had lot of landed property called Devaswams attached to them. It is an institution of great antiquity recovering gifts from its devotees.

The invasions of Haidar and Tippu between 1773 to 1790 changed the mode of administration and pattern of the land management since during that period only, the collection of land revenue was enforced. Under this regime of revenue assessment, land ceased to be a private property and came directly under the control of the State.

But virtual changes came under the British who succeeded the Tippu regime. They ignored the Tara organization, adopted

a geographical unit named *ansom* as the administrative unit, deprived the Nadavazhis of their administrative and military power and raised a number of talukas headed by Tehsildars. Talukas lay further subdivided into *Pravrittis* or *deshams*. *Adhikaris* and *Parvatikars* at the village level were made responsible for collection of revenue, law and order.

The territorial lords (*Janmis*) had occupancy tenants, tenants at will, tenants on lease for gardens or tenants for house sites. This feudal order and pattern of subservience remained almost undisturbed till tenancy legislation of 1930 assured a certain security to all types of tenancy through fixity of tenure etc.

Fragmentation of landed property started only on disintegration of joint families which followed only after the passing of *Marumakkattayam Act* and the *Namboodiris Act* in 1933. Due advantage has been taken of these legislations by a majority of these communities and gradually the individual members are leaving their joint families to set up their individual homes. Before that the claim to the division of the joint family property was unheard of. All the land was collectively managed by the *Karanavan* — the eldest male member of the family of the ancestress.

While the division of property proceeded under the said Acts by some sections of the Society, the pressure on land decreased for one decade to rise again (the percentage of population depending on agriculture in Travancore-Cochin was 45, 48, 52 in 1931, 1941, 1951 respectively).^{*} The shift in favour of commercial crops also increased at that stage.

Among Hindus, caste is most inextricably connected with the occupations. Although most of the skills are hereditary, due to the increase of education, technical know how and adaptability demanded by urbanization, the shifts are also visible from one occupation to another. *Izhavas* — said to be immigrants from Ceylon in olden days and constituting a considerable bulk of Hindu population — formerly considered as low caste engaged in toddy tapping, have taken to land cultivation and are either tenants or landowners now. As such they hold

^{*}Social change in Malabar by M. S. A. Rao.

a much better economic position in northern (almost at par with Nairs) and Southern Kerala but are a little down in the central parts.

The natives of the country were the passive participants in the whole game of sea-borne trade. Since Arabians were the first to enter into the picture and settle down on these shores, Muslims form the major trading community in the rural sector. Christians are said to have pioneered banking and commerce, etc. The moneylending in the village is a by-profession of the wealthy landlords and traders who charge interest ranging from 20 to 60 per cent in cash or kind against the security of crop, ornaments, etc. and follow illegal methods.

The Menons, a sub-caste of Nairs is professionally bound up with clerical and accounting jobs and has been almost monopolizing the land revenue service in the State at the village level since its incorporation in the State for the last two centuries.

Amongst Hindus, Brahmin priests have, during the last two decades, lost their hold on people in maintaining the norms of the caste rules but they still play a prominent role in ceremonies and festivals which are too many in these parts, relating to every phase of agriculture as well as human life.

Physicians and teachers command universal respect from all the communities and professions.

The Hindu is conscious of his being in majority and feels it as his strength. The other two communities are a bit obsessed by their being in minority and are over-conscious of their religion.

The matriarchal pattern cannot be said to have considerably changed over to the patriarchal. The changes that have come are neither uniform nor wholesale. They are rapid in Travancore and slow in Malabar; Cochin occupies the middle position.

Newspapers, radios and general and fresh elections* have come to hold a dominating influence on the life of the people who are designated more and more by the party affiliations than the caste or community to which they belong. Adverse land,—man-ratio, low productivity, high pressure on land, high birth rate, lack of subsidiary crafts and organized trade have made the

* To be held for the fourth time during 8 years from 1952-1960.

villages a den of poverty. Good independent housing or toddy lulls the inhabitants into complacency.

However, Kerala, inspite of the impact of national and international forces on it since ages, still remains a separate culture area because of its peculiar village-setting, temperate climate, matriarchal domestic economy, separate language (although richly sanskritized) distinct dresses, dances, festivals and folk-lore. Apart from that, whatever internal self-subsistence there may have been in the village (Ansom, Desham or Tara) two or three centuries earlier, it is difficult at present in Kerala to point to a unit as a clearly demarcated coherent independent village community. If there is one it does not coincide with any administrative unit under the revenue or Panchayat set up. With the disintegration of Tarawads the social cohesion has given way and petty rivalries dominate. Various committees and bodies raised at the village level do not prove much effective to integrate the village life. Old feudal heads and ex-adhikaris have failed to provide leadership at the village level. Brahmins left in the village live an isolated life as landlords or idling priests.

Agriculture is the main unifying factor. Inspite of much of diversity, the interdependence of landlords, tenants, labourers, village artisans, shopkeepers, traders, teachers and physicians etc. silently perpetuates the basic unity of life.

It is for such a village setting that Vinoba presented Gramdam as a possible way for its social cohesion and solution of its intricate problems. On his entry into the state he had already bagged exactly 2500 Gramdams from different parts of India during his peninsular tour. The concept of Gramdan, however, underwent a change due to a peculiar geographical, sociological and administrative set-up in rural Kerala. In the following pages will be presented the growth of Gramdams which started only with the entry of Vinoba into the State on 18th April, 1957.

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PART 2

The Storm and Thereafter

CHAPTER 6

Thus Spoke Vinoba

VINOBA SHOT up on 18th April, 1951 as a founder of Bhoodan movement when he walked undefended into the disturbed areas of Telangana where Communist snipers had been looting lorries, shooting landlords and hooting the armed might of the Government of India. Exactly six years later, on 18th April, 1957 he was gratified to meet Shri E. M. S. Namboodiripad, who as head of the Communist Ministry, which had marched into power only a fortnight earlier, was there on 18th April, 1957 to receive him on Kerala's southernmost border and 'assure him of the party's and peoples' fuller co-operation in the solution of the land problem' and expressed 'the desire to seek his advice and have repeated consultations with him before pushing in any legislation about land reforms.'

Vinoba, sticking to his six year old spartan routine, moved into this spice garden, met its loving, intelligent, progressive yet simple citizenry from the chief minister to the commoner and tried to understand their problems. He finally came out with this manifesto for Gramdan before an assembly of Sarvodaya workers of Kerala on 11th May, 1957. The abridged translation of his speech recorded in Hindi in cyclostyled hand-out under Prarthana Pravachan No. 157 dated 11th May, 1957 follows hereunder :—

"Not only my visitors these days refer to the complicated economy of Kerala but quite before my arrival in this state I have been told about the non-existence in Kerala of the

S-3.

entity known as a village so also about Kerala's low per capita of land, its high density of population, its uneconomic holdings and a hard living in spite of the subsidiary occupation. Shri Pattom Thanu Pillai, ex-chief Minister, P.S.P., revealed during his talks with me that while in power they had tried to acquire some land for the poor but without disturbing the pattern of land ownership. They had, however, a mind to enforce a ceiling of 15 acres of wet land. The only alternative with the politicians is to impose ceiling. But people know how to defeat such a legislation. During the early days of Bhoodan movement, we, in Hyderabad, found people effecting bogus transfers and partitions as a safeguard against the proposed law of ceiling. So far the law of ceiling has been framed only in Hyderabad (Andhra) and Bengal. Elsewhere it is still in the making. But people have already effected the necessary safeguards against it.

The Communists, pronounced for their sympathies for the poor had declared in their election manifesto in Andhra a ceiling at 20 acres of wet land in the deltas of Godavari and Krishna which is far from being a progressive step. The law of such ceiling will enter the Statute Book while actually the status quo will persist. Over a discussion on this issue the Communists of Andhra had to accept that they could not displease the middle class although such ceiling was not within their principles.

The people in Delhi who draft this 5 year plan don't know anything about the conditions obtaining in these areas. Since they have higher standards of living they propound the theories of maximum holding and ceiling. Some propose that it should be at three times the basic holding, some fly straight to the maximum holding. But it is all a faulty rationale intending that a person could hold quite a large area and deprive many others of the right on land. Why on earth should a man be entitled to own 3 times the family holding and deprive the other two recipients? Such rationale of ceiling is totally wrong and ill-conceived.

We cannot be content with anything short of total elimination of private ownership. On that ground the question hardly arises of small or big holding, good or bad quality of land.

America has 12 acres of land per capita. As such we

cannot be as prosperous as America. Even India as a whole has more land per capita than Kerala. Since the land cannot be stretched, we have to work under the limitation of low availability of land. Thus the only question worth consideration is whether feeding the nation with the available land will be easier through community ownership or individual ownership. We are convinced that the production will increase by liquidating the individual ownership and not by preserving it. If anybody could convince us that the suffering can be reduced by maintaining the private ownership we will certainly withdraw our insistence on community ownership, but community ownership becomes the inevitable conclusion when we think of the good of all.

The production being low in India some people object to our idea of equitable distribution. Shri Harekrushna Mahtab, ex-Governor of Bombay commented that through Bhoodan I am distributing poverty. Shri Mahtab feels that equitable distribution is not yet necessary and that there will be more production if ownership rests with efficient farmers who will be competent to pay the labourers more and thus make them happy. The land ownership, he feels should not be thrust on the labourer but it should rest with the owner who shall be the trustee of land.

I say the trustee should treat his wards much better than himself and he shall be eager as such to pass the rights on to his wards as early as possible, which implies that ultimately the land is to change hands and mere increase in wages will not help for long since we have to behave in society as we behave in the family.

It is wrong to think of increase in the production first and distribution of land later. The sound rationale implies that increase in production goes hand in hand with equitable land distribution. This is what Sarvodaya means.

As such I find no difficulty in resolving the complications of Kerala economy. If you say the land is less why own it at all? Do away with individual ownership to plan the economy afresh for increase in production.

It is apparent that due to low availability of land, the increase in production may also not lead to the required prosper-

city. The industries will also be geared up and even migration to other provinces will have to be considered. But liquidation of private land ownership is the foregone conclusion. It is along these lines that you have to think.

All the three parties *i.e.*, the Congress, P.S.P., and the Communists worship the same deity; they all talk in terms of the service of the poor. To persuade them to fulfil this objective, we must raise our voice against private property and collect hundreds of Gramdans.

Don't say there are no villages in our province. There is some compact area within which the population is considered to constitute a village. It is enough to have it declared as Gramdan. Have hundreds of Gramdans. The follow-up will be looked into by the law which is never coercive if it has the backing of the people. All the political parties should be made to unite and work for it. People from every village and house-top should say, 'Down with private property'.

Our ancient culture supports our conviction since it accepts everybody's right on land including that of animals. The Government of this state is also in your favour and I am also here in your province. Moreover, everybody likes the idea of Gramdan. So go ahead with your plans of action and accomplish this task of welding socialism and communism to merge them into the ocean of Sarvodaya. This is the task for you."

CHAPTER 7

The Walking University

VINOBA DASHED straight across five southern districts of Trivandrum, Quilon, Kottayam, Alleppey and Ernakulam within three weeks to reach on 8th May at Kaladi — the venue for the annual Sarvodaya session for 1957. The rain-god twanged his bow in vain. Undeterred, Vinoba resumed his intensive trekking in the state and was for 30 days in the interior of Palghat district, 45 days in that of Kozhikode (Calicut) district all amidst the heaviest lash of rains. For the last fortnight he was in Cannanore district along the coast till his tall silhouette faded into the Mysore State on August 23, 1957 when the rain-god was also mild. All through the period he threw lavishly the seeds of his thoughts.

Relieved of the heavy strain of responsibilities after the termination of the Kaladi session which had fired them with new zeal, the workers spread into the different parts of the state concentrating mostly around Kaladi and Kozhikode district. By the time Vinoba — the founder of the Gramdan Movement — left Kerala, he is said to have bagged 301 Gramdans numerically.

After 11 months in Tamilnad, his walking university had the session of 127 days in all in this province. The Acharya trekked 900 miles, addressed 150 gatherings (including 14 talks at Kaladi session during the 6 days halt there). Except his city audiences at Trivandrum, Quilon, Kottayam, Ernakulam, Alwaye, Trichur, Palghat, Kozhikode, Tellicherry and Canna-

nore, the rest were rural audience. He also addressed separately the Christian Priests, Sarvodaya workers, Khadi and Harijan workers, Basic teachers, Pressmen and an all party meeting. Chief Minister E. M. S. Namboodiripad met him thrice or four times during his tour. The prayer meetings were very well attended in spite of the fury of the winds, lightning and rains that set in after 11th May. The audience was very well behaved and was not at all dull, it put him a number of questions and got clarification of his views on topics ranging from Communism to prayer and his personal austerities. In between, he fell ill in the first week of July and did not address public meetings for that week. He had four attacks of cough which disabled him from speaking at length at places. Once he had to make use of the conveyance during his illness. No odds stood in his way to continue his austere routine through the hills, dales, jungles and coasts of Kerala.

The verbatim reports of his speeches have been recorded in the cyclostyled hand-outs named Prarthana Pravachans (Prayer-speeches) running almost serially from No. 136 to 285. Due to repetition the study is boring but here and there one finds quite effective passages elucidating his stand on social, economic, cultural and political issues. Many of the valuable parts of his speeches have not found their way to the daily papers. He, at times, slashes at the Congress, its conservatism, its national planning and land policy. One finds him managed by 10 to 12 permanent members of his entourage who are not so skilled in dealing with the people and specially the pressmen. On the whole, he is sympathetic towards the Communist regime in Kerala although he is disappointed about their levels of ceiling. His stay in the province delayed the flare of publicity of insecurity in Kerala by almost a year. He was supported both by the Christians and the Communists in his Gramdan campaign. People read both 'Bible' and the 'Kapital' in him

The Greatest Aristocracy

Enemy No. 1 of the status quo and violence in any manner, the greatest defender of democracy at the village level, full of constructive compassion for the poor and the oppressed he politely but firmly hits in his speeches at those who feast while



others starve, who want to rule and not to serve, who talk of ceiling and not of abolition of private ownership, who give dole to Khadi rather than own it. 'Power' he feels, "cannot cure the ills of society or Buddha would not have left the kingdom for a saintly career. Not kings or politicians but thinkers constitute the greatest aristocracy on earth. Books instead of the Statute Book, rule the world"! With such words he weans the youth away from the lure of power.

Community Development

Slashing at the Community Development work, he feels, "Without Gramdan, road construction by the C.D. people is a means to facilitate the draining of village wealth by the cities." "Villagers by co-operation in such road constructions dig their own graves and Panchayats without Gramdan are the decentralized exploitation plans" in his view. Land he declares, is the basic necessity for every villager, nay every Indian. To experience freedom in its true sense, people must raise small units of socialist democracy at the village level through Gramdan which creates the true community spirit — badly missing in the C.D. work.

Second Plan

He feels that in second plan 80 per cent of the outlay is meant for the section constituting only 20 to 25 per cent of the country's population. The investment through five years of the plan period is 5 pice per day per man which is nothing as compared to the potential might of India's man power which if invested could work miracles.

Correctives

He wants more homogeneity in the society through the bonds of love which should replace the cordon of law. He tries to correct custom by reason and break the rigidity of law through reference to nature and the family. And he declares accumulation as much a sin or crime as stealing.

To avoid adverse effects he wants the development of science to be preceded by the development of human personality, wants nationalism to be replaced by humanitarianism and global considerations, by which Japan should be allowed access

to the arid lands inside Australia and the people of Kerala to spread out into the thinly populated tracts of India.

Very often in his speeches the Defence head is under charge. At a stage, Gramdan is suggested as a part of defensive planning even if it involves a little of coercion by the state.

With little respect for the entity of the state, with great regard for the individual and community life, he champions the cause of public initiative in building up democracy at the base. With inhibitions about Nehru he does not hit directly at Nehru or the constitution, but every word of his strikes like an axe at the roots of the institution of private property. "People ask, 'can private ownership be abolished?' I say yes! Since I have personally demolished the tabernacle of ownership, I am confident I will shape such India where individual ownership is non-existent," says the saint.

Khadi

In his speech at Parli he is bitter about the Khadi policy of the Government and observes, "After freedom officials waited for orders to wear khadi. They were ready but the orders never came. It was felt against the spirit of independence. What a ridiculous concept of independence? Mill is strengthening itself while Khadi is staggering. Steel parts (for Ambar) come from Ahmedabad, spinning is carried out here, yarn goes to Tripur in Madras state for weaving, cloth woven goes to Bombay and other cities for sale, all in the footsteps of the mills."

He chastely pours out that Khadi who fathered the present rulers is now an orphan maintained on dole. He observes, "You can take to mechanisation but will have to assure employment to those thrown out of work. The production may increase but the purchasing power will be lost. Stating further, he says, "Mill cloth is cheap because it has thrown thousands of weavers and spinners out of employment. Ask the mill-owner to look after them all, then you will see that Khadi is cheaper. Khadi, as such, is dear because it bears the burden of employment to millions. Buying Khadi is a social gesture while purchase of textile goods is an anti-social one, since it leads to unemployment. Not sparing the Brahmins he says "Don't feed the Brahmins but look to the poor. Should the people be prepared

to buy Khadi, I will bear the curse of the Brahmins gladly." The craftsman, he contends, will have the freedom from obligation if you buy his goods but he will be oppressed psychologically if you make him rely on charity. The villagers, he predicts, will be liquidating their economy and it will be suicidal for them if they don't produce their own cloth.

Addressing an all-party meeting on 11th July, 1957 at Calicut, this august personality behaved with utmost humility and made a moving appeal to his picked audience of hardened gentlemen to show their spirit of renunciation. His weighty words, dipped in pathos, follow : "The history of Kerala will record that Vinoba moved (on foot) in this province with a group of his comrades under the heaviest rains. He begs for your help. There is a story in Mahabharat. Abhimanyu entered the Chakra Vyuh, so has your comrade (Vinoba). He begs his comrades to help him otherwise he knows he has his date with the destiny. If you wish, do help him and relieve him of this work, otherwise, come what may, he and his few comrades will see to what destiny holds for them."

There was something in between the lines for the power-polluted politicians to understand the latest and the subtlest Satyagraha technique of the first individual Satyagrahi of October 11, 1940.

The Press

In the same meeting he indicts India's drowsy press. "Compared to the voluntary abolition of private property in these 2500 villages, had 25 villages overthrown the private ownership through violence it would have been flashed in the press all the world over. But the main crime of these 2500 villages is that they have eliminated the private ownership through peaceful means. That is why they do not constitute the news."

Christianity and Communism

"Private property is sacred but all the more sacred is its renunciation" he told the representatives of Christian Churches in Kerala. "The religions have tried to convert the individual whereas the others have not found it advisable to leave the

human society at the mercy of the individual. On one side is Christianity, on the other side is Communism."

"Had 'love thy neighbour' been practised, there would have been no growth of Communism. But the thought remained confined to the whims of the individuals; as such, the religions were unconsciously defending the status quo whereas the Communists say they were consciously doing it. Thus rose the ideology which reduced the individuals to nothings in preference to society."

"But we want both, the transformation of the society and constant ennobling of human personality; since if the quality of the individual does not improve, even the best social order will crumble," observed the saint. "As such, we stand for synthesis. Our performance is of very critical nature but we have consciously chosen this role with readiness to have blows from both the camps but fortunately we have the blessings of both the Christian Bishops and the Communists who stand poles apart." (Prarthana Pravachan No. 139).

Referring to the vast areas under temple lands (Devaswams) in Kerala he felt it was dangerous "to arrange permanent financial support to religious institutions. By this practice spirit loses its grandeur and money instals itself in its place."

"Communism in India," he said, "is going to adjust itself within the limits of the constitution. As such, it is undergoing change and can at a stage be assimilated into Indian culture." (Prarthana Pravachan No. 259).

Sarvodaya Fold

Coming to the Sarvodaya workers, he deplored the lack of mutual love, spiritual insight and search for new ideas amongst them. Critical of this hollowness he told them, "softies won't be able to propagate the ideology, the ball being hollow from within is thrown away by the earth but the pick — axe being solid is let in by it. Quite so, the workers hollow from within will be thrown away by the public."

He regretted the lack of self-confidence amongst them and found most of them lost "in the crowd as slaves of environment with no strength of will to change the course of events." "The

world," he said, "will count how many Gramdams were received but I will be anxious to count how many workers I could get. If at the end of Kerala tour I could get 30 to 40 workers I will feel I have conquered Kerala." (Prarthana Pravachana No. 205, dated of 8-6-1957).

As founder of the walking University he gave his convocation addresses to the workers as follows: "Every village is a University, every house is a class, every rural occupation is a part of the curriculum, and improvement of tools and techniques is the research." (Pravachana Prarthana No. 203, dated 10-6-1957).

"Our body is the greatest capitalist, it always leans for comfort and security. The danger is from within, not without. It matters little whether good people are in power or bad, none is going to help or hinder our work. If this much clarity and confidence is there in our minds only then can our service gain strength or it becomes a hand-maid of those in power." (Prarthana Pravachana, No. 163, dated 10-5-1957).

Expressing his indifference towards constitutional changes or pressure on the Government or the Congress, he explained his stand thus:—"One, who is constantly active, imbued with determination and purpose, who is of clear intellect and uncompromising nature has tremendous power in his indifference."

Talking more closely to the workers he narrated how he had inspired the workers in Tamilnad. Here are his own words: "At last I started padyatra twice in a day and lo! The workers were roused from slumber. They felt this man (Vinoba) has worked like us in the constructive field for 30 years and has come after leaving all that. He can't be a mere preacher, since preachers don't waste their youth like this in constructive activities and in old age don't start on foot as preachers. They understood me and my purpose. I poured out my heart to the workers and it clicked and clicked well. Nearly 200 Gramdams came in." Prarthana Pravachana No. 150, dated 7-5-1957).

Gramdan Concept

At Mayannur on 21st May, 1957, he defined his Gramdan for Kerala thus: "Without going into the legal scope and sense of the term 'village', wherever 5 to 25 families stay together,

that can be taken as a village. All families living in a compact area can distribute their lands.

'Gramdan', he says 'is the most modern thought in Economics'. It forges unity in the village, gives fresh life to and provides a sound basis for, all the constructive activities; strengthens the rural conscience', and 'allows the freedom to experiment on co-operation in different lines.' 'Social integration' through it 'leads to strength in 'the community' and development takes long firm strides since the village brains command the import and export, sale and purchase in the village'.

"Bhoodan," he says, "entails a responsibility of distribution; but in Gramdan the community does everything. Due to collective thinking, social instead of individual interests dominate in Gramdan where marriages will not be a parental responsibility but that of the society. The production will be planned and grain sufficient enough to last for two years will be kept in stock. Now owners want money, the labourers want grain. The owner goes to sell the grain in the town and the labourer goes to buy the same from there. Moreover, cash crops are more popular than food crops. But in Gramdan "All for each and each for all" takes shape and there is a collective responsibility on each and all." "Bhoodan," he observes "was an incomplete idea but Gramdan is an integrated concept of rural development. It makes people stand and walk on their own legs without waiting for orders from Delhi." "Many plans," he says, "move from Delhi for poor deserving people but they are dried up on the way to the advantage of big bosses only."

To sum up, he wanted Gandhi Smarak Nidhi, Kasturba Trust, Nai Talim, Khadi, Cottage Industries, N.E.S. and C.D. People to co-ordinate their activities for their survival. He was quite satisfied that Rs. 20 lakhs so far spent on Bhoodan out of Gandhi Nidhi were well rewarded in that it propagated the ideology, yielded 40 lakhs acres of land and 2,500 Gramdans in India. During his 4 months' tour here, the daily average sale proceeds of literature were Rs. 121.1. Total sale amounted to Rs. 15381.00. In all he had 1571 acres of Bhoodan from 224 donors (12.37 acres daily average from 1.76 donors).

He lavishly threw the seeds of Gramdan thoughts amidst the heaviest showers of rain. 301 saplings grew, most of them on paper, some on soil.

CHAPTER 8

The Numerical Targets

A FEW words about Bhoodan will be necessary before presenting the Gramdan phase of the movement in Kerala. Bhoodan here dates back to the Padyatra of Shri Shankar Rao Dev in 1952 followed later by Shri J. P. Narayan in 1954 wherein 29,021 acres of land had been received by the end of 1958 and only 2,126 acres had been distributed till then. The distribution is said to be at a standstill for the last 2 to 3 years.

There are two big pockets of Bhoodan lands in Nilambur (Kozhikode district) and Paryaram (Cannanore district) each with an area of 1,000 acres. The settlement on these lands has been taken up by Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal and Sarva Seva Sangh on Sarvodaya lines. But the growth of Gramdans in Kerala synchronized with the entry of the founder of the movement in the state. One Gramdan Thachancode with 72 families said to have been received at the inauguration of an All India Padyatra at Cape Comorin on February 2, 1956 is not shown in the cyclostyled list provided by the publication section of the Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal Calicut (locally designated as Sarvodaya Prasiddhikaran Samiti, Kozhikode). The said list contains 543 Gramdans with an average unit of 20 families each. This number is borne out by the weekly Bhoodan Journals published in Hindi or English from Banaras. All these Gramdans are located mainly in 5 pockets viz.,—

1. Malayadi (Trivandrum district).
2. Kaladi (Ernakulam district).

3. Krumbranad (Kozhikode district).
4. Wynad (Kozhikode district) and
5. Palghat (*see map*).

It was mainly after the Kaladi session that the figures started mounting. Some 29 of them during Vinoba's tour sprang up first in the Malayadi area just 20 miles to the north-east of Trivandrum where a Sarvodaya Ashram named Vinoba Niketan is working since 1954. But during the last 18 months, only 6 have so far been added there.

Later, there was a boom both in Kaladi with 93 Gramdans and in Krumbranad with 67 Gramdans during Vinoba's stay. A fair sprinkling with 36 Gramdans was also there in Wynad taluka in Western ghats area of Kozhikode district.

After Vinoba's departure, work in Kaladi became slack. The emphasis shifted to Krumbranad pocket *i.e.*, Quilandy taluk of Kozhikode district which on Vinoba's suggestion was selected to form an intensive experimental area (See Part III) for Gramdan development work. This area happens to be the native place of Shri Kelappan, nominated as the Chairman of Sarvodaya Mandal formed by Vinobaji to look to the organization of Gramdan development work. As a result, Shri Kelappan started on 3rd October 1957 his padyatra in Krumbranad along with the full force of the second line Sarvodaya cadre.

From Gandhi Smarak Nidhi came Shri R. K. Menon with his basic school staff and students, Shri D. Ramachandran Potty with his sharp oratory, Shri Gopinath Nair with his cultural squad and from Sarvodaya Mandal Shri Shrikanth Poduwal with his poetry, Kumari A. K. Rajamma with her devotional and emotional appeal stormed the area for a couple of months.

Regarding the pace of numerical achievements, within first 83 days Vinoba got 71 Gramdans at the rate of .83 Gramdans per day. Later, during the remaining 44 days of his trek he begged nearly 230 more at the rate of 5.2 Gramdans per day. From Vinoba's departure to close of 1957 the average daily roll was 1.2 Gramdans. The totals stood at 450 Gramdans.

From January 1958 to April 1958 the average was .43 per day and from April to the end of 1958 the daily average was .17 Gramdans per day. At present there is little enthusiasm for Gramdans; as such the figures stand at 543.

A signatory for Gramdan was not required to mention the details of his plot or plots of land as in Danpatras of Bhoodan but simply asked to sign a pledge for Gramdan along with 20 other neighbours. As such, 12,084 signatories stand for the Gramdan concept submitted on paper in 543 separate sheets. The workers in Kozhikode and Ernakulam districts for all practical purposes seem to have collected signatures from 20 neighbours in a continuous area which was accepted at the office level as one Gramdan. For another 20 families in the same contiguous area a separate gramdan was declared since Vinoba is said to have announced 20 families as the minimum number for a Gramdan. As such, the figures are somewhat deceptive.

In the field, all these 543 Gramdans are almost 363 compact Gramdans located in 310 different rural denominations (Ansoms, Deshams, or Karas). For instance, there are 9 Gramdans shown on record at Naduvattam in Alwaye Taluka in Kaladi pocket and accordingly included in the aggregate published in Bhoodan Journals from time to time. But at the spot there is one compact unit of 179 families worked out as one Gramdan by the worker appointed there. Same about the neighbouring villages of Manjappa and Neeleshwaram. In Krumbranad pocket, Pallikara shown in 14 Gramdans with 280 families, Karumalla in 5 Gramdans with 123 families, Nirmallur in 8 Gramdans with 171 families, Meladi in 13 Gramdans with 283 families, Pantalayani in 10 Gramdans with 205 families, Melur with 15 Gramdans and 300 families, Vayoor with 9 Gramdans and 194 families and Mundakara with 8 Gramdans and 197 families are the examples of such exaggerated presentation of figures.

Taking the declared number of 543 units into account there are on an average 22.2 families per unit of Gramdan. Practically in 363 compact actual Gramdans there is an average of 33.3 families per such compact Gramdan, but there are 39 Gramdan families per rural denomination embracing these Gramdan units.

A revenue village in Kerala is of course the most confusing thing. The population at time goes to 18,000 persons but is in no case less than 2,500 scattered in hundreds of houses and

tens of hamlets and Karas. The Ansham, and Desham, and Kara have no proper definition. Table No. 1 shows more or less the actual position districtwise.

Table I DISTRICT-WISE ANALYSIS OF GRAMDANS

No.	District	Taluka-wise break-up	Declared Gram-dans District wise	Actual contiguous units	Rural denomi-nations	Shown in excess	Joining families
1	Trivandrum	Nedumangad	34				
		Neyyatinkara	1	35	35	32	—
2	Quilon	—	—	—	—	—	—
3	Kottayam	—	—	—	—	—	—
4	Alleppey	Mavilikkara	1	1	1	1	—
5	Ernakulam	Alwaye	77				
		Kunnathunad	46	123	68	54	55
6	Trichur	Trichur	1				
		Thalappilli	15				
		Mukundapuram	1	17	17	15	—
7	Palghat	Alatur	16				
		Palghat	12				
		Chittoor	18				
		Ottapalam	5				
		Titur	3				
		Ponnani	2	56	56	49	—
8	Kozhikode	Pernithalmanna	4				
		Ernad	11				
		Kozhikode	3				
		Quilandy	214				
		Badagara	7				
		South Wynaad	63				
		Vithiri	3	305	180	153	125
9	Cannanore	Cannanore	2				
		Hosdurg	2				
		Kasargode	1				
		Kottayam	1	6	6	6	—
			543	543	363	210	180
							12084

A minimum number of families in a Gramdan unit as per official list is 7 at Vaniya Paramba or 9 at Vellinezhi in Ottapalam Taluk in Palghat district and the maximum is 51 families at Kottayam in Alwaye taluk in Ernakulam district (60 in Nediyruppu Colony Kozhikode).

Pallikara is the revenue village in Quilandy taluk Kozhikode district where as high as 80 per cent of the total population is said to have signed for Gramdan. The same has received due publicity in *Bhoodan Yagna* (Hindi) dated 22nd November 1957.

As indicated in Table I there have been no Gramdans in Quilon and Kottayam district. Vinoba passed hastily through these districts on his way to Kaladi and did not spend more than 9 days in these two districts. Alleppey district had only one Gramdan of 22 families in October, 1958. In Cannanore there are six units with 90 families. Vinoba was in that district for a fortnight.

In Trichur there are 17 Gramdan units embracing 421 families. Vinoba toured the area for 10 days. In Palghat where the saint trekked for full one month there have been 56 gramdans by 1,347 families. In Ernakulam district where Kaladi Sammelan was held, there are 123 Gramdans with 2,562 families and in Kozhikode where Vinoba moved for 45 days and Kelappanji had his Padyatra for 60 days there are 305 Gramdans by 6,769 families.

As such two districts are without any Gramdans. Another two put together have below 10. Other 3 districts of Trivandrum, Trichur and Palghat have only 108 in all. Ernakulam has 123 and Kozhikode tops all with 305.

One out of every 230 persons in Kerala has so far come forward for Gramdan. In Quilandy taluk 9 out of every 100 persons have stood for it.

From sample study in a number of villages it can be concluded that out of all the 12,084 signatories 90 per cent approximately have land below one acre, 9.6 per cent between 1 to 3 acres. Only .4 per cent have above it with one signatory owning more than 30 acres.

The Gramdan can be divided into five major pockets.

1. Malayadi Pocket

It is a cluster of 34 Gramdan units with an average of 25 families per unit lying within a radius of 4 miles from Malayadi in Nedumangad taluk of Trivandrum district in the vicinity of Vinoba Niketana — a Sarvodaya Ashram headed by Kumari A. K. Rajamma, a member of A. B. Sarva Seva Sangh. This pocket lies in the midland region of Kerala, has a density of 711 persons per square mile. In all there are 20 revenue villages (Pakuthis) in Nedumangad taluk each with an average population of 13,000 persons split in a number of sub-villages (Karas). These Gramdans lie in 32 rural denominations (Karts) and affect only 2 per cent of the total population in the Taluk.

2. Kaladi Pocket

This pocket in Ernakulam district has 123 Gramdan units mostly within the radius of 8 miles from Kaladi, spread out in 54 rural denominations (Revenue villages and sub-villages) of Alwaye and Kunnathunad taluk. Total families in this pocket are 2,562. This pocket lying in the midland region of Kerala is divided in two by the river Pariyar. Every affected rural denomination holds 47.4 families and 2.3 Gramdan units. Density of population is 1,000 per square mile. The development work is supervised by Shri Ikkanda Warriar, a member of Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal.

3. Krumbranad Pocket

Krumbranad being the local name of Quilandy area of Kozhikode district, 214 Gramdan units are spread over in almost all the 54 revenue villages of Quilandy taluk and outside in the 14 adjoining revenue villages. This pocket runs along the coast and is unique for its poetic richness. Total number of Gramdan families is 4,691, with 71 families and 3.3 Gramdan units per revenue village. Gramdan population forms 8.9 of the whole population of the taluk which is 292 square miles in area with a population of 291,883 persons. Density as such is about 1,000 persons per square mile. Shri Kelappan, Chairman of the Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal directs the development activities of this pocket, chosen for intensive experimental work.

4. *Wynad Pocket*

This pocket is geographically unique. Situated on the Western Ghats at an altitude of 3,000 feet in Wynad taluk of Kozhikode district, it offers a good escape from the coconut-dominated landscapes of the coastal and midland region. Tea, coffee, rubber estates and thick forests add a new charm and offer a good chance to a northerner to taste the cooler climate in this temperate region.

The density of population here is naturally low, *i.e.*, 150 per square mile. The taluk is 528 square miles in area holding a population of 79,551 persons. There are 63 Gramdan units located in almost equal number of rural denominations. Total number of families involved is 1,264 with an average of 20 tribal or Harijan families per Gramdan unit. The development work is nominally under Shri Kelappan.

5. *Palghat Pocket*

Fifty-six Gramdans of Palghat district are thinly sprinkled in its 5 talukas. Gandhi Seva Sadan at Parli run by Sarva Seva Sangh manages the development of these pockets. Density of population in the area is about 792 per square mile.

Apart from the Gramdans under these pockets there are others also twinkling here and there in isolated corners. Besides, there are some vast tracts of Bhoodan lands in the state.

An organization under the name of Sarvodaya Mandal was nominated by Vinobaji on 14th July 1957, at Kozhikode to shoulder the responsibility of Gramdan work. Following chapters deal with the Sarvodaya Mandal, Gandhi Smarak Nidhi and the Khadi Commission. The Kerala Khadi Board, a statutory body at the provincial level has also been dealt along with Khadi Commission. The Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh had its direct but limited performance at one place only; hence it has not been included here. The role of N.E.S. Block has been discussed only during the particular case study where the N.E.S. block was active in one of the Gramdan pockets.

The Sarvodaya Mandal is the direct vehicle of Sarvodaya ideology whereas Gandhi Smarak Nidhi and Khadi Commission seek their light from and owe their allegiance to Vinobaji. Sarvodaya leadership also constitutes half the strength of the

Kerala Khadi Board which came into existence only during the Communist ministry. The Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal and Gandhi Smarak Nidhi are the non-official agencies; the rest are official ones channelizing their finances through various schemes for Gramdan villages. We will take up Sarvodaya Mandal in the next chapter.

CHAPTER 9

A Paradox

VINOBA DISSOLVED the Bhoodan Samitis on November 22, 1956 at Palni. Why? "My faith is not on the organizations but the individual; organization has no heart hence the question of change of heart does not arise in them," said Vinoba while reiterating his stand on the issue on 8th June, 1957. But the river again took a turn against its course. Almost the same personnel came up to serve the same purpose under the Sarvodaya Mandals. It will be quite relevant, it seems, to quote Vinoba's speech delivered after his nomination of Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal at Kozhikode on 14th July, 1957.

"The question arises: why are we raising this Sarvodaya Mandal after we have dissolved the Bhoodan Samitis? In spite of reluctance, some set-up to serve as a foundation for our faith and execution of our work becomes necessary. Elsewhere, some people are elected and they execute the work. This goes on in democracy which divides the people but this is Sarvodaya work where the question of election does not arise. Nobody elected me for Bhoodan work. As such I have no capacity to elect or not to elect people. I want a friend's fellowship. We have a bigger fellowship no doubt, but this Sarvodaya Mandal is raised to execute whatever little work we have and they will plan for future activities and enroll volunteers. Sarvodaya Mandal consists of persons known closely to me and it will draw faith from all. We don't want debates but offerings at the altar which have started. We got the Sampattidan which

though little, has drops of faith (Vinoba got Sampattidan worth Rs. 51,405.00 as annual donations in the State)."

"People as well as ourselves look with a prejudiced eye at those who have been working in political parties since long. The prejudices of the people can be cured through our impartial stand only and such prejudices about others should go the way our party affiliations have gone."

"Some old and some young people are there in this (newly nominated) Sarvodaya Mandal. With the old, serving as a bow, the young will serve as an arrow and go ahead with the backing of the old. Somebody had pointed out that Kelappanji alone will do as a Mandal. Nobody in his (old) age will carry any burden of responsibility alone but will certainly expect others to accompany and help him."

"Assembly does not deserve its name if there are no old persons on its strength since a gathering of the young is a sheer debating society, it can't take decisions, hence the inclusion of the old is necessary. Differences may occur. But for the differences of opinion between the young and the old, there would have been no progress of the nation. It is expected of the youth to consult the old since the aged are more experienced than they. But the youth, after it has laid its views frankly before the old, should accept the latter's advice without much argument."

"The differences of opinion can be taken to consultants like me. If that be impossible the method of unanimity can be adopted. But in the absence of unanimity the matter can be dropped and other alternative tried."

This explains the constitution of Sarvodaya Mandal which has the following members :

1. Shri K. Kelappan,
2. Shri E. Ikkanda Warriar,
3. Shri K. Janardan Pillai,
4. Shri Shyamji Sunder Das,
5. Kumari A. K. Rajamma,
6. Shri I. K. Kumaran, and
7. Shri Diwakaran Kartha.

They also constitute the total strength of Shanti Sena in Kerala. A brief sketch of each member will provide an inkling

of their capacities to work out the Gramdan concept, leaving aside the other utopia of Shanti Sena.

Shri K. Kelappan

One of the strongest crusaders against the caste system and real builder of the Congress in Kerala throughout the freedom struggle he could not reconcile himself with the Congress as it was shaped after freedom. Joining P.S.P. he represented it in Parliament from 1951 to 1956. During J.P.'s tour in 1954 he gave away his whole land — 30 to 40 acres — in Bhoodan and during Vinoba's State tour in 1957 he gave his life for Sarvodaya. 69 at present, he was nominated as the Chairman of Sarvodaya Mandal and the Chief of Shanti Sena. He is also the Chairman of Kerala Gandhi Smarak Nidhi, member of Khadi Board and Honorary organizer of Mudadi Intensive Area Scheme in Krumbranad area, his native place.

Shri E. Ikkanda Warriar

One of the members of a big family of Diwans of Cochin he was a lawyer and president of the Cochin Praja Mandal before he shot up for a few months in 1946 as a chief minister of a responsible Government required to work under the Diwan of Cochin — a state with a population of 20 lakhs. Later on in the integrated ministry of Travancore-Cochin, he was taken as a minister. Inactive later for 4 years he was drawn to Bhoodan movement during Shankar Rao Deo's Padyatra in Kerala in 1952 and was the chief of state Bhoodan Samiti till it was finally dissolved in 1956. He, aged 60, is one of the persons who represent the Sarvodaya Mandal in the state administration to draw funds etc.

Shri K. Janardan Pillai

41 years of age at present, he started his career as a member of Inter-Religious Fellowship Madras, moved into Young Hindu Movement to rebut the influence of Christian conversions amongst low-castes and worked later in Arya Hindu Dharma Seva Sangha patronized by Birla. After freedom he became an organizer for Congress work amongst students of South India. In 1950 he joined as an assistant convenor of Gandhi Smarak Nidhi. Since 1952 he is a full fledged convenor

of Gandhi Smarak Nidhi, is on the executive of Kerala Khadi Board, and an honorary organizer of Intensive Area Scheme at Nemom.

Shri Shyamji Sunder Das

He is aged about 60, is a Gujarati businessman born in Calicut and well-versed in Malayalam. Formerly, a textile dealer, he is now the agent of Burma Shell. Courting arrest in 1942, he was in jail for sometime. A host to Sarvodaya leadership, he is the key man to finance the Sarvodaya work. His own firm accommodates the office of Sarvodaya publications including the '*Bhoodan Kahlam*' a Malayalam weekly.

Interested in Harijan work he was drawn into the development of Nediyrippu Harijan colony and has spent nearly 15,000.00 from his own pocket to rehabilitate the settling Harijans, released from the gripping tyranny of neighbouring Muslim landlords. Convenor of Sarvodaya Mandal he is also the patron of Harijan Sevak Sangh. His talent for business management is a great asset to the Sarvodaya Movement although youngsters don't see eye-to-eye with him.

Kumari A. K. Rajamma

Quite active in student movement just before freedom, she left her studies in Law and joined at Sevagram (Wardha) and toured various parts of North India. During Bhoodan work she became an organizer for Trivandrum district and continued till the organization was dissolved at the close of 1956. She is a pet of Vinoba and managed Vinoba during his tour in Kerala rather too strongly and earned the disfavour of the workers here. She is 32 now and is in charge of a Sarvodaya Ashram named Vinoba Niketan at Malyadi and is also the member of All India Sarva Seva Sangh.

Shri I. K. Kumaran

Aged 50, he came into prominence during the liberation of Mahe, a French possession and was convenor of Bhoodan Samiti for sometime after Mr. Ikkanda Warriar. Not highly educated, he is engaged in constructive work at Mahe.

Shri Divakaran Kartha

He is also an old man and a member of Kerala Sarva Seva

Sangh. He looks to the organizational work at Nilambur Bhoodan colony.

All the above members also constitute the Shanti Sena membership which has not gone beyond 8 since its inception by Vinoba on his departure from the state.

There are 15 whole time workers (men) on rolls of the Sarvodaya Mandal. Additional 5 workers of Sarva Seva Sangh are on deputation to Sarvodaya Mandal. Its balance sheet for the period 1-8-1957 to 31-7-1958 throws further light on its working. Against the total income of Rupees 33746.13 n.P. from Sampattidan the expenses are shown as under :—

Travel :

	Rs.
T. A. s	8322.74 n.P.
Expenses for the Jeep	4289.68 n.P.
Establishment.	
Salaries	5565.69 n.P.
Office and misc.	3430.55 n.P.
Field work.	
In Krumbranad	8312.92 n.P.
In Nilambur and elsewhere	1800.00 n.P.
Balance.	
Cash in hand	2024.55 n.P.
Total	<u>33746.13 n.P.</u>

The Sarvodaya Mandal has its own jeep and maintains an office at Calicut. The '*Bhoodan Kahlam*' weekly is managed by the Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal in the premises of Burma Shell agency of Shri Shyamji Sundar Dass. The travel-expense, constituting almost two-fifths of the whole expenditure, exceed the expenditure in field work. Some workers are poorly paid.

Now we turn to the role of Gandhi Smarak Nidhi in Gramdan work.

CHAPTER 10

In Gandhiji's Memory

GANDHI SMARAK NIDHI till the end of 1956, has been the major financier to Bhoodan Samitis and Sarvodaya work including Vinoba's Padyatra. After the dissolution of Bhoodan Samitis some Gramdan work has directly been taken up by the Nidhi. One camp by Nidhi workers held in the middle of 1957 in Quilandy Taluk of Kozhikode is said to have brought nearly 31 gramdams and Nidhi's budgets have since then tried to cover the Gramdan follow-up work. The financial position of Kerala Gandhi Smarak Nidhi is as under :

	Rs.
Total collection in the province for Gandhi Smarak Nidhi	23,60,508.00
Deduct for Bhoodan and Krishi Vibhag the central quota	8,03,559.00
Balance remains	15,56,949.00
Expenditure to the '57 end	6,55,167.00
Balance of allocation at the end of 1957	9,01,782.00
Amount spent upto 9/58	84,100.00
Probable expenditure last quarter of 1958	1,09,900.00
Balance available for 1959 onwards	7,07,782.00

This amount of Rs. 7 lakhs or so is to be exhausted under a phased programme extending upto 1964-65. The previous

practice of allotting grants to other organizations has to be stopped entirely by the end of 1960 by scaling it down through the year 1959.

Studying the budget outlays one finds that there were 25 village centres which have now been reduced to 8 only where only Rs. 6,000.00 could be spent for land and buildings against the sanction of Rs. 50,000.00 for 1958. On the other hand 3 centres have been opened in the cities of Trivandrum, Kozhikode and Ernakulam. The Nidhi incurs considerable expenditure in propaganda through padyatras, camps, conferences, study circles, seminars and prayers where the youth is said to be indoctrinated. In addition to Shri K. Kelappan and Janardan Pillai of Sarvodaya Mandal other members of the executive of Gandhi Smarak Nidhi are Shri Pattom Thanu Pillai (Ex. Chief Minister, PSP), Shri K. I. Mathew (Advocate, Parvur), Smt. O. K. Madhavi Amma (a homoeopathic lady doctor, Ernakulam), Shri Eacharan, M.P. (Harijan) and Smt. S. K. George, wife of Shri S. K. George, Ex-Editor *Gandhi Marg*). Then there is young spirited Shri Gopinath Nair — A Shanti Niketan product (Incharge Gandhi Tatwa Prachar Vibhag). Last of all, Shri Radha Krishna Menon has entrenched himself in a village 14 miles from Calicut and is battling hard to pioneer new approaches in village planning and education.

Development of Gramdan Villages

In the budget for 1958 there was provision for expenditure of Rs. 81,900.00 for development work in 5 compact areas of Gramdan villages earmarking Rs. 16,380.00 for each. Later, it was decided to take up only 2 such areas but the work started in one, i.e. Kaladi as late as July, 1958.

The working of one such Gramdan area is explained by the Nidhi as under :

One unit will contain a group of villages say within a compass of 2 miles to be managed by 2 males and one lady worker. The main effort will be to rouse the local enthusiasm and mobilize all available resources. The financial assistance sought from the Nidhi should act as a stimulus. Special efforts will be made to avail of the assistance given by the Khadi and

Village Industries Commission etc., and the assistance sought from the Nidhi will be utilized only for purposes for which help is not available otherwise. For one such unit the budget runs as under :

Non-Recurring Expenses

	Rs.
(a) Well, building, bathroom, agricultural implements and bullocks	4500.00
(b) Industries, Charkhas, looms etc.	1000.00
(c) Adult and child education, health and recreation	1100.00
(d) Provision store and share capital for a co-operative	700.00
TOTAL	7300.00

Recurring

(a) Workers' salary	3600.00
(b) Craft and Balwadi Teacher	1620.00
(c) T.A., postage and books	560.00
(d) Subsidies for seeds and manures	500.00
TOTAL	6580.00

Loans

(a) Purchase of raw material for industries oil seeds, etc.	1000.00
(b) Provision store	500.00
(c) Agriculture operations	1000.00
TOTAL	2500.00

In all, the total outlay is 16,380.00 per unit. On the two such proposed units the expenses will be 32,760.00 for the year 1959. So far only one centre in Kaladi pocket is activated which we will study in detail later.

Compared to this the outlay for propaganda through Tatwa Prachar Vibhag is Rs. 43,130.00 and under a similar heading 'Training Camps for Workers' there is an additional provision of Rs. 15,700.00. In all Rs. 58,830.00 will be spent on publicity. We will now shift over to a brief study of the role of Khadi Commission with its intensive area schemes etc. launched in the Gramdan villages.

CHAPTER 11

Khadi after Gandhiji

FREEDOM FIGHTING India had Khadi as its main plank for both political and constructive activities, but free India in the first few years saw the cruel mopping of cottage industries. The rapid growth of textile, oil and rice mills disillusioned millions of artisans and craftsmen and the rural unemployed population. However, Karve Committee, appointed by the Planning Commission in June 1955, prepared a case for Cottage Industries which to some extent pacified the Gandhian economists who don't see eye to eye with industrialization. Khadi and Village Industries Commission at the Centre and the provincial Khadi Boards now include a large number of Khadi economists, and they have got a good margin and free hand to experiment with their ideas on economic integration of the rural communities which are being trapped into a quickly urbanising economy where production of industrial machinery for cotton textiles during the second plan is to go from 4 crores to 17 crores and the export target for mill cloth to be achieved by 1960-61 is 1000 to 1,100 million yards. The adherents of Khadi are trying hard through the Khadi and Village Industries Commission and Provincial Boards to rehabilitate the rural economy leached through foreign trade and domination during the last two to three centuries, and have evolved an integrated rural development plan through the Intensive Area Scheme with Khadi as the base. Gramdan brought a new hope. Both the C.P.A. and the Khadi Commission jumped at the idea. But C.P.A.

due, perhaps, to a strong urban bias of its staff and self-righteousness of Sarvodaya people could not do much to co-ordinate its activities with the Bhoodan or Gramdan people whereas Khadi Commission seems quite at home with the sponsors of Gramdan work.

As a result nearly 40 workers from different Gramdan villages of Kerala along with trainees from other states have joined at Kora Gramodyog Kendra, Bombay* where new Khadi Gramodyog Vidyalala sponsored by Acharya Vinoba has started functioning from June 15, 1958. These trainees through one year's course will be trained in the techniques of different village industries and taught the theories of Sarvodaya philosophy with special reference to Bhoodan and Gramdan movement. The curriculum includes training in carcass recovery, use of bone digester, fibre-making, oil ghani, soap-making from non-edible oils, bee-keeping, cottage-match, agriculture and the use and construction of a gas plant. Besides, there is a separate provision by Khadi Commission authorizing any registered body to draw Rs. 1,800.00 annually for its workers. Designated as Gramsahayaks they will be expected to look to the population of 2,500 persons and supposed to submit a plan of work for five years for their area of operation. Apart from this, intensive area scheme has been decided to be extended primarily to the Gramdan pockets. A brief outline of the Intensive Area Scheme is presented hereunder.

Started in 1954-55 the Intensive Area Scheme is theoretically a comprehensive attempt at an integrated rural economic development except in the field of agriculture. A contiguous area with a population of about 20,000 is selected with a view to developing village industries as an integral part of the rural economy. Extended at present to 96 areas covering a population of about 20 lakhs spread into 2,000 villages it will cover nearly 200 areas with a population of 40 lakhs at the end of the Second Plan at a total cost of Rs. 2.77 crores. The scheme ensures full employment in the areas undertaken.

The principles of the Intensive Area Scheme are so much identical with those of Gramdan philosophy that the statement

* See *Jagriti* dated 18th December 1958.

of objectives of the scheme read very much like a Sarvodaya document. Gram Parivar (Village family) is the central concept governing the scheme which intends to arrest the disintegration of the village community hastened due to the impact of industrial development in the urban sector and also to stop the individualistic economic growth in the rural sector itself. It envisages a community of village families thinking together, working together and sharing together.

The scheme has somewhat more clearly defined economic and social purpose than Gramdan. It holds a promise of creating a full employment situation at a minimum standard from area to area in a reasonably short time and with comparative low investment. The concept of village sufficiency evolves further into that of regional integrated plan to be carried on in a central place for a given area or a region. The scheme envisages that the productivity of village industries should increase so as to yield a daily income of about Rs. 4.00 or an annual income of Rs. 1,800.00 per family. Some industries, it is stated, are in a position to yield this income with their present techniques if they are given the necessary financial, organizational and marketing assistance. The other cottage industries can also come up to yield the required income by ancillary process along with the main industry and technical improvements which don't effect displacement of labour even and ensure a steadily rising minimum income to the worker.

It is also stated that the shift from Kisan to Ambar charkha will double the output from 3 hanks to 6 hanks per work day, carding will increase from 3 lbs. to 8 lbs. per work day by change from medium bow carding to medium Modhia carding. The output is said to increase from one maund to 2 maunds of rice per work day by changing from mortar and pestle dehussing and milling to dhenki dehussing and milling. Similarly, improved oil Ghani will crush 90 lbs. of oilseeds instead of 40 lbs. per work day with an increase in the extraction percentage from 35 to 40. Improvement of technique is accepted as imperative but regulated by reference to proper economic and social criteria.

Every area to be covered by the Scheme is selected on the basis of the availability of experienced constructive workers

and some background of constructive work in the area. The democratic institution at the base to sponsor development is the Kshetra Samiti, a society registered under the Societies Registration Act of 1860, with membership open to the residents of the area of operation with age above 18 years and an admission fee of four annas and a monthly subscription of one day's free labour or Re. 1.00 in kind or cash. The executive of the Kshetra Samiti is the Yojana Samiti, an ad hoc body composed of the leading workers of the area nominated by the Khadi and V. I. Commission for the first two years and later an elected body of 9 to 11 members chosen by the primary members of the Samiti in the area.

The primary members of the Kshetra Samiti in each village under the Intensive Area Scheme elect one Gram Vikas Mandal of 7 to 9 members to implement things at the village level on behalf of the Kshetra Samiti. The constitution of the Kshetra Samiti seems to be more flexible than the Co-operative M. P. Societies.

Funds follow to the Kshetra Samiti from the Commission on the recommendations of the Area Organizers who are employees of the Commission but are expected to work under the Kshetra Samiti. Every Intensive Area receives loans and grants from the Khadi and V. I. Commission for development of various industries on the Commission's standard patterns of financial assistance. Construction and establishment expenditure is also met with through special grants and loans by the Commission. Rs. 73,000.00 are spent on buildings for Khadi godowns, production centres, workshop and Parishramalayas. Rs. 17,000.00 annually are incurred as establishment charges and Rs. 2,000.00 on contingencies every year.

In Kerala there are 5 such Intensive areas administered centrally by the Commission as usual. Krumbranad area is covered partly by the Mudadi Intensive Area Scheme. Elsewhere Kerala Khadi and V. I. Board is working under similar objectives. The State Board came into existence only under the Communist Ministry and was nominated as late as August, 1957. Regarding its activities it generally executes the schemes of the Khadi Commission which bears cent per cent cost of those schemes. Only the cost of administration is to be borne

S-5.

by the State which has set apart Rs. 8.41 lakhs for that purpose for the Second Plan period. The following tentative allocations on respective items have been made by the Khadi and V. I. Commission for 1958-59 to the State Khadi Board.*

	Grants	Loans
Ambar Programme	7,77,200	16,00,000
Village oil	2,23,520	3,28,000
Palm gur	1,70,700	35,630
Bee-keeping	1,00,400	—
Hand-made paper	60,750	94,750
Pottery	57,980	35,500
Soap	53,650	94,450
Gur Khandsari	40,600	—
Hand pounding of rice	27,760	79,000
Leather	14,250	11,190
Emporia	75,000	—
Exhibitions	60,000	—
Regional Vidyalyaya	40,600	—
Ambar servicing station	8,000	24,000
TOTAL	17,10,410	23,02,520

Out of these grants and loans from the Commission, the Provincial Board has allowed 15 per cent of the total to be spent in Gramdan villages. 50 per cent will go to the block areas and the rest to non-block areas. As a result, about 2½ lakhs of grants and 3½ lakhs of loans will be issued to Gramdan villages during the year 1958-59. In addition, the Gramdans will also have the same 15 per cent out of all grants and loans issued independently by the State Government for such works to the Provincial Khadi Board which consists of the following :

- | | |
|----------------------------|----------|
| 1. Shri K. P. Gopalan | |
| (Minister for Industries) | Chairman |
| 2. Shri K. Kelappan | Member |
| 3. Shri E. Ikkanda Warriar | Member |
| 4. Shri K. Janardan Pillai | Member |
| 5. Smt. C. K. Omana | Member |

* Second Five Year Plan-Kerala 213.

- | | |
|----------------------------|---|
| 6. Dr. P. V. Nair | Director of Industries and
Commerce. |
| 7. Shri P. Sivarama Pillai | Registrar of Co-operative
Societies. |

Three out of the seven members, are official, three (2, 3, 4) are from Sarvodaya Mandal and one Smt. C. K. Omana is a Communist lady member.

Since the main stress of Sarvodaya Economics is on Khadi and Village Industries we will study in Part 4 the performance of Khadi and V. I. Industries Commission and Kerala Khadi Board. The latter mainly approaches these villages through specially raised statutory bodies under the name of Gramdan Co-operative Societies which are registered under the State Co-operative Act but are financed and directed entirely by the Khadi Board.

PART 3

On Land

CHAPTER 12

Introduction to Part 3

WE WILL now see in Part 3 Gramdan in action in the land sector. A statistical table of comparative study has been presented at the beginning. Since farm accounting has not been introduced at three out of five places the figures for all the heads could not be obtained. Only paddy crop figures have been taken up in the table referred to above, to study the performance at respective places.

Experiments vary with the agencies which finance them and the persons who execute them. Three of them *i.e.*, Nilambur, Paryaram and Nediyrippu (Chapter 13 to 15) are new settlements of former tenants and landless labourers. The remaining two at Vellinezhi and Thachancode (Chapter 16, 17) have been under peasant proprietorship. At Vellinezhi the trusteeship concept is on trial and at Thachancode comprehensive scientific co-operation is being attempted to prove that Gramdan is both a new way of life and a promise of economic benefits.

At Nediyrippu the initiative came, of course, from Bhoodan quarters but the follow-up is now almost entirely gone into the hands of the state. The Kerala Second Five Year Plan lays down ample funds and assistance for the development of this colony. But still the experiment draws the non-official interest since the colonists have declared a Gramdan of all their individual holdings.

At Nilambur the role of the state is secondary and Sarvodaya leadership seems to be up for experimenting its ideas on co-operative community organization on a larger scale. Paryaram is neglected by all i.e., the social workers, organizations as well as the state; the farm operations are carried on an individualistic basis. There is little consistent effort being made to tap state finances and state interest in the venture.

The farming at Paryaram and Nediyruppu is individualistic. In Vellinezhi and Thachancode it is more or less co-operative. At Nilambur it is collective and is being carried out in a new settlement on Bhoodan land. It is perfectly on a clean slate and we will proceed with that in the next chapters.

TABLE for comparative study of Agricultural Sector.

Place	Nilambur	Nediyirippu	Paryaram	Vellinezhi	Thachancode
1 Overall Executive Agency	Sarvodaya Mandal	Primary non-official now the state	A. B. Sarva Seva Sangh	Mr. K. Poduwal	Gramdan Coop. Society
Settlement New or old	New	New	New	Old under Peasant Proprietorship	Old under peasant proprietorship.
2 Land					
Total Land (Acres)	1000	750	941	35	27.07
Under cultivation (acres)	400	350	50	26	27.07
Under cooperative cultivation	380	Nil	Nil	26	6.97
Outside	20	Total area	Total area	Nil	20.10
	(Kitchen garden)				
Distributed amongst landless	—	Total area	218 (but only 50 acres occupied)	Nil	Nil
Undistributed Land	Total area	Nil	202	—	—
Cultivable or uncultivable waste	400	400 Approx.	200	9	Nil
Forest	200	—	—	—	—
3 Management, Nature of Ownership.	Bhoodan	Agricultural Coop. Society	Bhoodan	Trusteeship with Initial Donor	Individualistic
Pattern of land management	Collective	Individualistic	Individualistic	Partially Co-operative	Joint

Comparative study of Agricultural Sector (Continued)

Place and executive agency	Nilambur Sarvodaya Mandal	Nediyirippu Primary non- official now the state	Paryaram A. B. Sarva Seva Sangh	Vellinezhi Mr. K. Poduwal	Thachancode Gramdan Coop. Society
Managerial cost (Monthly Rs.)	300	375	41	Undefined	Nil
Strength of managerial personnel	5	2	1	1	Joint
Farm Accounts Introduced.	Yes	No	No	No	Yes
<i>4 Investments with source (Rs. & Agency)</i>					
Initial Capital Investment	100000 (Forest exploitation)	15000 (Syamiji Sundar Das)	5543 (State & Public donations)	Out of Pocket by Mr. Poduwal	505 (Gramdan Coop. Society)
On reclamation & Soil conservation	100000 (Govt. grant)	37000 (State grant)	Included in above	Nil	Nil
Housing	48000 (Govt. grant)	39880 (State grant)	6600 (Harijan Welfare)	Nil	Nil
	4000 (Sarvodaya M)			Nil	Nil
	800 (Harijan Welfare)			Nil	Nil
	1500 (Govt.)	2400	600 (Sarva Seva Sangh)	Nil	Nil
Drinking wells					
Tools & Miscellaneous	Nil	3000 (Harijan Welfare)	3000 (Sarva Seva Sangh)	Nil	600 (G. S. Nidhi for he-buffaloes.)
			2100 (Sarvo- daya Mandal)		

Comparative study of Agricultural Sector (Continued)

Place and executive agency	Nilambur Sarvodaya Mandal	Nediyirippu Primary non-official now the state	Paryaram A. B. Sarva Seva Sangh	Vellinezhi Mr. K. Poduval	Thachancode Gramdan Coop. Society
5 Man Power					
Number of families	100	84	13	8	15
Working population	226 (60% male)	N.A.	N.A.	N.A.	40 (70% male) (30% female)
Average daily attendance	177	N.A.	N.A.	N.A.	N.A.
Previous occupation	Tenants	Landless labourer	Tenants, Artisan & Landless labourers	Peasant Proprietor, Landless labourers and toddy tappers.	Farmers and Landless labourers.
6 Animal Power					
Buffalo pairs	9	Not in use	Not in use	5	3 (on joint farm)
Cost (Rs.)	1700	—	—	1000/-	600/-
Other livestock	10	10	20	30	20
7 Paddy Crop Yield Comparison					
Acreage under paddy	175	Nil	Nil	8	6.97
Work days	11003	Nil	Nil	N.A.	1310
Working day hours	8	N.A.	N.A.	Flexible	Flexible



Comparative study of Agricultural Sector (Continued)

Place and executive agency	Nilambur Sarvodaya Mandal	Nediyirippu Primary non-official now the state	Paryaram A. B. Sarva Seva Sangh	Vellinezhi Mr. K. Poduwal Society	Thachancode Gramdan Coop. Society
Wages paid (Rs.)	13904	Nil	Nil	N.A.	None
New method applied	No	—	—	Jap. Method fertilizers etc.	Ordinary with manuring.
Yield (maunds)	880	—	—	292	64—16 srs.
Value of the yield (Rs.)	8800/-	—	Nil	2920/-	644/-
Average yield per Acre (maunds)	5	—	1—9 srs	36—20 srs.	9—8 srs.
Profit or loss (Rs.)	5104/- (loss)	—	—	—	—
Share of yield per member	Nil	—	—	Approx. 7/8th to the trustee	3—11 srs.
Method of distribution	Wage system	—	—	1/8th to the farm hands in addition to the daily wage	on the basis of family members
No. distribution of yield	—	—	—	—	—
Average Total Income From Land (annual)					
Per family (Rs.)	675/-	250/-	50/-	App. 4200/- trustee	300/- dry land etc. included
Per worker (Rs.)	375/-	N.A.	N.A.	App. 350/- farm hands	N.A.

CHAPTER 13

A Clean Slate

THE WIND-WAFTED leaves and branches of teak and silk-cotton trees cozily sheltered the singing robins, finches, and tits in a forest, encircled by the bold mountains of the Western Ghats and girdled by the rushing river Cheliyar. Here elephants and tigers would leisurely move for a few draughts of its cool clear water. This sylvan world did not know that it would be disturbed by a single danpatra of 1,000 acres of Bhoodan by the Raja of Nilambur who owned such 60,000 acres in all. The axe finally fell in 1956 when only 9 settlers set out to clear a few acres for themselves to whom *prapti patras* (titles of land) had been personally distributed by Pandit Nehru, the Prime Minister of India whereas Shri J. P. Narayan in his Bhoodan tour in 1954 had got the Bhoodan declared for this whole tract from the donor. Furious at the encroachment, the elephants at times would come to shake the pillars and posts of the houses of early settlers. Even the donor objected to the felling of trees out of a second thought till Vinoba intervened and handed over the complete charge of the area to the Sarvodaya Mandal which started with an understanding that settlement be made on the principles of Gramdan even though 250 proposed settlers were given individual title for 3 to 5 acres each.

Location

Popularly known as Nilambur Gramdan colony, it is 55 miles to the east of Calicut, the bus carries you through Manjeri and

Nilambur to drop you at Chungatra. A six miles trek through the rubber plantations (run as highly capitalistic organisations) followed by small subsistence plantations of coconut and pepper running along the low lying paddy fields with a miserable road at the close of your journey, brings you to the banks of the river Cheliyar. A boatman's little boy with an easy punting takes you across. What a beautiful landscape! A few steps and here lies the Bhoodan Colony (local name) with timber stacked in front under the tall thick trees. To your right hand within the bamboo fencing hangs a blue board "Nilambur Sarvodaya Gramdan Co-operative Society". These are the Headquarters of the Sarvodaya planners battling perhaps to bring out a new order of their imagination.

The area was surveyed and marked by the surveyors of the then Kerala Bhoodan Samiti in November 1956. On the north-east the river Cheliyar forms almost a concave curve but crawls straight on the south-east. Straight boundaries on north-west and south-west each running one and a half mile long through the hill and forest form almost a square (vide *Bhoodan Kahlam* dated September 3, 1957). All the varieties of the soil — sandy, loam, alluvial, clay and laterite — are there. The topography is plain besides the river, hilly in between and on the western side. A number of streams awaiting to be harnessed for irrigation run through the colony.

Settlers

Out of 250 title-sharers only 100 have turned up by the close of 1958, the main settlement was effected in 1957 and 1958 by clearing nearly 400 acres that yielded about Rs. one lakh out of timber and firewood. The felling seems rather indiscriminate carried to the very steep gradients even when the vegetation there could be a check against soil erosion. Out of the rest, 400 acres have to be cleared and 300 acres are to be preserved as forest, it is stated. 100 houses surrounded by small kitchen-gardens of 10 to 20 cents with tapioca and plantain cultivation lie scattered in a haphazard way over the hills and plain throughout the settlement. The settlers 90 per cent of whom were the tenants working on the estates of the donor, blame the management for avoiding permanent house allot-



ment even after two years of settlement. With timber and bamboo available from the forest, each family was given a housing subsidy of Rs. 15.00 to Rs. 20.00. The blacksmith of the colony accommodates his mother, brother, sister, her husband and her 4 children in his 12 × 12 ft. hut. 60 per cent of the housing is worse than the slums. 80 per cent of the housing is unhygienic and poorly maintained. Only one adivasi has constructed a concrete tiled house with the grant of Rs. 800 and Rs. 40.00 received from Harijan Welfare Board and Sarvodaya Mandal respectively.

There are 25 families each from amongst Harijans, caste Hindus and Muslims. 10 families are of Christians and 15 of Adivasis. The last *i.e.*, adivasis even before the rising of the colony lived here and made a living out of forest produce, honey, bamboo and timber felling out of the whole area now under the colony.

Farming

The farming operation is on a collective basis with a daily wage system with payment of Rs. 250.00 per day on an average to about 226 potential workers, 60 per cent male and 40 per cent female. For six days of the week, the coupons, equal to the wage earned, are issued in the name of the co-operative store, on the seventh day there is a cash payment.

Animal Power

Animal power is used for farming operations. 9 pairs of he-buffaloes had for Rs. 1700.00 are sheltered in a shed that cost Rs. 500.00. They also work at timber pulling and are maintained by 2 men each earning a daily wage of Rs. 1.75. They graze unattended in the surroundings. There are two or three buffaloes maintained by individual families who sell the milk inside or out of the colony.

Implements and Allied Skills

Nearly 600 farm tools were contributed by the state government. The same number came through the Sarvodaya Mandal, mostly hoes, sickles, crowbars, pick axes and the rest. Ordinary plough with 2 inch long steel share at the end of a broad wooden landside is used for ploughing.

Three carpenter families work on the tools and implements for the farm under the tree shade at Rs. 2.00 per day even though the wage outside the Gramdan colony is Rs. 2.50 to Rs. 3.00 per day. Temptation for land had made them compromise with the low wage. A carpenter who came one year back got the right on land only early December, 1958. He uses his own tools. When he has no work in his tree-shade workshop, he joins his two daughters regularly employed on the farm work. His family stays 18 miles from here which he visits twice a week. The farm supervisor advises him on tools etc. 23 ploughs were found ready for work.

The blacksmith does not get his daily wage but works on piece wage and gets work from outside the colony also. When without work in his poorly equipped workshop, he works in the farm for Rs. 1.25 per day. In smithy he makes Rs. 2.00 per day on an average.

Field Operations

There is an eight hours' working day in the farm or the forest from 8 A.M. to 6 P.M. with a break from 12 to 2 P.M. for lunch. The supervisor maintains a muster-roll, the detailed accounts of seed, labour, output, etc. and regulates the working through the bell system. A regular roll call is held at the field. The whole crowd without any groups or squads marches on to the area of operation. Females work separately from men generally on a lighter operation. Out of the total area cleared, the following was the crop layout during the first crop period of 1958 :-

Paddy	
Cotton	175 acres
Plantains	7½ acres
Tapioca	3 acres
Ginger	2½ acres
	½ acre

The rest of the 400 acres were still fallow. Sesamum was sown in the paddy area during the second crop. The break-up of area, yield and wage payment of the major crop is as under :-

Item	Paddy	Cotton
Area	175 acres	7½ acres
Work days put in	11003	1844
Wages disbursed	Rs. 13904.00	2322.00
Yield	880 maunds	36½ maunds.
Value (approx.)	Rs. 8800.00	Rs. 1430.00
Loss	Rs. 5104.00	Rs. 892.00

The wage distribution and work days for tapioca, plantain and ginger cultivation were not available but the crops were under good condition and expected to yield an income of about Rs. 3,000.00.

Sesamum in the second crop involved 1,000 work days and Rs. 1,143.00 of wage payment. But the venture is to end in net loss, the crop being too poor. The Gramsabha is stated to be in charge of crop planning.

The sesamum sown by the settlers in their own compounds was, however, in an excellent condition, plants running as high as 5 feet with pods bursting with seeds.

The paddy yield during the first crop of 1958 was just enough for 3 months for the colony. Second crop paddy could not be sown for want of irrigation facilities. A number of tame streams await to be harnessed for that purpose.

Soil Conservation

Rupees one lakh have been advanced as loan by the State Government for soil conservation on 4½ per cent interest. Only Rs. 75,000.00 have to be repaid within 20 years through easy instalments. The soil conservation team of the State government led by a supervisor started the work in the last week of November, 1958 and is stationed in the colony itself. The contour bunding was in progress at the time of the visit (4th to 6th December 1958) to the Gramdan colony. The women folk were busy with their sickles in jungle clearance, men were at the bunds with their pick-axes fighting hard against the gravel in the red laterite soil richly covered with humus. The average output of earth work was 14 cft. against the minimum output of 20 cft. per man per working day for which the Government

scheduled rate of payment is Rs. 1.50. But the colonists got Rs. 1.25 per day without any consideration for output. Able and efficient workers were grumbling against the management for not fixing up norms of work or dividing workers in squads but idlers were happy and worked quite leisurely. Out of the total working population of 226, following was the attendance roll on the dates shown hereunder :—

December 1	162
„ 2	174
„ 3	189
„ 4	183

On the 5th December 1958, 69 men and 42 women were at work.

Wages

The wage schedule has been set up according to the nature of work. As such, the wage for timber felling is the highest i.e., Rs. 1.75, for ploughing it is Rs. 1.50, and for general farm work it is Rs. 1.25. Women get uniform rate of Re. 1.00 per working day and children (12 to 16 age group) get 50 to 75 nPs. per day.

There is an allowance system in practice which is meant to bring the family income to 37 to 50 nPs. per member per day but there is no uniformity in this allowance schedule. The Gram Sabha after studying the condition of each family is stated to have decided the amount of allowance to be paid to the deserving families. By study of a cross section of the families the following conclusion could be made about the payment of allowance;

Potential worker	Dependent children	Amount of allowance
One potential worker	1 child	Nil
„ „ „	2 Children	00.25 nP.
„ „ „	3 Children	00.50 nP.
2 potential workers	Upto 3 Children	Nil
2 „ „	4 „	00.25 nP.

The allowance system is said to be introduced on 'according to the needs' principle.

The coupons equivalent to the wage or allowances earned are issued in the noon or evening by the managerial staff in the name of the co-operative store which is found bustling with activity in the noon or evenings. Women workers turned into housewives think hard to plan the budget but the items and quantities almost remain the same. One day in a week is for cash payments. The total draws in the day are not signed by each individual but by a leader nominated for a group to do the same. The whole income goes to the store except a few chips left for cloth which is not made available in the store due to some ideological considerations regarding self-sufficiency in cloth.

The Co-operative Store

The settlers have paid Rs. 20.00 as share money for the Sarvodaya Gramdan Co-operative Society. Nominally the store is run by its managing committee, which is the same as the Executive of the Gram Sabha. The average daily returns are Rs. 200.00 through sale of rice, salt, kerosene, sugar, jaggery, matches, soap, sesamum and coconut oil, coffee, and tea and bidis. The total disbursement of wages through the provisions by the store on 5th December, 1958 was Rs. 243.87. The annual turnover is stated to be nearly Rs. 80 thousand. A merchant at Nilambur about 14 miles from the colony provides stock on credit. Cartmen are employed from outside for Rs. 1.50 per bag for transport from Chungatra (6 miles) while the he-buffaloes idle away on the farm. The Society awaits appointment of a secretary (from the Co-operative Department) to be paid by the State Government for the first 3 years.

The School

The school was started in September 1958 in an unimpressive hut where charcoal burners, working in the forest, also stay and cook. 41 children below 8 years are on rolls, taking lessons in alphabet and counting in the morning and in Takli spinning in the afternoon. A teacher is appointed on a daily wage of Rs. 1.25. Children above 8 years, who were attending schools before their parents settled here, loiter all

the day for want of a school, the nearest school being 3 miles from the colony.

Spinning etc.

The Kerala Sarva Seva Sangh has supplied Charkhas. Training in spinning has been started with a 10 days' course for a batch of 15 boys and girls. It is planned to train 150 spinners through 10 batches. There is no weaver in the colony. One potter comes from outside to vend his pots at times.

Facilities and Recreation etc.

30 per cent of the population is stated to be literate. Newspapers like *Matribhoomi*, *Deshabhimani* — the two dailies and '*Bhoodan Kahlam*' weekly are received in the colony and placed near the office of the co-operative. Medical facilities are absent. Nearest hospital is about 15 miles. A drinking well costing Rs. 1500.00 has recently been completed. Muslims go 3 miles for Friday prayers, Christians read Bible at home, he does not go in for farm work.

There are 15 to 20 regular drunkards in the colony in spite of the prohibition in the district (Kozhikode) and Sarvodaya management in the colony. Shri O. Vailu, a drunkard often provides fun when he goes with the colony's gun (borrowed from outside the colony to defend against wild animals) to frighten the managerial staff for increase in wages and individual distribution of land. Mr. Vasu, good at stone cutting whenever he can get work, can be classed as an idler since he does not go in for farm work.

Management Set-up

Shri Ikkanda Warriar is the President of the Gramdan Co-operative Society which is said to be *de jure* authority for management. But the power mainly rests with the President due to the clause 20(a) of the Sarvodaya Gramdan Co-operative Society which reads "The President shall have a general control over all the affairs of the society and shall be the ex-officio treasurer and shall have the custody of all the properties of the society."

A clerk, a farm supervisor, an accounts and spinning instructor, a store supervisor-cum-salesman and a timber clerk

and supervisor make up the establishment staff which is paid Rs. 300.00 per month.

Another member of the Sarvodaya Mandal spends here a week within a month. A Congressite landlord from Chungatra also visits the colony at times to look to the sale of timber, etc.

Gram Sabha

The entire working population constitutes the membership of the Gram Sabha which is considered to be the supreme authority but it holds its meetings only on the two-day visit of the Chairman of the Co-operative who for the rest of the month is generally away from the colony. Ladies also attend the meetings but they seldom participate in the deliberations. Only once on the principles of "according to the need", a Muslim lady, demanded clothing allowance for women folk who wore more than men but were paid less than they. Future plans, farm management, wages, permanent allotment of house sites, individual distribution of land and drunkards form the subjects of discussions. There is an executive committee of the Gram Sabha consisting of 8 members.

The executive of the Sabha through its 8 members is nicely representative of the virile tenantry of Kerala and also presents a healthy variety of human character. There is one Mr. Chakko the toughest guy who has his arboreal house on a tree to dodge the elephants who frequently visit his ground hut. Shri Kunjan, having the profundity of a village headman is a guard to the colony and is armed well during the night. Shri K. R. Raghavan, an ex-serviceman with a smattering of Hindi is a forceful personality with a hardworking bent. T. Mohamed is a very efficient farmer. Bhaskaran Vaidya is both a farmer and physician quite enlightened politically and intelligent otherwise. Then there is Shri Raman Ilayat, the teacher who as a congressman courted arrests during freedom struggle. Shri Parameshwaran Acharya is the aged respectable carpenter and then last is the most inspiring Vellan—an adivasi who has been an old inhabitant of the colony. He is the only illiterate member of the executive of the Gram Sabha.

Most of these members were early settlers who on grant of Danpatra had made some investment for the improvement

of land before the collective venture started. With the simplicity of the peasant's language they were almost unanimous to state: "The love and binding sentiment that dominated 3 years back when there were few settlers, has vanished with the setting up of the collective management under which idlers talk ill of the set up even though they receive ready allowances and good wages."

Growing Pains

It appears to be a one-man show with little participation from the committee except that its members work for wages as if in a labour camp where they have been interned for their weakness about land-hunger. To rouse their participation, the statement of monthly income and expenditure has never been submitted for discussion. On the other hand, there seems to be an iron curtain around financial management. Nothing has been mentioned in the annual accounts statement of Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal except an item of expenditure for Rs. 500.00 on behalf of the colony. The supervisory or managerial staff is cut off from the people and is almost bureaucratic in its dealings. The profit and loss situation of the store also has not been explained to the people even though they have paid Rs. 20.00 as share money. No proceedings book is said to be in use. Only once have the Managing Committee members been asked to sign some book. One Congressite landlord who looks to the management of timber is looked on with suspicious eye by the community which, denied the share of responsibility, is careless about the general waste and misuse of the colony's assets. One such memorandum was also submitted by the spirited settlers but it was quietly cold-stored, it is stated. At a stage there was a move for general strike against the management when all the Gramdanis wanted to move to Shri Kelappan for representation but somehow the matters were hushed up. As a result, there prevails a general insecurity about the future amongst settlers who argue in favour of individual ownership to end all worries about the over-all set up which is beyond their control and eludes their understanding.

Margin of Improvement

It is a blessing in disguise that the expected additional 150 families have not turned up, perhaps, due to their disappointment about the co-operative ownership or their refusal to serve as guinea pigs for Sarvodaya experiments. Now the time limit is also over, the population should be restricted to these 100 families only, since with this number the land per capita including the forest is hardly 1.6 acres.

It must be stated that the over-all management of the colony is far from satisfactory. The farm operations are very loosely carried out. Intensity of labour is lacking. The whole working population could be easily divided into teams, groups or squads to show results on a competitive or comparative basis. Group leaders could be appointed in rotation to educate people in shouldering responsibilities. The share in management could be easily increased by utilizing the talents of the members of the Executive Committee who are at the mercy of the managerial staff.

Under the present management, the compost pit is indistinguishable from the animal shed. In spite of large-scale felling no use has been made of organic waste for manure. No view has been taken of proper integration of crop and animal husbandry. The live-stock population is hardly more than 30. Only 30 per cent of the people have some poultry fowls. The store needs considerable improvement in wholesale purchases in its own cartage of provisions, and generosity to allow cloth to take its place among other provisions. Self-sufficiency should not make commercial Khadi, handloom products, etc., a taboo. Much of the worry of the settlers could be diminished by permanent allotment of house sites. Now since the Government's grant for the construction of 76 houses at the cost of Rs. 626.00 each has been received (in February, 1959) the matters could be easily expedited by seeking the advice of some town planner.

With virgin lands the output of paddy is 5 maunds per acre which is a sad commentary on the co-operative effort. There is no agricultural expert attached to the colony, nor is the president of the Co-operative much conversant with the agricultural operations. His regular long absence from the

colony is a big problem but his presence may still be a bigger problem, say the settlers.

In spite of all this, the environment of the colony is highly thought-provoking and exciting for a practical social scientist, educationist, agronomist and an engineer. It needs a team at the top which, by dedicating a few years, can be instrumental in stimulating life in this newly rising co-operative village. But it is highly doubtful whether Sarvodaya Mandal can at all draw such persons within its fold. The greatest asset is not the virgin land and the tame streams perhaps, but the zeal, vigour and will within the settlers to create a new, progressive wholesome community which can take decisive co-operative measures towards prosperity. The challenge is manifold. Such experiment is the crying need. But who shall fold up the sleeves?

The vast resources of the community spirit may fizzle out by a loose handling of the vigorous community of peasants leaving the only alternative of individual ownership which may mean a clear verdict on the failure of Sarvodaya leadership to handle virile communities of the farmers. The leadership may retreat to its only field of spinning where it seems to be more involved.

The inherent inertia of the petrified structure of agriculture pervades the colony. New implements or fertilizers are not introduced, establishment of social services for proper education, recreation, health and veterinary are missing so also the participation of the settlers in the general management, supervision and fund allocation, etc. There is little freedom of action except in a kitchen garden extending to 10 to 20 cents where the crops are far better than those in the community farm. There are no incentives for hard work, no norms for output, no limit for minimum days of work, and no bonus for maximum attendance at the farm. As such, it may be difficult to secure increased production even through the use of all possible grants or loans flowing from the State Government to encourage such experiment. The income from forest was the primary source of investment. Now the Government loan of Rs. one lakh for soil conservation has come in. The present working shows income to be less than wage payment. It is

to be seen for how long the principle of "according to the need" works. The Co-operative Department is surprised why Shri Warriar is asking for a loan of Rs. 40 thousands for Nilambur co-operative, when he promised at the time of registration of the society that he will make no demand for loans which, according to him, will be had only from the Khadi Board. One has to see through the balance sheet whenever it is published by the Co-operative Society or the Sarvodaya Mandal how much has been the investment per acre and with what results. From the present working it appears to be a financial liability excepting its experimental value which is undoubtedly more important since Gramdan involves both the economic development and human relationship. In fact, Gramdan means applying religion to land as well as man. Any visitor to the colony will be convinced that the people, though with heterogeneous backgrounds, are, in fact, upto the challenge through their complete willingness to unite in a co-operative spirit to overcome petty jealousies, indifference, selfishness, suspicion and intolerance in the process of their growth into a single community, a single village. But the development in agriculture cannot follow merely through an ideology, it has to depend essentially on hard economic facts. That is the true test of Gramdan if we have to take Vinoba's manifesto on Gramdan in Kerala in all seriousness. Observers will expect an answer in deeds and no more in words, since on such experiment depends the future of the movement, of the country and of the people. But is Sarvodaya leadership conscious of it?

CHAPTER 14

Bhoodan as a Corrective

ON HIS way back from Nilambur, the visitor will do well to drop in at Nediyrippu, 20 miles to the south-east of Calicut and walk 2 miles to the west of the road asking for the 'Nediyrippu colony'. The road meanders through the plain paddy fields on to the steep hills covered with coconuts, areca and cashew-nut plantations till it abruptly ends and a wild waste faces you. The bleak foot path for another mile leads you on to a 'V' shaped valley with a small stream at the base and in the rising contours, the plantains, the young coconut plants and tapioca fields ascend to the abrupt tops almost 500 feet from the base.

A Wedge

The colony has a checkered history and is a proof of the corrective provided by Bhoodan to the cold bureaucratic set up immune to the social or economic change. The whole area of 750 acres was auctioned in 1953 by the then Madras Government of Malabar district for Rs. 3,800.00 only, *i.e.*, for Rs. 5.00 per acre. The deal was smelt by Shri Shyamji Sunder Das (member Sarvodaya Mandal) of Bhoodan Samiti of those days and he offered Rs. 5,000.00 to the Government with an understanding that he wanted to give the whole land in Bhoodan. After a year of deliberations the Government cancelled the auction deed and decided to distribute the land amongst 100 landless families. A committee for the purpose was formed

with the above named philanthropist as the member who assured the District Collector of his financial assistance to the extent of Rs. 5,000.00 but, as he got involved more than the six District Collectors who were transferred one after the other, he is stated to have invested Rs. 15,000.00 on the settlement by paying the amounts as subsidies for implements, huts, maintenance and seeds to the penniless settlers. The colony started with 27 Harijan families in 1954 with individual right on 4 acres for each family. A statutory body to draw the Government loans and grants for the colony became necessary and the Nidiyirippu Co-operative Agricultural Colonization Society, Ernad Taluk, Kozhikode district was thus registered in March, 1957.

Gramdan

Soon after, the grantees of land were prevailed upon by the said philanthropist and 60 out of 84 settlers signed their lands for Gramdan. As a result, the State Co-operative Department has honoured the sentiments of the settlers and declared the land of the colony to be the property of the co-operative and not of the individuals.

Rehabilitation

The settlers were landless Harijans, formerly squeezed to the marrow by the Moplah (Muslim) agricultural population of the neighbouring villages. Out of 84 houses in the colony, fifty-nine houses, each with 2 rooms and verandah with a tiled roof, have been constructed out of the State grants received as under :—

15 houses	Rs. 800.00 each,
14 houses	Rs. 650.00 each,
30 houses	Rs. 626.00 each

Seedlings for 25 coconuts and 25 areca-nut plants were supplied by the Government for every family. Grant of Rs. 3,000.00 has also come through the Tribal Welfare. Four drinking wells have been constructed out of grant of Rs. 600.00 for each. The contract for their construction has been with the Panchayat and not with the co-operative. The above

mentioned road, one mile five furlongs in length constructed by the Panchayat under Local Development Works, has been the cause of a scandal where Rs. 36,000.00 including the cost of 170 bags of cement are stated to have been spent but it leaves the unfortunate visitor halfway. The grantees never use this road, instead they have made a different footpath out of co-operative labour to approach the roadside market place, 1½ mile by this path, carrying the entire produce of tapioca, plantains and ginger on their heads to the doors of the Muslim traders-cum-moneylenders to whom the settlers are indebted. As a result, it is obligatory to sell the produce at 70 per cent of the market rate carrying the same to the door of the money-lenders who keep a strict watch on the crops.

Assistance

There is no producers' or consumers' store attached and no credit facilities flow to the colony. Primary educational facilities are also absent. One senior Co-operative Inspector attached to the colony looks to his own farm, two miles from here but draws his pay from the State. Out of the Government grants worth Rs. 37,000.00 for land reclamation, school building, and irrigation facilities, only Rs. 1,800.00 were spent and the balance lapsed. Marking and lining has been completed but bunding has not been carried out for soil conservation.

Harijan Sevak Sangh also has one employee attached to the colony to look to sanitation, adult education, and spinning. Paid Rs. 70.00 per month he too is competing with the co-operative inspector in idleness, it seems, at the cost of public expense.

The Strokes of the Pick-Axe

But a tremendous effort has been made by the individual settlers to smash the barrenness of the steep, rocky loamy soil to eke out their living. Their labour lost for centuries on others' farms has proved its mettle over the head of the callous rocks through the strokes of the pick axe. The able, efficient families earn Rs. 500.00 per annum. The lowest income is Rs. 200.00. Sale of firewood is an additional source of income. Entire agricultural operation is by hand, no animal power is used. The live-stock population can be counted on one's fingers.

5 Since exploitation through labour has been replaced by exploitation through trade and usury, one wishes that the trading genius of the said philanthropist could also come forward to organize co-operative credit, trade and marketing for the colony and see that the grants for soil conservation and other improvements of the colony are well invested through co-operative effort. He wields a good influence over the colonists and can show the way to the district authorities who in spite of a Communist regime can hardly lend their spirit to such experiments which do require some non-official and non-party interest. Now since the individual ownership has been replaced by co-operative ownership, it remains to be seen how Gramdan affects this colony. It is equally a challenge to the Co-operative Department of the State whose house also needs a re-ordering on that account.

CHAPTER 15

A Poor Show

IN THE northern parts of Kerala, 30 miles to the south of Mysore State border, in a comparatively dry, rugged and rocky terrain lies Paryaram, bearing an austere look devoid of Kerala's poetic charm. The area was under Madras State before November, 1956. The place is two to three hours' run from Cannanore by train *via* Payangadi or by bus *via* Telliparamba. Just beyond the state sanatorium stretches almost a contiguous area of 941 acres whose permanent occupancy rights were donated in Bhoodan in 1953 by a mill owner of Cannanore. In revenue records the estate is placed in two separate villages of Kadanpalli and Paryaram. After the Bhoodan Samiti, the Sarvodaya Mandal now pays a nominal annual rent to the supreme title holder — one Shri Nair. Only 218 acres divided in 3 acre plots have so far been distributed individually to 72 families out of which 13 families have so far turned up to settle; the rest do not find it worthwhile, it seems. 200 acres are almost uncultivable. 202 acres await distribution and 321 acres are under old tenants who do not cultivate anything but annually sell the standing grass for thatching. No information, however, was available about the disposal of grass growing abundantly on the Bhoodan estate.

Investments

In the first year Rs. 3,700.00 were spent on reclamation of 70 acres including a model farm of 6 acres where Rs. 800.00

were spent on housing, etc. The area falls under N.E.S. block which has built a 3 mile road to the estate through Bharat Sevak Samaj Camp organized for the purpose, it was stated. The N.C.C. (National Cadet Corps, Madras State) with 800 campers during a fortnight camp in 1956 did contour trenching over a limited area which cost Rs. 610.00. Land survey cost Rs. 333.00 and the sum of Rs. 2,100.00 is stated to have been spent on agricultural implements and Rs. 900.00 on a model farm of 6 acres mentioned earlier. Through N.E.S. Block staff there have been some silvicultural (casuarina) plantations on an area where contour trenching had been done by N.C.C. campers. Cashewnut and jackfruit plantation was also observed at places but was comparatively rare. The establishment charges from 1955 to 1957 have been Rs. 1,466.69 it was stated.

The Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh

The Nirman Samiti (Planning Committee) of the Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh appointed Shri Karanbhai, a Bhoodan leader of the United Provinces, to look to the development of Kerala Bhoodan lands. He visited the area in 1959 and drafted an ambitious plan with an outlay of Rs. 70,000 to one lakh. Near about sixty-five thousand rupees were sanctioned by the Sarva Seva Sangh but at long last, after a year or more of correspondence, only three thousand rupees came in the year 1958 which were spent on minor heads.

The Economy

The settlement has been on individual ownership basis on a 3 acre holding per family and spread out into a few pockets where land is comparatively easy to break. The settlers, 10 Harijans, 1 Marar (drum-beater in a temple) and 2 Nair families have been farm labourers or tenants in the neighbouring villages within 2 miles' radius. The plots of land do not yield full subsistence. Consequently, the grantees work partly on the neighbouring farms and pepper gardens. The soil is rocky and laterite, the general crops sown are plantains, tapioca, pepper and vegetables. The yield of paddy, sown by broadcasting for want of water and good soil, was reported as low as 100 lbs. per acre by the settlers fighting desperately for

subsistence on these tracts irresponsible to their labour for lack of capital and expert advice on land improvement, farm lay-out and crop planning. No debts are said to have been incurred by them to improve the lands broken bit by bit by hand labour out of implements provided by the Bhoodan Samiti. Some tools, including one spade, one pick-axe and one bucket to each grantee were donated through Shri Shyamji Sunder Das of Sarvodaya Mandal.

Out of 13 houses so far built on the estate, 8 houses got Government grants of Rs. 500.00 each from Harijan Welfare Board. Building material in the shape of timber came from the donor of the land. Bricks were laid by the grantees themselves who built the houses out of personal labour. A fresh grant of about Rs. 1,800.00 has been sanctioned for 3 more houses to be constructed through the Panchayat which is expected to take its own time for the execution of the work. Six drinking wells have also been dug costing Rs. 100.00 each on an average. One irrigation well was also seen under construction.

Settlers

Majority of the settlers bring up other people's calves on share basis on the estate which is a good pasture for the present. It is surprising why even such small capital for cattle breeding has not been extended to the settlers fighting a determined battle with the economic forces around them. Instead, spinning was taught to all of them and 25 charkhas distributed which have not so far yielded a single thread of yarn. Some families make some income out of mat-making for which the material is locally collected during summer months.

One Harijan grantee has two bullocks, two cows and a calf of his own. Prior to distribution he was illegally cultivating a few cents of the Bhoodan estates. He is a tenant to 2 acres of good land in his vicinity and does not go in for labour on others' fields.

Shri Shanker, the drum beater has comparatively improved his plot out of some remuneration from the temple. One Shri Kelappan has 4 acres under him, has a cow and a buffalo, sells milk to the sanatorium and makes a good living.

Amongst the 5 Harijan families with concrete houses in the Kadanpalli area, the husbands go for employment to Coorg in Mysore State, 30 miles from here and visit home only once in a month. Their wives, with famished faces, stay back marooned in these tiled houses while one person said to be a communist or a co-traveller, is said to have encroached on 6 cents' plot of Bhoodan land after the well-digging. A good crop of plantains stands there.

Observations

The person who is in charge of the whole settlement on behalf of the Sarva Seva Sangh and indirectly the Sarvodaya Mandal, Kerala, has not reported about this encroachment to authorities. For him, the State seems to have withered away and society is in the process of withering. His experimental farm of 6 acres in the estate is experiencing the tyranny of neglect after an investment of more than Rs. 1,500.00 and as such is of adverse demonstrative value to the grantees. As an employee of the Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh in Khadi work since 1938, he was deputed from Calicut in 1955 to take up the colonization work in these Bhoodan lands which are two to three miles from his place of residence and 5 miles from Khadi Vastralaya near Payangadi, the place of his duty where he reports almost every day. He visits the estate once in two months. Gramodyog Khadi Samiti sponsored by him for Khadi work amongst the grantees operated only for a short period and later shifted its headquarters to his residence at Valayancode.

Farm management is, in fact, very much different from Khadi work. As such, this gentleman, in charge of land development and settlement, seems to be a square peg in a round hole. Overloaded with his personal problems, he appears too old for the job. Although there is no possibility of the present settlers running away in spite of the cold, cantakerous nature of this gentleman, there is hardly any chance of more settlers being drawn into the estate. Sarvodaya Mandal too seems to practise '*laissez faire*' with its workers. There is a complete lack of interest and communication between the worker and the organization. Each goes his own

way and none bothers about the field work after it has been duly or unduly assigned to somebody.

Not only has the capital investment of about Rs. 10,000/- or more (excluding the housing grants) been haphazard, un-intensive, irregular and hence ineffective, the aspect of human handling too has been cruelly lacking. There appears to be enough scope for afforestation etc. (quite rich on the adjacent hills) and cashewnut plantation. With rich possibilities of dairying, poultry and vegetable gardening the sanatorium offers a good market for them. Only an integrated planning with the co-operation of experts can provide an incentive for settlement to the dissenting and diffident grantees. Deprived of capital, care and cordial advice, majority of the settlers tied to the land, unduly flutter to accomplish their dreams of honourable subsistence. In between, some whims of administration also give them a jolt. Previously, only the cultivated lands were taxable but, since the last year or so, every bit of land is taxed to the extent of Rs. 2.40 per acre. The revenue of the whole estate was paid by none. Consequently, the grantees who had paid the same for their own pieces of land were threatened for legal action till the matter was taken up by the Sarvodaya Mandal with the State Government and understanding was reached by which the title of ownership is not threatened in the case of undistributed Bhoodan lands.

The over-all condition of land is no better than it was in 1953 before it came under Bhoodan. It is deplorable that out of 29,021 acres of Bhoodan lands in Kerala only 2,126 acres have so far passed on to those hungry for land. As such Bhoodan appears a sanctified representative of Absentee landlordism. Colonization of landless on such lands will be impossible without the co-ordination of the activities of Sarvodaya Mandal with the state especially Kerala where party of the proletariat is holding the reigns of power. Nediyrippu colony is a mild pointer in that direction.

CHAPTER 16

The Trusteeship Concept

IN BHOODAN, the land passed on to be managed by Bhoodan Samitis or Sarvodaya Mandals but here at Vellinezhi one landlord Mr. Poduwal by writing away his lands in Gramdan has turned into a trustee or a manager of his farms. This lean thin gentleman wants to do on his 35 acres' fertile farm what Mr. Earnest Bader of Scot Bader Commonwealth Ltd. did in industry in England.

Getting down at Ottapalam Railway station, a few miles ahead of Palghat on way from Madras to Kerala, there is a 14 miles' rib-breaking bus journey to Vellinezhi due to compressed packing of about 60 passengers including ladies, children and old men in a bus with an authorized capacity of 26 passengers. Thereafter you walk one mile to Shri Poduwal's quiet spacious double-storeyed residence over-looking green paddy fields and a river. The host is a spiritually inclined gentleman blessed with 5 sons. It is indeed a happy home with each devoted to the others and all devoted to God—the Benevolent (see *Bhoodan*, Hindi Weekly dated 16-8-1957).

The Farm

From 1946 to 1953, Shri Poduwal was an active chairman of Producers' and Consumers' Co-operative Society but got his ancestral property divided and settled back in his village in 1953 building up his separate residence and finally surrendered the title to his lands etc. to Vinobaji on 13th June 1957.

During December 1958, his donated lands had the following crops etc. over an area shown against each.

Paddy	5 acres (double crop)
Paddy	3 acres (single crop)
Cotton	10 "
Cashewnut	4 "
Coconut	1 "
Homesteads	3 "
Waste (Under forest plantations)	9 "

The Participants

Seven families of farm labourers (5 Harijans and 2 Nairs) also signed for Gramdan in consultation with him and have contributed 1½ acre of waste land and half an acre of paddy land in all.

One of them has recently left the village to watch the property of his niece in another village. There are about 500 souls, young and old, affected by the experiment. All the 5 Harijan families used to be tappers for 4 months of a year from December to March. They have small house sites of 4 to 5 cents each with plantains, tapioca and vegetables grown therein. The plantains, are sold privately by them, so also the eggs and fowls. Each family has a number of goats; buffaloes have been added only after the new bonds were forged.

The Change

The poor families feel that their rich neighbour had some spiritual conversion by which he has accepted the new responsibility of looking after them. One great advantage told by these farm hands is the guarantee of employment, previously missing. Consequently, there has been reciprocal change amongst these members. "The estate is well looked after, so also the cattle. The intensity of labour has increased so also the yield," says Shri Poduwal who plans the entire lay-out and is an efficient farm manager with good farm equipment, sufficient bullock power and milch cattle. His persuasions to the neighbouring land-owners have resulted in maturizing a minor irrigation plan which will enable double cropping on quite a larger area.

These joining farm hands still feel that Shri Poduwal is the owner and not merely a manager or a trustee. But they are sure that Shri Poduwal will stick to his pledge of sharing the benefits out of the farm. They, in a way, own the whole farm mentally at this stage and prefer security of employment to the legal title on land with the exception of one gentleman who insists on demanding his share of land as if he had inherited it. Some interested parties seem to have twisted the mind of this poor fellow.

The farm hands, in addition to their wages in non-regular farm work of Re. 1.00 to 1.50, per day with meals, had 2 bags of paddy each from the first common crop, and in the second crop ending in February 1958 each family had 5 bags of paddy worth Rs. 100.00 or so. The manager had 210 bags. Farm accounting is not introduced. Everything is on a personal informal basis depending on the generosity and initiative of the Manager, who has read little about the technical aspect of co-operative farming. Nor has any light come from Sarvodaya leadership.

Observations

These farm hands still work on others' farms. The additional income flowing to the farm hands from this new relationship with land is not properly channelised. Some of them have invested their extra earning on he-buffaloes to plough others' fields on hire basis. Actually, it is a negative investment. As labourers they earn Re. 1.00 per day but as ploughmen, they will get Re. 1.50 and these poor animals with a life span of 5 years will hardly get work for one month out of a year according to their own statement. Such unplanned investment may further create problems for the joint management of the farm since no details have so far been worked out to channelise the increasing income and the labour power of these families. No standards or norms have been laid down for what belongs to the individual and what to the joint farm, what is to go annually to Shri Poduwal as farm manager and what is to be invested back on land improvement, equipment, or to the reserve funds. The co-operation, as such, is not comprehensive.

Another surprising contradiction is visible from Shri Poduwal's attitude to gramdan of 20 families of Harijans half a mile away from his farm. Indifferent to the dire needs of these poorest families he often employs heavily ornamented, well-dressed, well fed, non-Gramdan labour on his farm coming from one mile. Somewhat self-conscious about his benevolence he is living an isolated life and is fighting a lonely battle against the anti-social elements around him. He has a housing property worth Rs. 15000.00 in the commercial centre of the village but has an equal amount of payable debts. The critics feel that he has little right to keep apart a sum out of every crop to clear his debts.

Reversal of Priorities

Now a few words about a Gramdan of 20 Harijan families half mile away from the above mentioned farm.

The owner of these 3 acres of land gave it away in Gramdan to these Harijan families. It is here that the realities of Indian economy yell and stare in your face exposing the bankruptcy of ideologies, plans and priorities of politicians as well as social workers.

These mute, angelic figures of human flesh, deprived of barest clothing, subsistence and sympathy, are living an open condemnation of the plans of the provincial government and textile policies of the centre, which without caring to clothe these daughters of India lays down export target of 1,100 million yards of cloth by the end of 1961 to be produced through its seven and a half lakh textile mills and 20 lakh handlooms. These purest proletariat bring at times as wage a handful of rice to be cooked in the night and finished in the morn when famished dogs too share what their half-starved masters spare?

There was not even a rag to be seen on pegs, not a grain of rice in stock, nothing except the mud walls inside or outside the house. The bloom of youth comes here at 14 and old age follows at 24. A bride is had by paying Rs. 9.00 to her parent. Borrowings are on six naye paise per rupee per month i.e., 75 per cent interest per annum. 95 per cent income goes on food. Semi-starvation is a perpetual feature, unemployment guards the doors.

One out of these 20 families, has got a housing grant from the Communist Government while these muddy vestures of decay still drink water out of a muddy ditch. A well needs to be dug here to dump Nehru's socialist pattern, Morarji's textile policies, Communists' proletarian sympathies and Sarvodaya's concept of 'Anthyodaya' (Unto the last).

CHAPTER 17

Something Solid

Now LET us move to Malyadi pocket of Gramdams to meet Shri Velayudhan Pillai at his Gramdan Village Thacancode, 22 miles to the east of Trivandrum en route to Kallar. Salt of the earth, here is a person with practical and robust common sense who sincerely tries to maintain harmony in his thoughts, words and deeds. His growing convictions took him to the Ashrams of various saints in South India, made him work as a farmer, contractor and temporary hand in a Government sericulture farm till he turned a pacca socialist and finally, took to solid work in the field of co-operation based on reconstructive social idealism. Sarvodaya, to him, is an attitude toward living with the neighbours and is a concept too big to be confined to any formula. Sharing his land, savings and ability with his neighbours he is a whole time helper, friend and guide to them. His house presents the look of an active Public Relations Centre.

Sarvodaya Co-operative Society

Shri Velayudhan is the President of the Sarvodaya Co-operative Society registered in 1956 with 400 members and Rs. 3000.00 as paid up share capital. The Society pays for its own secretary who assists Shri Velayudhan Pillai at his separate rented office where Shri Pillai hammers people's problems into shapely activity, looks to their basic needs of credit and weeds out their unproductive demands. The Co-operative operates in five different spheres.

1. It deals in agricultural credit operations and has drawn an agricultural loan of Rs. 28000.00 from the District Co-operative Bank.

2. The Co-operative is now running a fair price rice depot with daily sale of Rs. 25.00 or so through a salesman paid on profit basis.

3. It finances and plans for the local cane industry supporting nearly 20 families.

4. It carries out soil conservation work in adjoining Gramdan units through coolies paid out of grants from Gandhi Smarak Nidhi.

5. It has evolved a concept of land army by organizing 20 farm hands and 10 petty landholders who offer Shramadan in Gramdan hamlets and get 3 meals a day out of the profits of the co-operative, public donations and grants from Gandhi Smarak Nidhi. Some people get a few plots to till, for one or two crops. This land army has, during the past 2 to 3 years, cultivated nearly 60 acres of land owned by small holders who lack resources and live on wages through unskilled labour. When invited by a village for road construction etc. this army is fed by the village. The president serves as a liaison between such villages and his land army is engaged in co-operative operations of different types.

Joint Farming

But Shri Velayudhan's major and more valuable contribution is his experiment in joint farming on 7 acres of paddy land owned by 15 families who have the working population of 40 members — 28 male and 12 female. There are 3 buffalo-pairs costing Rs. 600.00 jointly owned and maintained on the paddy straw of their own farm — surplus of it is sold in the neighbourhood. One member is in charge of maintaining these farm cattle and does this duty gratis.

The sowing in the first crop was by broadcasting due to lack of water. The second crop harvested in February, 1959 was sown through transplantation but not under Japanese method. Green manure, bone meal and farmyard manure were applied to it. The crop was found much better than the standing crops around.

The figures regarding the land, capital labour and yield distribution for the first crop were available which are detailed below. The dry land owned by the members is not pooled. The capital of Rs. 505.00 comes from the Sarvodaya Co-operative Society mentioned above and is drawn by the members individually. No rent or interest is paid by the joint farmer for the land or capital pooled through individual members. No wages are paid for the farm work. After deducting a part of the capital amount to be returned to the advancing members the rest of the yield is distributed on the basis of strength of family members. As such, out of a total yield of 5280 lbs., 1248 lbs. of paddy worth Rs. 213.00 were deducted and the rest i.e., 4032 lbs. were equally distributed among 72 members of 15 joining families at the rate of 56 lbs. per member irrespective of any other factor.

The following members have pooled the land, labour and capital etc. and distributed the yield as shown against their respective names. The last column of the table records the dry land kept out of the pool. (See page 107).

The study of the table shows the contribution of, and distribution to, each member, Shri Velayudhan Pillai invested half of the total capital and one-seventh of total land, did not put in any farm work and got as much as Shri Lucas who had no land, no capital but only the labour potential. Comparing Lucas to Shri Johnson who also did not have land or capital to contribute, the latter got 5.60 lbs. per work day and the former got 2.24 lbs. per work day. On the question that the present method may lower down the dignity of labour, Velayudhan had a prompt reply to offer. He remarked, "It will raise the dignity of human values which are more at stake than the dignity of labour. Members are expected to put in the best of their ability and co-operative is to look to their needs." He stated further, "Conscience will guide each member, not the material incentives. We seek light from life not from theories." These are the convictions which so far seem to work well in the practical management of this joint farming enterprise. It is indeed a triumph of the ceaseless service of Shri Velayudhan Pillai who has also launched another joint farming venture at Mathupuram, a Gramdan one mile away from here where 9 families have

Table : FIGURES ABOUT JOINT FARMING AT THACHANCODE

The joint family	No. of family members	Land pooled acres	Capital advanced	Work days put in	Share of crop received in			Unpooled dry lands in acres
					lbs.	mds.	srs.	
1 Velayudhan Pillai	6	1.00	250	—	336	4	4	3.50
2 Bhagwati Amma	6	.30	50	120	336	4	4	1.50
3 Kalyani Amma	3	.30	10	100	168	2	2	1.50
4 Parmu Pillai I	6	.70	25	180	336	4	4	1.00
5 Siva Shankar Pillai	5	.50	60	120	280	3	17	3.00
6 Rajamma	3	.25	—	50	168	2	2	.50
7 Lucas	6	—	—	150	336	4	4	1.50
8 Krishnan	4	.30	—	60	224	2	30	1.00
9 Kuttan Pillai	6	.80	—	120	336	4	4	1.25
10 Parmu Pillai II	7	.50	—	50	392	4	32	0.50
11 Kumar Pillai	3	.84	50	100	168	2	2	2.50
12 Raghavan Pillai	3	.33	—	50	168	2	2	.40
13 Parameswaran Pillai	4	.35	—	50	224	2	30	.20
14 Madhavan Pillai	6	.80	60	120	336	4	4	1.75
15 Johnson	4	—	—	40	224	2	30	—
Total	72	6.97	505	1310	4032	49	11	20.10

joined their hands and heads on a 3 acre paddy land where members jointly own a buffalo pair, go by turns to the farm work and have distributed the yield according to the number of family members.

Here is a beginning on a sound footing but there are 873 families who are signatories to Gramdan in the vicinity. Poverty in the area is equally well-entrenched, birth-rate is appallingly high. Inertia is rampant amongst people. A rubber estate of

one Shri M. K. Thomas, 3 miles from here, offers employment to the people from March to December on a daily wage of Rs. 1.50 per male and Re. 1.00 per female worker. The population faces rigours of unemployment from December to March. Another Co-operative — Vinoba Gramdan Sarvodaya Co-operative Society with 45 members has recently been registered with its office at Vinoba Niketan $\frac{1}{2}$ mile from here with Shri Velayudhan Pillai as the Secretary of the same.

It is an uphill task but youthful Pillai is equally fired with firm faith in co-operation which according to him is the cradle of economic social and actual democracy. He is quite hopeful of better days for the co-operative community organisation which seems to be the life mission of this hard boiled gentleman now paid Rs. 100.00 (as a Gram Sahayak) by the Khadi Commission for his selfless work in the villages. For the last 2 years till the end of 1957, the Gandhi Smarak Nidhi paid him an honorarium for the devoted service to the villages in the Malayadi pocket.

That is all about the co-operative land management in Gramdan villages. No other Gramdan village throughout Kerala is involved in land distribution or co-operative land management. Now in the next part we will proceed to study other approaches on trial in Gramdan villages.

PART 4

In Cottages

CHAPTER 18

The Wedge

As **THE** steel horse fumes and trots on its rail track from Calicut on to Kaladi, there rushes a coconut-dominated reel of shifting scenes with Kerala's simple citizenry busy on its river banks, rowing, fishing, swimming and washing. Kiddies blink through the shady homesteads while inmates are busy at coconut or copra. The school going children jig over the footpaths lining over the bunds of the green paddy fields. There are no straying cattle to be seen as far as the eye can reach.

Then as you approach within ten or twelve miles radius of Kaladi (Angamali Railway station)* the spirals of the churches start rising in the zirth place of Shankaracharya – the great Vedanta philosopher. British missionary Mr. Mateer and his colleagues seem to have lavishly 'planted' their 'fruitful cases in the spiritual desert and the moral waste of India.'

As a result, 35 per cent of the Indian Christians are in Kerala. Insignificant in the north of this coastal state they are probably in majority in these regions. Obviously, the dwindling pennies of poor Swami Agamanand of Ramakrishna Mission at Kaladi to rebut the Christian influence are vainly fighting the regularly reinforced pounds and dollars from abroad whose annual sums to India are equal to the total amount of Gandhi Smarak Nidhi (Gandhi National Memorial Fund) which has chosen to work out one Gramdan centre here at Naduvattam 4 miles from Kaladi.

* The site of firing during the Deliverance struggle.

The Christian heads in spite of their public declaration in support of Gramdan movement smell some Trojan horses in it. While Christians abroad have been bold enough to declare Gandhiji as the only Christian after Christ, highbrows of the local churches with their confused loyalties look down upon Father Mullaseri of Naduvattam due to his strong support to the Gramdan Movement based upon Gandhian principles and led by one of Gandhiji's most devoted disciples, (Vinoba). These doubting Messiahs have been doubly surprised, perhaps, by Shri P. C. Oommen's choice of having selected this area for Gramdan follow-up work.

P. C. Oommen

Shri P. C. Oommen, a thorough-bred Christian gentleman aged 43, hails from Trivandrum and his mother comes from a family which is Christian since the last 43 generations, it is stated. A teacher from 1933 to 1946, he was almost all in all in a Handloom Co-operative Society from 1946 to 1951. Later, his services were taken up by Gandhi Smarak Nidhi of Kerala as a Chief Organiser of Japanese methods of paddy cultivation from 1952 to 1955, then as a Gram Sevak at Shastavattam in Trivandrum district till he took up his present assignment at Naduvattam — his headquarters for Gramdan follow-up work in Kaladi pocket.

Deeply devoted to the personality and social philosophy of Vinoba he explains the growth of Kaladi Gramdans with his typical frankness. "Since the impact of Sarvodaya Session was there on the people no necessity arose for propaganda. Only assurances had to be given for regular employment through Ambar, Cottage industries and other development programmes. For that, Shri Gopal Pillai was quite efficient and he could collect a large number of signatures from the area with the help of Shri M. N. Karunakar — a gentleman brought up in Swami Agamanand's Ashram — now employed as a Branch Manager of Forest Industries Travancore (FIT) at Neeleshwaram 2 miles from here."

Not discouraged by what has been done by the victims of 'Targetosis' Shri Oommen feels, "Gramdan is a contract between Vinoba and the people and it must be honoured." He

visualizes further, "Even though the poorest strata from all the communities have been recruited in Gramdan, there is a moral force working in the psychology of the people which is gradually unifying for a solution to their common problems."

Peculiarities of the area

The pocket of 123 Gramdan units spread within the radius of 8 miles from Kaladi in 54 rural denominations of Alwaye and Kunnathunad talukas of Ernakulam district, covers 2,562 families of all the various communities in the area. The main crops are paddy, tapioca, pepper, rubber, cashewnut, coconut, lemon grass and ginger. The economy is in the hold of middlemen mostly traders-cum-moneylenders who advance money on the standing crops and buy them a few months earlier at 30 per cent less than the market price. The money is advanced much beyond the immediate needs of the people. If the producer is a drunkard he is taken to the toddy shop to blur whatever little intelligence he has with him, with an eye on the maturing pepper or paddy crop. This trader-cum-moneylender coils around the producer who is advanced Rs. 40.00 even if his immediate need be Rs. 10.00 to finish up his independence. Rich peasants also take to moneylending and enjoy the economic mopping of the people.

The state managed lift irrigation by pumping the river water into channels is in vogue for the last 15 years. Small percolation wells are also commonly used by small farmers who use man power to draw big cans out of them through lever system and are heard counting the buckets loudly, keeping in view the number of cans the particular plot requires. Generally, the farmer and his wife are seen working together at such lever appliances where the can tied at the top of the bar comes up by the sheer weight tied at its base. Only dipping needs pressure through man power.

Fertilizers are not popular, green leaves from the forest are used as manure. The average yield per acre per year through double crop is 16 maunds of paddy out of which the tenant to the owner pays 4 maunds but parts with 8 maunds if he is a sub-tenant. Hired bullock power is generally in use costing Rs. 3.00 per work day including the plough men. Farm

labourers are generally paid in kind costing about 62 to 94 nPs. with two meals a day (costing 37 nPs.).

The Bamboo Industry

Next to agriculture, bamboo industry is the mainstay of the people here and is a rich source of exploitation by those who can invest in it; the industry is strangled right from the bamboo cutting in the forest to the export of the mats. The wholesalers are without exception the men with cars and bungalows.

The forest runs parallel to the coast in Kerala. The forest department issues a permit for Rs. 6.75 per thousand bamboos. The cutter spends his days and nights in the forest, fells the bamboos, bundles them up into rafts of 25 each, floats them down the river to be stacked at the catchment point down the river. Transported to the working village, it is issued to the workers who prepare mats at home and earn about 19 to 25 nPs. per day on an average. The mats are collected by the investor at his trading office, packed into the truck and sent to the nearest Railway station whence they move to the big cities like Bombay.

40 man-work days are generally paid Rs. 120.00 per raft of 1,000 bamboos from the forest. But since it involves coming, going, camping and working, the cutter hardly gets Rs. 1.00 per day in spite of the risks involved in the forest life during nights.

The Wedge

Shri Oommen had seen that, in spite of Ambar training in the village prior to his arrival in July, 1958, the Ambar had totally failed to attract the working hands in need of employment. He was no more crazy about Charkha and wanted to see what could actually click to socially and emotionally integrate the people and help them economically to boot. He went round the people's homes entered into their hearts, saw the deep sores and also found deep potentialities of co-operation if he could plunge into the jungle of bamboo trade infested with wild exploiters. He found the bamboo cutters unemployed, mat weavers strangled by the heartless agents of the big magnates of bamboo trade. After a thorough study of the tricks of the trade followed by a deep self-search he found the due strength forthcoming from within and stood up not alone but

along with the whole village assembly which discussed the issue for weeks together sitting upto midnights studying its own strength and fears against the vested interests entrenched deep in the trade for the last so many generations and decades. "They would show forged accounts of advances against us," said one. "They will hardly allow freedom to us, their perpetual slave," said another. "There will be no permits from the forest department and there will be all possible hurdles and harassments if we ventured to go in independently," voiced another. All these fears were true but something had to be done. So an "Erra Committee" (Erra i.e., Bamboo) of 3 members was selected. Permit in the name of Gram Sabha was had and the work started in right earnest. But as the first raft touched on the catchment post down the river, one Shri Pappu a small agent of big major interests in trade held up the raft on the plea that one Shri Oosef — a bamboo cutter owed him some money. It was nothing surprising for the members of the community who had taken the decision in the presence of the agents of vested interests. They knew it. It was trial of strength between peaceful co-operation and guilty individual interests who considered themselves as exploiters both by right and by inheritance.

The village assembly headed by Shri Oommen held a meeting at the spot where the bamboo rafts lay held up. The exploiters were also invited to the meeting who all came completely drunk. But when they found the whole community solidly united and firm like a rock but polite, they signalled the big crocodiles to rush in for a compromise. The colours of the mental skies changed. The compromise was easily reached by nominating an impartial committee of a few members to look into the case of the said debt. The committee, as was expected, found that the debtor had paid much more than he actually owed. The Gram Sabha buried the dead past beside that river bank to start a fresh era of triumphant and progressive co-operation in the community life of Naduvattam — said to be the most conscious village in the whole pocket of Kaladi Gramdams where community co-operation is an established fact now. It has covered many more milestones ahead.

Roughly, 720 mats (6 ft. by 4 ft. each) made out of 1,000 bamboos bring Rs. 120.00 to the bamboo cutters and Rs. 60.00 to the mat weavers. The venture ensures regular daily income of Re. 1.00 to 30 Harijan bamboo cutters and 37 nPs. per day to nearly 50 mat-weaving families. The wholesalers take delivery straight from Gram Sabha sales depot at the rate of Re. 0.30 nP. per mat bringing profit of 5 nP. (10%) per mat to the Gram Sabha which deals with the mat-weaver and the cutter in coupons to be handed over at the Gram Sabha provision store forming another complementary activity of the Gram Sabha.

A fool-proof chit system has been introduced through the ingenuity of Shri Oommen whereby each dealing member of this robustly growing community knows what he or she has earned, what lies in deposit with the Sabha or what advance he or she owes to the Sabha to-date.

Out of the profits (10 per cent) on investment of Rs. 500.00 in bamboo trade one worker managing the depot and the book-keeping side is paid Rs. 37.50 p.m. Rs. 5.00 goes as rent for the depot. But self respect and self-confidence born out of the venture are the real though invisible profits that the members of the community talk proudly of.

The Provision Store

The provision store forms an organic part of the community life of the 160 Gramdan families of Naduvattam. Raised in a building rented for Rs. 6.00 per month, with an initial investment of Rs. 500.00 from Gandhi Smarak Nidhi, it deals in rice, food grains, spices, sugar, salt, soap, kerosene, coconut, coconut-oil, Khadi, matches, pulses, onions, bananas, papers and pencils and has been instrumental in closing down 2 private shops since its active dealing with the people.

For things sold or wages earned the coupons issued by the Gram Sabha are valid to draw on the provision store. The salesman deposits hard cash plus coupons with the cashier. Accounting side is personally looked into by Shri Oommen. No share money has come from the people. The management is in the hands of 3 illiterate but honest members of the Gram Sabha who adjust with the market and pay Rs. 37.50 to the

salesman keeping a little margin of profit for the Gram Sabha. These committee members of the Gram Sabha make the purchases; the salesman takes charge without weighing. There is an effective dependability and trust among the responsible persons. For large scale purchases the salesman goes to Trichur closing the store for a day.

The store accounting is not introduced. There is no ledger folio system for each item to indicate its details of purchase, sale, profit or loss. Monthly stock-taking of each item determines the profits, etc. Average daily sale is Rs. 30.00.

Monthly Trial Balances are not introduced. Only Rs. 100.00 have been floated for the purchase of pepper. Funds have not been forthcoming for the much needed purchase and marketing of the village produce to further salvage the village economy from the clutches of the middlemen and effect more positive polarisation between the economically unsocial elements and the co-operative efforts of the people.

Gram Sabha

The Gram Sabha consisting of 8 members, each representing 20 families wins immense confidence from the people and stands solidly united, thereby effecting a closer emotional integration amongst the people by weekly meetings to discuss the current problems facing the community life. The Gram Sabha looks equally to the human needs of the community. It incurred expenses for admitting two poor fellow beings to the hospital helping them financially for treatment of some chronic trouble they were suffering from.

Two spirited young men Shri Pappu and Joseph have been greatly instrumental in activising the centre. One buffalo-pair owned by the Gram Sabha purchased out of Rs. 200.00 advanced by the Gandhi Smarak Nidhi partially serves the needs of the farming operations of the community. These animals are maintained by Shri Joseph who keeps the account of their maintenance and the wage earned by them. They get work for 7 days in a month and are a source of monthly loss of Rs. 11.00 it was stated. Out of members of Gram Sabha none owns land more than 20 cents. Gramdan so far does not touch

the land management since, generally, one Gramdan member goes as a wage earner to another member's farm.

Resting on his Oars

Shri Oommen has undoubtedly been felt as a force by the surrounding elements. Cars of big trade magnates do stop to have a complimentary chat with him. But there is some undue complacency visible in him of which he too is conscious. The overall statistical and accounts side of the centre needs stream-lining. The grants sanctioned for buildings etc. need be spent for a better living, the present residence of this gentleman being worse than a slum. His attitude towards departmental 'co-operation' is unfortunately one of indifference. He seems to have lost faith in official approach to co-operation probably due to his bitter experiences in a handloom co-operative society for a number of years in the past.

Farming needs face lift. His knowledge and experience of Japanese method of paddy cultivation has yet to be brought to use. Marketing needs handling through the Gram Sabha for which Gandhi Smarak Nidhi has to be persuaded to modify its policy of investments in the rural sector. The work has to take extensive shape now after the intensive phase of emotional integration is almost over and people have rallied round the worker i.e., Mr. Oommen.

The lady worker Kumari T. Leela who came into the Sarvodaya fold after her intermediate studies in 1955 and got training in Basic Education in Sevagram for 2 years from 1955 to 1957 is unfortunately not yet applying her mind to the work amongst ladies and children. Her talent could be utilized better at Akkunnam, a Gramdan village half a mile away amongst the poor potters' families who need sisterly care and emotional warmth more than anything else at this stage.

On the whole a right start has been made to shape the community life in a corporate pattern where weekly and fortnightly folk dances further enrich the community life when, after the Parisha Mutta Kalli or Villadi Champat dance, the dancers beating the drums, cymbals and the bow strings tied with trinkets, along with the audience, sing in chorus :

*Cheram Cheram Nattarey
Cheruk Cheruk Namonnaye
Verey Verey Nin Ini Arum
Nerey Akan Nokenda*

(Rally Rally Oh countrymen!
Join Join and be together,
No prosperity nor smooth life
By living apart, oh brother!)

CHAPTER 19

A Contrast

THE KALADI pocket, sprinkled over by 123 Gramdan units covering 2,562 families spread over in a radius of 8 miles around Kaladi, is also approached by the Kerala Khadi Board through a Gramdan Sarvodaya Co-operative Society registered on 24th March 1958 and duly certified by the Khadi Commission. The work is carried out under the patronage of Shri Ikkanda Warriar — a member of the Sarvodaya Mandal as well as the Kerala Khadi Board.

This Gramdan Sarvodaya Co-operative Society has its headquarters at Neeleshwaram two miles from Naduvattam — the Gram Nirman Kendra of Gandhi Smarak Nidhi discussed in the last chapter. The rented spacious lonely building belonging to Shri Narayan Dharam Paripalana Yoga — a sectional Hindu organization of Idavas (Thiyyas) accommodates the society's office, an Ambar training centre and Ambar workshop raised in September 1958 in a temporary shed in the courtyard. The landscape around is beautiful, the river Pariyar is a few furlongs from here.

The Membership

The society has 54 members constituting 2 per cent of the total Gramdan families in the area. The occupation-wise and village-wise strength of the members is given below :—

The members come mostly from Nadivattam and Cheranalur but still 9 per cent of the contiguous Gramdan units are

<i>Occupation-wise strength :</i>		<i>Village-wise strength :</i>	
Bamboo workers	16	Naduvattam	25
Farm labourers	16	Cherannalur	22
Farmers	10	Malayatur	2
Sarvodaya workers	5	Neeleeshwaram	2
Merchants	4	Kovapadi	1
Driver	1	Manjappa	1
Bidi worker	1	Nayathodi	1
Tea stall owner	1		
TOTAL :		TOTAL :	54

represented therein. The members belong to all the different castes of the area. There are Brahmins, Nairs, Edavas (Thiyyas) Christians, Pulliyas and Harijans. Out of all the 54 members, only 5 own between 1 to 2½ acres, the rest i.e., 49 have land below one acre.

The Managing Committee has the following members.

1. President (Non-member)
Shri M. N. Karunakar
2. Member—Shri T. G. Divakaran
3. Member—Shri Pappu
4. Member—Shri V. U. Krumban
5. Member—Shri A. K. Joseph
6. Member—Shri Damodaran Nair
7. Secretary—Shri Radhakrishnan

Branch Manager of the Forest Industries Travancore (FIT) at Neeleeshwaram
 Motor driver of Malayatur
 Assistant to Mr. Oommen at Naduvattam in Bamboo work
 A coolie with 20 cents of land from Cherannalur
 A student from Manjappa
 A coolie from Nayathodi
 A young social worker from Neeleeshwaram

The Finance

The total share money collected by the end of 1958 was said to be roughly Rs. 300.00. The share is of Rs. 10.00 to be paid in 20 monthly instalments of 0.50 nPs. each.

The Provincial Khadi Board has granted Rs. 12,000.00 for the various activities to be launched in the area on the basis of the Society's resolutions passed through the meetings directed and conducted by the Khadi Board personnel. Two general meetings and eleven managing committee meetings held in 1958 starting from 24th March 1958 have asked for the aids and grants from Khadi Board for the following items :

1. Hand Pounding of paddy,
2. Ambar unit,
3. Bamboo mats,
4. Village oil,
5. Godowns,
6. Workshop,

The Ambar

So far Ambar alone has been taken up. The Ambar training, started in June 1958, had trained 157 trainees by the end of 1958. The Ambar workshop was installed in September 1958. The cotton bales are produced from the Industrial Estate, Ollor, 35 miles from here. 500 weavers in the non-Gramdan area within these Gramdan units are stated to be working on mill yarn procured through the weavers' own 'Changamnad Co-operative Society' which also manages the sale of cloth produced by its members. They may be persuaded to use Ambar yarn, it is stated.

The Training Staff

The training staff in Ambar consists of 8 ladies and 2 gents paid Rs. 60.00 each. In addition, there are 2 field supervisors with the same pay. The total establishment charges are roughly Rs. 750.00 including Rs. 25.00 the monthly rent for the building. The workshop is electrified. One lathe is working on electric power.

The funds have also been made available for soap and pottery units by the Khadi Board, it was stated.

Twelve persons have been sent from this area in June 1958 to Khadi Commission's Kora Kendra, Bombay for one year's training as Gram Sahayaks.

Observations

There seems little enthusiasm amongst the people about this pre-fab structure by Khadi Board. For lack of popular zeal and initiative, the venture seems soulless and can hardly be called a people's own programme. In Ambar only middle class people came for training. Nairs who have some vain pride of high class stock find it helpful to prop up their tottering economy through Ambar and find it convenient to train up their women folk in that. The lower-class folk, it was told, work in the forest since it brings better wages than Ambar can assure. Khadi Board people, it appears, don't feel like studying the local conditions but have the same ready-made solutions for all places and people. Nobody has cared to study why Ambar failed in Naduvattam and bamboo industry succeeded. But with directives from above and blinds over their own eyes the zealots of Ambar seem to be pursuing their whims with little mercy for the public finance and little attention to the real public cause. It seems, they did not find time within one year to walk two miles to Akkunnam — a Gramdan hamlet of Naduvattam — and see the plight of 20 potter families whose wares, deprived of marketing facilities, occupy whatever little space they have in their half-dilapidated huts (12 ft. x 12 ft. in size) which present the look of a flood and famine stricken area. There is nothing to be called a house. There is no work, no grain. Above that, the owner of site of these unfortunate huts is using all the harassing tactics to eject these poor half-starved souls who, perhaps, do not know that they could be fed and housed better in jail than by working on an honest vocation in this wretched country.

Beyond this centre, the usual drift prevails in the rest of the Gramdan villages which lie abandoned like illicit children born in the flush of the moment under the frenzy of 'Targetosis'.

Now we move over to the study of the experimental area in Krumbranad.

CHAPTER 20

The Experimental Area

TWELVE MILES rail or bus journey north of Calicut along the typical Malabar coast where blue Arabian Sea often flashes through the green feathery coconuts — brings you to the Experimental Area of Gramdan follow-up work. It was in this pocket that the Sarvodaya workers, orators and leaders landed with full force for 4 to 5 months after Vinoba's departure. Shri Kelappan had his Padyatra here. Gandhi Smarak Nidhi had its camps and campaigns. Shri R. K. Menon of Ramnath-kara came with his students and drama squads. Smt. A. K. Rajamma preached here her gospel of Gramdan. Shri M. P. Manmathan, Principal, Mahatma Gandhi College, Trivandrum, — the star orator for the movement — addressed huge gatherings in the area. As a result of the above there were 214 Gramdans netted in this pocket involving 4691 families covering 8.9 per cent of the total population of Quilandy taluka.

Agencies

Various agencies have stepped in to shoulder the responsibility of intensive development work to evolve a prospective pattern of rural development under the impact of Gramdan. The main approaches have been through the Intensive Area Scheme, Kerala Khadi Board, Gandhi Smarak Nidhi and Gramodyog Khadi Sangh, the last two being non-official agencies. In all the four agencies, the work is carried out under the close collaboration of Sarvodaya leadership and Sarvodaya workers in advisory or organizational capacity.

The N.E.S. Block is also active in a part of the area and is remotely committed to the development of Gramdan villages under the co-ordination plans for Gramdan and Community Development arrived at the top level conferences at Yelwal and Delhi. A few pages have been devoted to that approach also.

All the five approaches have been discussed separately. There were other stray efforts at 4 or 5 places in the area by Sarvodaya workers mostly through the Gramdan Co-operative Societies financed by the Kerala Khadi Board. But they were either quite in a premature stage or just similar to the cases taken up for study under Kerala Khadi Board (at Pantalayini) which is quite representative of such efforts.

The experimental area extends upto the whole of Quilandy taluk which is spread out in 292 square miles and has a population of 292,883 persons.

The crop statistics of the taluk for 1957-58 shown below in descending order of their acreage throw some light on its agrarian economy.

<i>Crop</i>		<i>Acreage</i>	<i>Crop</i>		<i>Acreage</i>
1.	Coconut	56117	11.	Betal vines	606
2.	Rice	35952	12.	Red grams	528
3.	Areca	6732	13.	Turmeric	411
4.	Pepper	5945	14.	Lemon-grass	350
5.	Tapioca	3958	15.	The rest	1210
6.	Rubber	3818		(pulses, ragi	
7.	Mango	2510		chillies	
8.	Cashewnut	1880		tamarind etc.	
9.	Vegetables	1310			
10.	Ginger	786			
TOTAL ACREAGE :					122113

This area is perhaps the biggest coir supplier to the world market. As one journeys along the road one finds coir spinning going on almost in every house. The industry is not within the orbit of Khadi and Village Industries Commission. There is a Coir Board, a separate central body for it. The

co-ordination between the Coir Board and the Khadi and Village Industries Commission has not been tried. From the working of the industry in the field, the said Central Coir Board seems to be a white elephant staying in some ivory towers. The whole industry is managed by middlemen as stated earlier. These individual investors advance for conversion into yarn say 15 lbs. of fibre, declaring it as 12 lbs. and invariably cheat the worker by 3 lbs. of yarn converted free of labour charges.

Fishing

This being a coastal area, fishing is another prominent feature of the economy but fishermen are mere coolies to the investors in the industry which requires an initial investment of nearly Rs. 6000.00. One boat costs Rs. 500.00 to Rs. 1000.00 but generally 2 boats with a team of 16 fishermen launch the operation. There are separate nets required for sardine and mackerel etc. After the catch, fish is sold by middlemen under the prices fixed by the top investor. Only 50% remains with the fishermen each of whom is indebted to the extent of Rs. 500.00 during the stormy season when there is no operation allowed by the unwieldy sea. As a result fisherman falls a victim to the 'big fish' and lives in perpetual slavery, almost.

Weaving

Along with coir, weaving is the second most popular cottage industry in this area. The shuttle beat in the houses is heard often by the passer-by. The inmates are seen winding the thread or working at a few looms in such houses for plain cotton cloth woven out of mill yarn procured through their own co-operatives which also manage the marketing of production. Replacement of mill yarn was told to be the primary incentive to launch here the Mudadi Intensive Area Scheme which is taken hereafter for discussion.

(A) THE MUDADI INTENSIVE AREA SCHEME

The headquarters of the Mudadi Intensive Area Scheme lies at the 20th milestone from Calicut on the Bombay Cape Comorin highway. The Intensive Area stretches north-south from the 17th to the 22nd milestone. It covers the following

villages with area and population shown against each. The Gramdan families in each village are shown in the last column.

Jurisdiction of the Mudadi Intensive Area.

Village	Population	Area	Gramdan families
1 Mudadi	6,560	3.81 acres	66
2 Viyoor	7,486	6.48 „	194
3 Vanmukham	3,456	1.98 „	44
4 Parakad	3,038	1.71 „	42
5 Tikkoti	3,471	1.24 „	42
6 Pallikara	2,482	1.79 „	280
	26,493	17.01 „	668

The density of population is 1558.2 per sq. mile Land per capita is .41 acres. The Gramdan population of 4,000 persons forms 15 per cent of the residents of the Intensive Area.

Mudadi is the native village of Shri Kelappan, Chairman of Sarvodaya Mandal. He, as an M.P., was instrumental in getting this area included under the scheme and is the Honorary Organiser since the start of the operation of the scheme. With Mudadi Kshetra Samiti registered on September 4, 1955 under the Charitable Societies Act, the scheme was inaugurated by Shri J. P. Narayan during the same year.

The Co-ordination

The Headquarters of the Intensive Area with construction costs at Rs. 75,000.00 lie just on both sides of the national highway in the limits of Tikkoti village. The Gramdan office of Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal was lodged here for about a year from October 1957 to September 1958 till it shifted to noisiest parts of Calicut, 20 miles from here. The Gandhi Smarak Nidhi's youth camp held here during Vinoba's Kerala tour resulted in 21 Gramdan units which were offered to Vinoba on his arrival here. The staff of the Intensive Area Scheme went whole house into the campaign, it is stated.

The buildings

The Intensive Area headquarters accommodate the office of the Mudadi Kshetra Samiti, the office of the Organiser

Mudadi Intensive Area, Khadi Godown and main Khadi centre, Community Production Centre, Workshops for general, Ambar and Ghani sections, Sales Depot and Show Room and Demonstration and Production Centre for soap and oil industries.

Besides, there is a sub-centre also at Machchu Kunnu (sub-village under Mudadi Ansham) 3 miles from here which has pottery production centre, oil pressing unit for non-edible oils, hand pounding of rice and village industries godown.

There is a cottage match factory in a rented building at Vellarkad (sub-village of Mudadi) and a coir production centre in a thatched shed at Mannamangalam (sub-village of Viyoor). The general Saranjam workshop is said to manufacture traditional Charkhas, looms, spinning and weaving accessories, village industries equipment and caters to the needs of the Basic Training Schools and N.E.S. Blocks of the Taluk.

Ghani Saranjam Workshop manufactures Wardha type and Kallupatti type Ghanis and other accessories. Ambar workshop manufactures Ambar charkhas, Belnis, dhunia modhia, accessories etc.

The other activities carried by the Intensive Area seem to be the milk distribution amongst children at certain village centres, building houses and digging wells for Harijans out of Government grants.

The Staff

The present staff employed at the Intensive Area headquarters drains Rs. 12000.00 annually as pay from the Khadi Commission. The Organiser and Assistant organiser annually draw Rs. 2700.00 and Rs. 2040.00 respectively. The rest goes to 6 workers engaged in Khadi and other supervisory posts. Khadi workers are said to have been reduced from 8 to 4, perhaps for lack of output or under the provisions of the Scheme. There was much grumbling going on over that issue.

The Kshetra Samiti headed by Shri Kelappan consists of 8 members out of which 3 are teachers, the other four are said to be of social bent of mind.

General Performance

The main stress of work seems to be on Khadi. The cotton for spinning comes from Tiruppur in Tamilnad. Khadi Commis-

sion is said to be the sole procurer. 81 Ambars were distributed in October '57 to equal number of trainees after training in 4 groups. In March 1958, only 3 Ambars were stated to be active, giving only 120 hanks per month. 20 Ambars have come back to the headquarters, the rest lay safe in the corners of the houses. No servicing was done at home by the staff. Neither were the local blacksmiths or carpenters trained to look to minor repairing nor did training equip the trainee to handle the mechanism of Ambar. The instructors, paid a monthly salary of Rs. 50.00, went over to more remunerative jobs elsewhere. 3 hanks, instead of the required 6 or 8, was the output of each trainee when the training was terminated. For full one year Ambar was a dead investment. Unfortunately, the best spinners are also stated to have thrown Ambar into the lumber till on October 2, 1958, one month's refresher course given to 10 spinners from Nair families of Machukunnu is said to have activated at least 10 charkhas there which now yield 500 hanks per week, it was told. The rates of payment are graded as under according to the weekly output targets.

<i>Output per week</i>	<i>Payment per hank</i>
Below 30 hanks	17 nP.
30 to 50 hanks	19 nP.
50 and above	20 nP.

The spinner is stated to have stuck to Kisan Charkha wherein he or she earns 15 nP. per hank for spinning. Ambar brings 9 nP. per hank for spinning. The total disbursement of wages for Kisan and Ambar spinning both was told to be roughly Rs. 500.00 p.m. with an average monthly production of 5000 hanks out of which 3200 hanks are locally supplied to 16 weavers who produce roughly 800 yards of cloth. The remaining 1800 hanks are sent to Salem district in Madras state for weaving in Gandhi Ashram Trichangode. 8 weavers trained by the Intensive Area centre have taken to mill yarn, it was stated. The working, on the whole, is uninspiring and discouraging.

The consolidated figures for 1957-58 could not be made available due to some official bottle-necks but those for 1956-57

are enough to show the inner working of the Intensive area which, it seems, has not made any progress during the year. Rather there seem to be possibilities of retardation of the process. The total wage payment in the Intensive area was to the extent of Rs. 27514.00 against Rs. 15000.00 as the salary of the staff. Production was valued at Rs. 50218.00. Sales amounted to Rs. 28,091.00. On production side, Khadi stood at Rs. 27,773.00 and general Saranjam at Rs. 11,363.00. Coir, rice hand-pounding, oil, soap, etc., were valued at Rs. 11,082.00. About work in the villages the conditions are equally pathetic.

Pallikara

Pallikara whose economic survey was carried out by the Intensive Area staff has not experienced any change for the better. The signatories, softened by house to house canvassing carried three to four times, seem to have signed for Gramdan with not much hope or optimism but with an attitude to see if anything could come out of it and also under the hope that the Intensive Area Scheme might prove more effective to improve their economic lot. This is the consensus of opinion held by the villagers in general. Devoid of self reliance and hope for economic survival they seem to have compromised with the drift.

Twenty persons who had land between 4 to 15 acres knowing later that they will have to share their lands with others have demanded the cancellation of their Gramdan pledge.

Before Gramdan, 125 Kisan Charkhas were plying, now the number has shrunk to 30 and that too amongst those families who are quite active at other skills of coir and handicrafts. Litigation among the Gramdan signatories goes on unabated.

One young man sent for training as Gram Sahayak to Kora Kendra Bombay was expelled by the authorities for indiscipline, it is reliably learnt, but the gentleman complained of bad diet and gave 'adverse climate' at Bombay as the reason for his premature retreat. Another gentleman, who was till recently a member of the Mudadi Kshetra Samiti and a rolling stone in different political parties, was at the back of Gramdan signature campaign but now seems to have retreated to some unknown corner.

Except that the cans of dried milk are despatched to Pallikara there is no contact with the village by the Intensive Area personnel which mostly remains home-confined or at best office-confined and has consequently developed a guilty conscience and lost the courage to face people who were given false hopes first under the Intensive Area Scheme and later during the Gramdan signature campaign. Not that there is no promise; but no concerted effort has ever been made for emotional integration of the people who stand positively in need of leadership to set the ball rolling. The social workers like Shri Narain and T. Moyidin are quite promising and can be trained into any position of responsibility. But the brains of the Intensive Area personnel seem to be elsewhere. They feel the problems of the area are solved by their own employment. The organisers are indeed a reflection on the poor selection and gullibility of Shri Kelappan who has collected all punctured tyres there. The convictions are meek and spineless, the spirits are missing, morale for Khadi is at its lowest ebb. The atmosphere is sickening. Clearly, selflessness of Shri Kelappan cannot compensate for his lack of realism to select and handle persons. The orators and workers who led the signature campaign, equally need a bit of heart searching, but now it seems to be a cry in the wilderness to expect any conscientious action from those who have now retreated back to their comfortable jobs of 'talk and travel'.

Tikkoti—the Oasis

But there is an oasis in the desert. There are pioneers everywhere who break through all cordons and barriers, turn away from the beaten track and pave new inroads. Tikkoti a Gramdan unit within the Intensive Area and a few furlongs from the sea coast offers some hope.

Here is Shri T. Gopalan, an ex-P.S.P. young man with practical horse sense who raised in September 1957, a bigger family with 240 young and old members from his neighbourhood. He handed back the capital of Rs. 2500.00 advanced by his uncle (a doctor at Calicut) who shared for years a good profit through the retting business carried on locally, by Shri Gopalan here. Shri Gopalan with equal stubbornness resisted

other programmes of Intensive Area Scheme whose staff would point to the Coir Board for the organisation of the indigenous coir industry. But finally he succeeded and squeezed Rs. 2000.00 from the Intensive Area to raise on 9th December, 1957 a co-operative venture in retting. All these 42 Gramdan families have come together as partners who were previously his employees in the trade.

This Gramdan unit, headed by a Gramsabha of 102 adults with an executive of 5 members, with Shri T. Gopalan as their member Secretary, manages to buy coconut husk, steep it in their courtyards into brackish water channels connected with the sea and carry out the retting operation. The wage distribution is Rs. 18.00 per day to 18 workers. After the fibre is cleaned it is supplied to the Mannamangalam coir spinning centre through the Mudadi Kshetra Samiti who manages that part of the work there and offers employment to about 50 men and women who earn 43 nPs. a day through carding and rope making by hand spinning or 56 nPs. a day by producing coir yarn on Charkhas devised for that purpose. Hand spun coir yarn is said to have a ready market. The total investment both at Tikotti and Mannamangalam is told to be Rs. 3000.00 out of Khadi Commission funds and Rs. 2000.00 out of Kshetra Samiti funds. Out of these 42 families, 12 are Muslims and 30 are Hindus. They have a community store of their own, raised through co-operative labour and resources on the land donated by Shri T. Gopalan and have pushed the papers of a Gramdan Co-operative Society for registration. The capital is expected to be doubled in 4 years' time. According to Shri T. Gopalan an investment of Rs. 30000.00 will provide complete employment to their entire community which has 10 fishermen, 20 coir workers and 12 labourers who share each other's burden in marriages and do the house-thatching in a community way.

These families have about 20 acres under coconut. Two Ghanis are proposed to be installed by the community for extracting coconut oil. Shri Gopalan also proposes to collect Rs. 75.00 from each member at the rate of two annas per day for 600 days to raise a share capital of Rs. 3000.00 to enable them to have Rs. 30,000.00 as loan from the Co-operative Bank for going whole house into a self reliant independent community

of 42 or more families. He intends to extend his work and throw other middlemen (his old colleagues) and big investors out of the trade in the vicinity and seems, imbued with the required punch and stamina. Made of the practical stuff he can teach a lot to the staff of the Intensive Area Scheme how to break the stalemate and pioneer necessary approaches to the people's hearts and their problems.

Observations

One naturally feels the necessity of evaluating the work of Intensive Area Scheme which seems to be the main hope for many people in Sarvodaya circles.

Since there was the Krumbranad Development Society working few miles away at Quilandy engaged in exactly similar work under Shri Kelappan's Chairmanship, one feels it is a financial waste to have spent so much again on buildings and staff with so poor results. Moreover, there is a general lack of interest among members of the Mudadi Kshetra Samiti since the quorum is hardly complete during meetings. 500 primary members in the villages covered by the scheme are equally inactive and apathetic. Gram Vikas Mandals in the 6 Anshams (villages) are only dummy bodies except that they look to the milk (dried) distribution service to the children in the mornings which is being done by every Tom, Dick and Harry in the country. The Khadi workers employed under the Commission come mostly from the Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh with a pride in Khadi work while the organisers having little experience in Khadi are said to have descended on Khadi in silken parachutes from above. As a result there is a rift in the highly paid organisers and the low-paid Khadi workers who have lost all idealism of Khadi but are in a good mood to compete in idleness with the imported stuff in the staff. Eventually, the Intensive Area headquarters appear like the hybridization of a monastery with trade and industry.

Production has been shockingly poor in Ambar which constitutes the main hub of the scheme and is the staple subject of cottage sector. It came to almost 1/40th of the pay received by the staff which, for the greater part of the year 1958, could not show production of more than 200 hanks per month costing

only Rs. 37.50. Investment on Ambars being above Rs. 12000.00 the production out of Kisan and Ambar both is Rs. 400.00 worth of yarn per month which will bring 500 yards of Khadi costing Rs. 750.00 that is still below the total pay of the staff. In 1956-57, 22 persons only had annual employment through Ambar each with an income of Rs. 33.68 per annum (Rs. 2.81 per month). In other aspects of Khadi production 669 persons earned an income of Rs. 2.25 per month on an average. Khadi assured annual employment to 42 persons out of a population of 26,000, coir ensured an annual income of Rs. 102.00 each to 15 persons. It is apparent there is a terrible under-utilization of funds, equipment and personnel. The ratio of output to expenditure is shockingly low.

Ideal average production out of one Ambar is told to be 200 hanks per month. For 80 Ambars distributed by the I.A.S. (Intensive Area Scheme) the required monthly production will be 16000 hanks which will be worth Rs. 3,000.00 of yarn yielding 4,000 yards of cloth. The annual production out of that will be 48,000 yards of cloth. Need for the population of 25,000 covered by the Scheme at an average requirement of* 20 yards per head will be 5,00,000 yards of cloth. Self-sufficiency requires 800 Ambar Charkhas. By now 3 years of the scheme are over. Two years are left for self sufficiency targets perhaps. By the present speed it will take 50 years to reach the target. But by that time the population of the area is going to double itself if the present birth rate prevails.

The house of Khadi Commission is reported 'not in order'. It has become a den of job hunters imported from sophisticated circles who have not the remotest sympathy with Khadi. To quote Shri Kelappan, the Honorary Organiser of this I.A.S., President of the Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal and member of the Kerala Khadi Board: "Previously if a worker would address a letter to the Board (The Central Advisory Body) which was actually meant for the Commission (The Central Executive Body), the office staff looking through the contents would do the needful to direct the letter to the Commission. But now the letter is returned to the sender after a few months with the

* Estimates based on the plans of the Intensive Area Scheme.

remark that the letter be addressed to the Khadi Commission."

Similar lack of imagination is shown by the staff of Mudadi I.A.S. The people at Machukunnu are expected to go 3 miles to buy an earthen pot even though it is manufactured within a few yards or furlongs of their residence. The plea offered is that production centre cannot be made a sales centre. The irony is that the godown of pottery is fully packed for want of market.

It is due to such whimsical management that the staff does not enjoy the confidence of the people who prefer to stand far away from the huge mansions raised under the name of Khadi and Cottage Industries. God knows whose employment problems the staff is solving! There is little impact of the Scheme on the economy of the area.

Even though the production side is very weak the marketing is at its worst. The statistical side of the working of the scheme seems to be a guarded secret. There is no display of chart, graphs or figures relating to the investment, establishment costs, employment and wage distribution, production or sale out of each industry. There is a blank facing the visitor on that account. Going round the building is never enough for an inquisitive visitor to such projects. The mind of the staff needs to be sensitized to the value of evaluation.

It is stated that during 3 years from 1954 to 1957 out of the total outlay in the Intensive Areas all over India, 6.8 per cent has gone on salaries, 62.9 per cent on Khadi and 30.3 per cent on building and construction. Unfortunately one finds better furniture, equipment and buildings but worse mental equipment for Khadi or village work.

The emphasis has come to rest on raising centres, buildings and training but the education of the mass mind about the sentiment and economics of cottage goods is cruelly neglected. Creative idealism required for such work is totally lacking. Instead, Nehru Government or Communist administration is made the scape-goat to hide their own failure and incompetence to approach the people's hearts and apply the A.B.C. of business management.

Shri Kelappan, an Honorary Organiser of the Intensive Area is too much on demand in political and other organisational activities. He seems too old and too respectable for field work

involved in Gramdan. Lastly, since the Intensive Area Scheme does not touch the agrarian aspect of the economy it has been a good riddance of a bad job on the part of Sarvodaya leadership to throw away the Gramdan sponge to the Intensive Area Scheme where misfits abound. However, the working of the Intensive Area will be better understood when exposed to comparative study. For that let us move to Balusseri and meet Shri Krishnan.

(B) GRAMODYOG KHADI SANGH

Two miles to the east of Quilandy you cross the river Aghalpuzha and see cars being carried over the beats across the river from where N.E.S. Block area of Balusseri begins. Eight miles bus journey further by road—thickly lined with fruit laden coconut palms and graceful arecanut plantations—brings you to Balusseri. Here in the vicinity lie 36 Gramdan Units all located in 12 revenue villages out of the 19 covered by the N.E.S. Block raised in April 1958. The Block covers the population of 100,217 persons with a sown area of 32,000 acres and an uncultivable waste of 11,200 acres. The cultivated land capita is .32 acres. Average indebtedness per landowner is Rs. 625.00. Gasping for life there are 19 Co-operative Credit Societies claiming 8,785 members with a share capital of Rs. 1,08,340.00 only. The population seems to be in a tight corner economically.

36 Gramdans in the area were harvested after Vinoba's departure through a well-organized Gandhi Smarak Nidhi camp held at village Mundakara, 1½ miles from Balusseri where processions, dramas and cultural features were organised under the able guidance of Shri Gopinath Nair—a Shanti Niketan chap. Many big guns of Sarvodaya who boomed here promised to fight poverty from the front line by settling down amongst the people but one finds the old fighters only in the trenches. All the seasonal birds who came to make it an experimental area have flown back to their secure nests.

Khadi Clicks

Here is Shri N. V. Krishnan who proves that Khadi clicks and clicks well. What the Intensive Area Scheme with

Rs. 75,000.00 on buildings and Rs. 1,000.00 as monthly establishment costs could not do, Shri Krishnan through his Gramodaya Khadi Sangh, a self-supporting body, has been able to accomplish. He has created 612 spinners who produce 5,000 hanks per month, (as much as the Mudadi Intensive Area) 16 weavers spin Khadi yarn (nothing is sent to Salem district as in I.A.S.) bringing the monthly production to 1330 sq. ft. yards which is sold through their own (Gramodaya Khadi Sangh's) sale depot at Balusseri. Shri Krishnan started one year earlier i.e., in 1954 under the patronage of Akhil Bharat Sarva Sevak Sangh while Intensive Area Mudadi entered the field in 1955. He is assisted by Shri Gopal Nair, an employee of Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh.

Here, 612 spinners work on the Kisan Charkha. In return for each hank costing 25 nPs. the spinner gets six nPs. in cash, 9 nPs. worth of cotton and 9 nPs. worth of Khadi or other spinning accessories. 26 persons are said to be self spinners. The oil ghanis (for coconut etc.) are also working along with the cloth depot. The work is a result of the devoted efforts of Shri M. V. Krishnan, a young bachelor devoted solely to Khadi whose sincere persuasions have brought honourable living to the unemployed people here. Besides, he has been successful in persuading the townsmen of Ballusseri to spin and buy Khadi. He faces no problems of establishment, buildings, production or marketing since the approach right from the beginning has been a human, creative and realistic one.

Nirmallur

Nirmallur was selected during study to have an understanding of the field approach. While showing round a Kisan Charkha training class of 25 spinners in this village with 217 Gramdan families just 2 miles from Balusseri he (Shri Krishnan) explained his indifference towards Ambar with a chuckle and stated, "Well, field experience is the guide", and continued, "Thirty seven trainees after training in 3 groups in this village were distributed 37 Ambars costing about Rs. 3,700.00". Shrugging his shoulders he revealed "The monthly output on all of them is 200 hanks of yarn in total which is the normal output of our 10 Kisan Charkhas that cost only Rs. 50.00 and

the training costs on Ambar are equally high, same about the servicing. So we are happy in our modest ways; we do not want to deny the logic of facts."

There are 50 Kisan spinners already active, giving 700 hanks per month (14 hanks per Kisan spinner) in this village Nirmallur. The spinners have their own pass-books where a running account of their spinning deposits and advances etc. is kept and daily entries made accordingly. The village has sent its proposal for the registration of a Gramdan Sarvodaya Co-operative Society. The share money so far collected by 100 members is Rs. 140.00. The official list gives 171 as the number of Gramdan families but the Gram Sabha representatives state 197 as the present figure out of which 75 are Nair families, 75 are Thiyyas, 10 are Muslims and 37 are Harijans. Muslims and Harijans are stated to be landless, others have .40 acres per head. The main source of income to the land owning group of Gramdan membership is coconut, areca and pepper. The objectives before the village for the formation of the Co-operative seem to be, oil pressing, fibre making and co-operative marketing of produce. There are 37 rich families in the village who own 800 acres of land where other villagers work as wage-earners at times. Expenses on marriages are heavy. Average indebtedness is above Rs. 600.00. Use of hired bullock power for Rs. 2.00 per day along with the ploughman is in vogue. The village leadership integrated in newly formed Gramsabha commands good confidence among the people. The president, Shri Viswanath Nambiar — a person of good breeding and a popular figure — is deputed to Kora Kendra Bombay for training to work later as Gram Sahayak under Khadi Commission. From the N.E.S. Block side there are 3 plots of paddy demonstrating the Japanese method of cultivation. Three years earlier Gandhi Smarak Nidhi also tried it but people again fell back to the old, less productive method, it was told.

(C) THE NATIONAL EXTENSION SERVICE

Coming to the Balusseri N.E.S. Block which covers these 36 Gramdan units spread in 12 Revenue villages the working was found in December 1958 — January 1959 as under:



The Block Development Officer of the area was away at Himayatsagar (Andhra) for training while B.D.O. for the adjoining Perambra Block was officiating as B.D.O. for Balusseri also along with his own load of work. Seen at his headquarters at Perambra he was found facing two basket loads of papers and mechanically signing them since he was called upon to leave for the District headquarters Kozhikode in response to a telephone call by the District Collector. The B.D.O. had one leg in Jeep, the other on the table signing papers not only for his block but for the neighbouring Balusseri Block also. The multi-purpose job of the B.D.O. it seemed, had come to mean so many things to be attempted at the same time, and the author as a visitor was an additional nuisance. However, the problems of this accommodating B.D.O. narrated during the 25 mile jeep journey on to Kozhikode were in no way different from other B.D.O's. The gentleman had been brought over from the Registration Department to the Development work, got less time to be in the field, had been forced to drag along the district collectorate. His Block needed financial aid for steps against water-logging whereas the grants sanctioned had been allocated for irrigation. The rush, speed, pressure and tensions for the 'spending programmes' had made him useless for the people but a useful multi-purpose man for the district administration which after thus crippling the post now planned to merge the B.D.O's post in that of the Tahsildar to further shut the doors for any possible initiatives in the field of integrated rural development. So that is the long and short of it. (The second attempt to visit Gramdan units in this Block area, in spite of previous appointment with the acting B.D.O. failed due to pressure of meetings at the district level).

Official View

No use could be made by the Block personnel of whatever little sentiment was created through Gramdan which, according to the version of the official class and true to a great extent for lack of approach, has meant nothing beyond the signatures. "Nowhere have the people taken a step to share land or other resources or even given a gesture for co-operative pattern of life," it was asserted. One of the most responsible officials of

the revenue department of the Quilandy taluk had this to say: "Legally no view can be taken of Gramdan as it stands in the Taluka. That is what could be said in reply to the queries of the Revenue Board after a deep study of the situation about Bhoodan or Gramdan. At times the donor had no rights on what he was said to be donating."

Co-ordination

One such circular about the co-ordination with the Gramdan workers is said to have been received at all Block headquarters but no detailed instructions have followed since then. As a result, there is no Gramdan representative on the Block Advisory Committees, nor has any such demand been made from the quarters concerned. That, in brief, is the follow-up of the high level talks on co-ordination between the Block personnel and the Gramdan workers.

The Field

Diffidence amongst officials and cynicism among the people were the main features observed in the field. No tangible grappling of the people or their problems was there to find. The general rifts and party politics at the Panchayat level were stated to be the perpetual headaches towards wholesome approaches to the villages which don't have a nucleated setting as seen in other parts of India. There is little scope for work in construction of roads and schools since in Kerala the road mileage is already .72 miles per square mile and literacy and schools are the pride of Kerala. So beyond the distribution of fertilizers the vision gets blurred. The middlemen's menace or the scourge of indebtedness is not being touched even with a long pole. The co-operative structure is just nominal and superficial, it doesn't touch the core of economic problems. Nor did the staff seem conversant with the gravities or priorities of the area.

Sivapuram

During the visit in mid-December 1958 the Block personnel (Balusseri) was as yet engrossed in surveys and statistical studies while the B.D.O. was away for training. The Block also has taken up Ambar training as a part of its programme to solve the rural unemployment. At Sivapuram, a village affected by

Gramdan, the Block was running one Ambar training class of 20 lady trainees selected out of Gramdan and non-Gramdan families for a 3 months' training under 2 instructors paid by the District Industries Officer Kozhikode who, it seems, did not care to compare notes with Shri M. V. Krishnan about Ambar training (see the preceding chapter) but just launched it in. The performance seemed rather poor. The training was being imparted in a miserably ill-kept building. It appeared cleanliness and order had no co-relation with Block work at the village level. The scheduled hours of the work centre (Parishramalaya) were 8 A.M. to 5 P.M. with one hour's interval for lunch, but the instructors were found to be habituated to report as late as 9-30 A.M. and were told to close at about 4-30 P.M. with the due privilege for the interval for lunch.

This callousness will naturally result in poor grasp of the Ambar by trainees and the natural lot of the Ambar will be just to lie in the lumber.

Following is the caste analysis of the 20 trainees.

Nairs	4
Thiyyas	13
Carpenter	1
Weaver	1
Harijan	1
<i>Total</i>	20

The equipment of the training centre was 10 Ambar sets, 10 belnis. Carding was on a bow string appliance. The Kerala Khadi Board is expected to take over the yarn produced during training. 50 spinners to be trained in 3 groups will be brought into a spinners' co-operative it was stated.

In a way, the Block area approach was found not an improvement on the Intensive Area approach at Mudadi except that the Block personnel had more prestige than the I.A.S. personnel, had a jeep at its disposal and was found expert in showing itself rather too busy.

Observations

Mr. Albert Mayer, the founder architect of Community Projects evaluating the N.E.S. approach writes the epitaph by his own hands.*

"The real and irremediable failure will be this: That all the targets set will be achieved on paper by wishful reporting and by wishful acceptance of the reporting, punctuated by prepared visits into the field. In other words, we shall be back where we started only on a much bigger scale and the frustration will be more universal."

He further states, "Praise or criticism by upper authority has come to be excessively based on mechanical results. The heights or depths of this phase have been reached by the upside down fiscal criterion that is now constantly applied. How much money have you spent? Why haven't you spent it faster? Will you spend it all by such a date? The results of this are a false set of values. The assumption is incorrectly made that money spent is equivalent to good work achieved. And what is now happening and will increasingly happen in this over-speeded programme, is a return to that self-deception at higher levels and that cynicism on the part of the people and the field worker which we had begun to dispel."

The greatest tragedy about C.P.A., of course, began when it was again tied up to the same old soulless district administration which its pioneer — Mr. Albert Mayer — so carefully kept at bay.

(D) *GANDHI SMARAK NIDHI*

Balusseri area also, like Kaladi, has been selected by Gandhi Smarak Nidhi for follow-up work and a gentleman working with Nidhi for the last five years has been posted here since March 1958. He has also a background of Harijan and Tribal Welfare work under other local welfare organisations in different parts of the province.

The gentleman, even though he maintains an album of cuttings of his speeches published in the local press, has had no

roots in the area as yet and seems rather incompetent to meet the challenge of the situation in the Gramdan units around Balusseri. He is no doubt on demand at all the sundry functions in the area for speeches but he is not yet at his job it seems, lacks most of the qualities for field work of the present nature and holds no comparison with Shri Oommen working at Kaladi under Gandhi Smarak Nidhi.

As yet no centre in any village has been raised and no impact of the organization has been felt on the Gramdan units. Out of the few Gramdan-effected villages visited, Mundakara has its own case history which needs a mention here.

Included in the Block area, Mundakara, 2 miles from Balusseri, has 197 families who have signed the Gramdan village pledge on persuasion from Kelappanji. But the village is torn in factionalism which has been further accentuated after Gramdan, it is said.

One gentleman who was a Congress detenu in 1930 and handed over the Gramdan pledges to Kelappanji by the close of 1957, went into an adventure of a cattle fair in March 1958 with the permission of the Gram Panchayat Board by depositing Rs. 200.00 from somewhere while the village in general did not want the show.

The cattle fair, however brought a good earning but some of the lieutenants of this bully misused the money and there is none now to submit the account to the community who participated in the deliberations when given positive understanding that the profits will be used for some community purpose. Now there is none to bell these bullying cats of the cattle fair. The rival group which could replace it is equally worthless, it is stated. A year has passed in suspense. Fresh young leadership is not forthcoming for fear of the old grey heads forming rival groups and distracting the constructive tendencies of the village youth. One village clerk — an Ansham Menon — is said to be equally active in torpedoing the cohesion of the village life. And yet there is another gentleman who is equally interested in such bull fights. So the village is in between so many devils and the deep sea — just 12 miles from here.

None from the Sarvodaya circles has even ventured to look into the matter and provide a fresh footing to the village. The

Gandhi Smarak Nidhi worker is equally incompetent and inexperienced to handle such concrete situations obtaining in these villages which require handling by a person sufficiently matured through hard knocks of community life and who has the poise and audacity to be a reliable arbitrator, a trustworthy consultant and a practical 'down-to-earth' fellow.

It is not without reason that Shri Krishnan Nair, a convener of Gramdan Panchayat of Panagad, 2 miles from here, complains of the non-realistic attitude of Sarvodaya leadership that gave promises to the people of his village without any sense of responsibility. His village has 175 signatories of Gramdan scattered all over the village without even an idea of any compactness.

Nor are there any working principles evolved by the Sarvodaya leadership or Gandhi Smarak Nidhi to utilise the technical know-how of the Block staff for the reorganisation of life in Gramdan units. The possibilities of working out any operations jointly seem remote at the moment since each sits in his own cozy compartmental nest basking under high ideals and objectives feeling that all is well with the world — a divine creation.

(E) KERALA KHADI BOARD

The Krumbranad Development Society, founded by Shri Kelappan in 1953 or so for Khadi and Village Industries work in the area, with its impressive mansions at Quilandy about 12 miles from Kozhikode, was expected to take up Gramdan development work in whole of Krumbranad area as declared by Shri Kelappan vide *Bhoodan* (Hindi) dated 22nd November 1957. But, for reasons better known to the sponsors, a new body under the name of Pantalayini Sarvodaya Gramdan Co-operative Society — just half a mile away from the headquarters of the Krumbranad Development Society mentioned above — has been set up and is engaged in exactly similar activities of Ambar and Khadi work.

Pantalayini — the rural part of Quilandy township — is half a mile from the sea coast and was listed as Gramdan early 1958 with 315 families who own 100 acres of coconut, areca and

pepper gardens and 15 acres of paddy land in all. Nairs constitute the landowners' group but the holdings are miserably small. 200 families are said to be coir workers and as usual suffer through the tyranny of middlemen. The agricultural produce not brought under co-operative marketing is sold on advances from merchants close by, who generally offer 10 to 15 per cent less than the market price. But this Gramdan crop seems to have been raised merely to draw Khadi Board grants. Unfortunately, the gentleman appointed incharge of the work is regularly paid Rs. 116.00 p.m. by Sarvodaya Mandal for his planned and consistent hibernation whereas the Ambar Instructors (4 ladies and 2 gents) were found without any pay for nearly three months in December 1958. The trainees in Ambar hailed 90 per cent from Nair families and the whole programme presented a sectional approach. The information about caste analysis of the Gramdan membership could not be made available but the occupational break-up of members is as under:

Self-cultivators	20
Tenants	30
Wage earners	250
Businessmen	15
TOTAL	315

The total indebtedness of the Gramdan families was said to be roughly Rs. 29,000.00. The co-operative credit work is not being launched nor are the normal co-operative agencies approached for any economic programme since the organisers themselves were said to be under debt to the Co-operative Bank. It all appears to be a hotch-potch approach and shows bankruptcy of planning the community life. 250 wage earners' families are said to face the threat of unemployment for 3 months of a year during June to August in rainy season.

Shri V. R. Krishna Iyer — Minister for Law and Order in the Communist Ministry — belonging to the landlord class of the village is said to have contributed little to the socio-economic development of the village. The Gram Panchayats and regular Co-operatives are shunned by the Gramdan organisers generally, who find themselves secure under the patronage of Khadi Board, it was observed.

The whole venture appeared isolated and pocketed one. One feels it has created a new caste of Sarvodayites and Gramdanis who carve out an island of their own without any rational attitude on community planning. Khadi Board too does not seem to have the necessary personnel to study the economic conditions before it approves the activities to be launched in a particular area. One would like to see that the Board does not merely enter into the spending or training programmes but also evaluates the economic impact of its outlays and does not encourage raising organizational set-ups at every half a mile. Such easy access to funds may prove the doom of Khadi work, one genuinely fears.

And that is the end of the ventures undertaken by various agencies in the Experimental Area of Krumbranad.

CHAPTER 21

A Promising Venture

WHEREAS HUNDREDS of Sarvodaya thinkers of high calibre have not stepped down from their arm-chair methods of merely telling others what to do, here is Shri Radha Krishna Menon — a 'down-to-earth' fellow who tries to do what he feels is right.

Quite young—not above 40—he is a person with profundity, good breeding and high education who has been tasting the flavour of constructive work since his teens. With his horizons of maturity still expanding he knows how to identify himself with the people and how to live upto a cause, it seems.

A strong votary of Basic Education at the start of his career he, staking a lot of his property, set up a Basic School in 1949 at Ramnatkara — 10 miles to the south east of Kozhikode — which is now a Basic Education Training Centre running under government aid. But in 1957 he shifted to village Peringavu, 2 miles further into the interior along with his Maharashtrian wife to raise a new Gramdan Community over an area of 50 acres lying on a hill top. Half the area belonged to the Basic Education Society and the other half *i.e.*, 25 acres came in donation through Bhoodan. He has settled here with 30 families — 15 Harijans and 15 non-Harijans where one doctor Shri Kerala Varma has also been drawn as a new entrant into this new community.

But unfortunately there is no agricultural land with these new settlers. It is more or less an educational-cum-industrial colony of cottage nature born out of the sincere aspirations of

socially sensitive Shri Menon. There are 10 potters, 10 agricultural labourers along with other salary earners like teachers and cottage industries personnel who have pledged to pool their incomes together for a healthy community living. It is a new village with buildings rising out of grants from various agencies like Kerala Khadi Board, Gandhi Smarak Nidhi (of which Shri Menon is a member) and Harijan Sevak Sangh. A personal donation of Rs. 5000.00 has also been showered by Pandit Nehru. And all these grants have duly been fertilized by Shramdan (voluntary labour contributions).

A community shop constructed through Shramdan by the Village Council of this little community is run on a non-profit basis. A Basic School with nearly 100 bright young students is one of the most active features of this little sapling of a village planted on the barren hill top amidst a picturesque view of Kerala's typical landscapes of plain paddy fields crawling at the feet of coconut-covered mounds and hills dancing around. There is another nursery class (pre-basic) of 30 kiddies run by Smt. Menon who serves as a devoted mother to them along with her own trio and feeds them all at lunch and in the afternoon.

Aided by Khadi Board, the industries like soap, oil, Ambar, pottery and hand pounding of rice have been set up in the locality in newly raised sheds and tiled buildings which partly serve the needs of the adjoining population. The villagers around have participated in the construction of minor roads and the approach road to Ramnatkara but are as yet watchful and diffident to share the life with this growing community for fear of losing their individual land holdings. It will be a triumph for Shri Menon if he could win a few of them over, into his newly growing community which is as yet divorced from agriculture for want of cultivable land even though the soil conservation operations being carried out on the hill will facilitate some plantations of coconut and other productive trees.

Since the whole atmosphere of this little village vibrates with warmth and fellow feeling, the lovable Menon family does not mind living in a perpetual financial insecurity since everything is pooled and shared and the advantage naturally goes

to the poorer sections of the community. Tapping of funds seems to be a perpetual struggle for Shri Menon who appears to have staked a lot of his personal property in this and the previous venture of Basic Training Centre at Ramnatkara. Perhaps he is running faster than the people around him.

CHAPTER 22

Emotional Integration

THERE IS a new encouraging venture of emotional integration by the lovable people at Purameri — a village with 300 Gramdan families, 8 miles from sea coast in Badagara Taluka of Kozhikode district. Kumari Kaumudi, who had surrendered for good, all her ornaments to Gandhiji on his visit to these parts during 1930's, belongs to this village. Her family folk known as Rajas who have now taken to the profession of teaching, still provide genuine leadership to the people and a sobering influence on the growth of the community life. The cultural level of the people seems to be a bit higher. Literacy too is high due to Raja's High School and 4 Elementary schools. The ladies, majority of whom are well-educated here have a leading role in activising the social thinking. The people, due to their gentle docile nature, seem to prefer Sarvodaya to other political ideologies here. That is why 'Sarvodaya Patra' — a charity box in the family for supporting Sarvodaya workers — has succeeded so well in this village.

Although Kumari A. K. Rajamma of Vinoba Niketan (at Malayadi at Trivandrum district) had some role in the beginning, most of the credit for consolidating the will of the people towards good neighbourliness and social integration goes to Shri Panikkar, a Sarvodaya worker posted during the last year by Sarvodaya Mandal in this village. He is a good scholar of Sanskrit. While an Arya Samaj preacher for some time, he was influenced by Vinoba's stand in Telangana and started

working for Bhoodan as early as 1952-53. Undeterred by the early outward indifference of the people, he seems to have made a determined approach here to do one thing *i.e.* to smash the existing aloofness amongst the 300 Gramdan families through an unbroken house to house contact in all the different sections of the society. Never could the people find so sympathetic and friendly an approach to their personal and social problems. Sarvodaya, they thought, was too good to be believed. It was taken to be a rest camp for old and frustrated politicians. But Shri Panikkar — a quiet patient stubborn lad — by his regular visits to the hearths of the people could at last melt the social stiffness of the intelligentsia to lead them into creative channels of good neighbourliness who now feel convinced that the longest cut is the shortest cut and good neighbourliness is perhaps the primary need for emergence of a new society.

As a result Shri E. V. Krishnan Nair, a thorough gentleman working as a Headmaster of the local High School strengthened by Shri A. K. Shankar Varma Raja, Shri A. K. Rama Varma Raja (father of Kumari Kaumudi referred to above), Shri V. P. Venugopal and S. A. Mekad — heads a local Sarvodaya Mandal which is blending the individuals into a harmonious community life. Sarvodaya Mahila Samaj, led by Smt. Uma Tamburati (Smt. A. K. Shankar Varma Raja), is equally an active body in the social sphere.

Fortunately, there is no private money-lending in the village. People are said to have their dealings entirely with the Co-operative Rural Bank. There are 30 families of weavers using mill yarn but free from any meddling by the middlemen or such agencies.

The main crops are coconut, arecanut, plantains and paddy (double crop). Annual income of an average family is Rs. 250.00 with the following break-up.

	Value in Rs.
Crop	200
Coconut	15
Areca	10
Plantains	25
Coir	
TOTAL	250

20 Kisan Charkhas have so far been distributed amongst the needy families, 20 trainees were undergoing in Ambar spinning under local arrangement.

As already stated, the class of teachers provides the leadership but is found a little diffident and shaky about its role further in the social change. A little obsessed about the inefficacy of the prevalent educational methods they are yet exploring constructive channels for their social idealism. The minds are sufficiently pliable for any co-operative venture. But shall Shri Panikkar be competent to lead the experiment to its further stages of socio-economic integration? That is the problem.

The pattern of land ownership is as yet unchanged. The spine for a good social life has been raised but the flesh and blood is as yet to be provided by flooding the barriers of individual ownership. The spirit and attitudes seem healthy but they have yet to affect the behaviour a bit more substantially. Gramdan being a process, there is a sound hope in this healthy beginning which can reasonably be followed by institutionalising the social life under a service Co-operative and other corporate bodies as steps ahead.

The village falls under the Tuneri N. E. S. Block but the influence of Sarvodaya seems to be dominant on these 300 families. The co-ordination is worth trying but Shri Panikkar has some mental resistances towards the departmental approaches. The alliance of block can possibly initiate him into the A.B.C. of planning and organization if he could be mentally prepared for that. But that is the general malady of Sarvodaya work. Shri Pannikar can't help it, so it seems. Nor can the Block people step out of the beaten tracks, one can easily presume. The village chose the present line early 1958 as a result of Smt. Rajamma's camp in the village. People of Purameri demand regular visits from this amazon who is a living inspiration for a band of selfless workers in this village at least. But let us study her role in her own Ashram at Malayadi in the next chapter.

CHAPTER 23

The Torch - Bearers

EXCEPTING Mr. Velayudhan Pillai's work which has already been presented in Chapter 17 there is not much to report in the villages of the Malayadi pocket. But Vinoba Niketan—a Sarvodaya Ashram of Smt. A. K. Rajamma, member of Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal and Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh has a role in buttressing the movement. The institution claims to have lit the torch of Gramdans in Kerala and has been a host to Akhil Bharat Seva Sangh, Kerala Khadi Board and Central Khadi Commission in certain training programmes in Ambar spinning, and weaving. It rose in 1955 on a disputed, but later donated, site. Built out of mud, bamboo and thatch the Ashram has a roofed area of roughly 3,500 sq. feet.

The primary objective was to reinforce the field work of Shri Velayudhan Pillai. The Communist Ministry had been generous enough to attach adjoining 10 acres of forest land to enable the Ashram to extend its activities. Not only that, a personal letter from Shri E. M. S. Namboodripad to some communists, who were hostile to the activities of the ashram, had mentally and politically smoothened matters for the institution. Rs. 10,000.00 are stated to have been sanctioned for the Ashram by the Central Government under Local Development head. But the plans are not less ambitious. A Gram Vidyalaya—whose plan duly autographed by Vinobaji and framed in glass faces the visitor to the institution—requires Rs. 50,000.00 for

its construction which seems too high a target for achievement in the near future.

Khadi

This Ashram, 22 miles east of Trivandrum on Trivandrum Kallar road and just half a mile from Shri Velayudhan Pillai's place, Thachancode, has 27 residential members (90 per cent bachelors, widowers and spinsters). It claims to have trained about 75 youngsters in village work, introduced 800 Kisan Charkhas in the vicinity, creating out of them 500 regular spinners who now produce 5,000 hanks per month which are woven into cloth, through 10 looms working at the Ashram and 6 looms active at Nagarcoil 50 to 60 miles from here. Out of 10 weavers, working regularly at the Ashram, 7 have already been working at mill yarn, only 3 are new at weaving. Ashram pays 40 nPs. per yard as weaving charges to these weavers. Average monthly production, by all the 16 weavers connected with the work is 1,200 yards (2½ yards per weaver per day). Average monthly sales at the Ashram sales-depot are said to be 500 yards bringing the sale returns to Rs. 1,000.00. Another sale depot is located at Kattakada, a few miles from here.

17 Ambar Charkha instructors have been trained in the past to work under A. B. Sarv Seva Sangh. The Ashram has served as a host to the State Khadi Board and A. B. Sarv Seva Sangh for running 3 Ambar Parishramalayas for women trainees during the last 3 years. Six months' weavers' training course aided by Khadi Commission was being conducted for 10 trainees during 1959.

Soap making, oil pressing, and a workshop for manufacturing Charkhas is also attached to the Ashram.

Welfare Activities

A Balwadi (children's pre-basic class) has been running with the aid from Gandhi Smarak Nidhi and Women's Welfare Board since 1957. One Government trained teacher and one Ayya are paid Rs. 60.00 and Rs. 30.00 p.m. respectively.

A creche for 5 babies was started in 1958 out of a grant from Central Social Welfare Board which also pays Rs. 50.00 p.m. to the lady worker running the creche. Public Health

Department provides dried milk. Local cow milk is also supplied to the children, it was stated.

Objectivity

Financially the Ashram seems to be in a tight corner. With 24 workers stationed at the Ashram the field contacts in the area appear disappointing. The institution lies amputated from the social organism around and is deeply infested with the rarefied artificiality proverbial about such institutions. It presents the appearance of a nunnery-cum-monastery where inmates live confined within the self-created smoke screens of inner conflicts, complexes and confusions. The conditioning of the minds is the only task so far well-accomplished by the institution. In the absence of some dynamic programme, principle or a personality to pull up such institutions it is natural for the inmates to spin self-prisoning cob-web of personal deception. It is surprising that the Ashramites don't spin a single thread during the day but for 20 minutes of prayer they bring their Charkhas along to demonstrate the hypocrisy that is corroding both the Sarvodaya ideology and its adherents.

With problems and poverty yawning around the Ashram these 27 workers have not at all been felt as a force. In Khadi they have done as much as Shri Krishnan at Ballusseri had done almost single-handed. Objective study of the social forces, healthy planning outlook and integrity required for organizational and team work seem to have been declared as contagions emanating from bureaucracy hence out of question under some unwritten clause of Sarvodaya.

Having failed at Vinoba Niketan to create the true Gramdan spirit which she preached in hundreds of Kerala villages. Smt. A. K. Rajamma leaving 800 Gramdan families in the vicinity is said to be burning her fingers now at a newly raised Brahma Vidya Ashram (Sanctuary of spiritual knowledge) at Sevagram.

CHAPTER 24

At Higher Altitudes

Now on the last lap of field study let us get away from the monotony of coconuts and climb up the Western Ghats mapped under South Wynaad taluk of Calicut district to breathe in the bracing salubrious air of thick forests, well-pruned tea estates, richly green coffee plantations and lovely cardamom orchards. 63 Gramdan units are stated to lie here at an altitude of 3,000 ft. approachable by a 50 miles pleasant bus journey from Calicut (Kozhikode). These new roads were opened with the tea and coffee plantations raised by foreigners a century back. Isolation of the jungles broke, unsettling many a poor adivasi from the land but the wages are stated to increase with the demand for labour in plantations required to do felling, weeding, picking and other allied operations. The crop statistics of the taluk detailed below vividly explain the agronomy of the area.

S. No.	Crop	Acreage	S. No.	Crop	Acreage
1.	Paddy	30,077	9.	Ragi	1,582
2.	Coffee	17,629	10.	Rubber	635
3.	Tea	9,839	11.	Ginger	625
4.	Pepper	4,964	12.	Lemon-grass	240
5.	Plantains	3,175	13.	Areca	30
6.	Tapioca	2,670	14.	Coconut	15
7.	Cardamom	1,870	15.	Miscellaneous	539
8.	Oranges	1,624			
					TOTAL 75,494

Obviously, out of a total cultivated area of 75,494 acres only 15 acres are under coconut while more than one-third of the total cultivated area is under coffee and tea. Two-fifth is under paddy. The taluk with 528 sq. miles of area bearing the population of 79551 has the density of 150 persons per sq. mile, the lowest in the state. The Gramdan could find fertile soil only amongst the landless population of the taluk. The 63 Gramdan units are constituted of 1264 tribal or Harijan families with an average of 20 families per unit. That roughly covers more than half of the tribal and Harijan population of the taluk; Shri N. K. Jai Bhadrans now under training as Gram Sahayak at Kora Kendra Bombay got Rs. 100.00 p.m. from Sarvodaya Mandal for this signature campaign hence this high percentage of Gramdan coverage of the lowest sections of the society. The signatories state they were promised five acres of land per family, but the Sarvodaya people have rarely been seen after the signature campaign which, they say, swept the area like an election campaign.

Four Gramdan villages Vengur, Mannikkavu, Olivayil and Kongiyampam, all within 3 miles radius of Meenangadi, 53 miles from Calicut (Kozhikode) were visited for study. Unlike the other habitations in Kerala these adivasi hamlets have a score of houses huddled together in a contiguous area. 3 to 5 acres under house sites in each village are owned by the community. Each house plastered meticulously with different colours of clay stands on a plinth 5 feet higher from the earth with steps running all round the mud walls. The roofing is of Bamboo with straw thatching. Each family has its granary woven out of bamboo and plastered with cowdung. On the fringe of these hamlets there is banana cultivation in small beds by each family. The population is invariably of tenants over lands belonging to one Jai Chandran, M.P. or some Temple Trusts (Devaswams). Some Nairs, Brahmins, or Adhikaris also hold good areas of cultivable land under plantations, etc. Each tenant family has 2 to 3 acres of land under it and pays a share from $1\frac{1}{2}$ to 2 maunds of paddy in kind out of an average yield of 6 to 15 maunds of paddy per acre. The families rear some cattle and, during off season, work in the tea and coffee estates.

Hand-pounding of rice carried on by an ordinary method of mortar and pestle is the main cottage work that women folk of the family jointly do for a few traders in the neighbouring town of Meenangadi getting 12 lbs. of paddy per 80 lbs.

The staying power of these families is low, the stocks invariably run out during rains and they borrow at 200 per cent rate of interest. For a loan of say, Rs. 10.00 they will pay back in cash or kind Rs. 20.00 after 4 to 6 months. Only 5 per cent of their population have their dealings with co-operative agencies who charge 6½ per cent interest per annum. Marriage expenses are generally Rs. 150.00 including the money to the bride's parents, ornaments and community feeding. Most of these adivasis having borrowed Rs. 50.00 to 150.00 from a Muslim trader-cum-money-lender (Shri Hasan of Kariampadi, 2 miles from Meenangadi) are paying 50 per cent of the principal as interest every year for the last five to ten years.

The inhabitants belong to Mullakarama tribe and help each other in farming operations through labour and bullocks, etc. Coffee estates provide work from February to April at the daily wage of Re. 1.50 per male and 75 nPs. per female. Ten per cent are drunkards. None has gone to the school beyond primary education.

Follow-up in these Gramdan villages has been next to nothing. On 13th November 1958, Shri Kelappan formed a Committee with Shri Raghavan Nair Kuppattod — a young landlord aged 25 as convener and 12 other persons of the taluk as members. In the second meeting only 8 persons turned up but at the third meeting (not the last perhaps) only the convener was present. The committee, as revealed by the convener, has its main objective to distribute the Bhoodan lands in the area which are being gradually encroached upon by settlers from Travancore side. No attention has been paid to the usury in these Gramdan units nor have the general co-operative enterprises been contemplated in these socially well-knit hamlets of tenants. The area has not drawn promising social workers as in adivasi Gramdan villages of Koraput (Orissa).

This lands us into a critical and comparative study of the movement which will be dealt with in the following chapters.

PART 5

The Threshing

CHAPTER 25

The Tide and The Ebb

THE NUMERICAL achievements have been dealt with in Chapter 8 Part II. It is obvious that the tempo of getting more Gramdans gradually came down after the emotional storm of 1957 — declared as the year of destiny. Perhaps, the visit of Shri Morarji Desai, the Central Minister, had also its effect who, visiting Meladi in Krumbranad area in December 1957 is stated to have said: "It is more difficult to develop these villages according to the plans of reconstruction than to acquire new Gramdans."

History proves that sanctity of a thought is lost when it passes from a prophet to a priest. There were speeches and house to house canvassing which unfortunately took the shape of a signature campaign similar to that of a Communist sponsored peace movement. 20 signatures on a sheet of prescribed paper meant one Gramdan on the score board. Top leaders spoke of the social implications of Gramdan and promised to entrench themselves amongst the people to pull the villages out of lethargy and lack of initiative whereas ordinary workers promised more of aids, grants, loans and programmes of employment through Khadi and Ambar etc. At places more lands were promised. The incentives offered to the people were mainly material and developmental.

The workers felt that they were ushering in a revolution by bringing in a large number of people in the Gramdan fold and were thereby in a mood of conquest during the year of

1957 which, to their belief, was full of such revolutionary potentialities as Gramdan envisaged. But that emotion could not stay for long.

Consequently, one feels most of the Gramdans were mere paper babies which boosted the figures but actually they were in a contiguous compact area of Gramdans already announced. The workers seem to have wrongly presumed that for the additional 20 families in the same close vicinity there must be a declaration of a new Gramdan. The headquarters of the Gramdan work at Sarvodaya Mandal also were not in a mood, it seems, to go into the details about the declarations. Actually all persons in a contiguous area even numbering upto 200 or more have been considered one group, one unit during the development programmes taken up later and worker does not talk of the number of Gramdans but the families involved in the vicinity of his centre. Numerically things have been presented in an exaggerated manner. All this needs correction after due verification. It seems about 180 can be conveniently dropped out of present figures.

As already stated, out of every 230 persons in Kerala only one has so far come forward for Gramdan. In experimental area of Krumbranad, 9 out of every 100 persons have stood for it. Based on a formal sample study carried out at a number of work-centres, it can be stated that out of all the 12084 signatories, about 90 per cent have land below one acre, 9.6 per cent have between 1 and 3 acres. Only one signatory had more than 30 acres.

Impact on Agrarian Set-Up

Practical achievements of Gramdan phase in delivering land to the landless are much below that of Bhoodan phase. The total coverage so far through Gramdan follow-up work is about 220 families in the land sector which is quite insignificant in relation to the 21 per cent landless population of the state. Above that, about a thousand families have been approached through cottage industries programme. Apparently, only one-tenth of the lot that signed for Gramdan has so far been covered. The pattern of ownership which is the basic test of Gramdan is as yet unchanged. Since the voluntary pooling of rights

has not been pushed up, pledges for Gramdan have not stopped the purchase sale, lease or mortgaging of lands to others or to each other. Gramdan has not yet created effective mechanism of vigilance on the economic conditions of each joining family and united them so as to plan together the production, sale, purchase and marketing operations — relating to their economy.

The rural oligarch, the feudal class, careless of the statute book or the movement continues to dominate through custom. Attachment to land or cost of land has not been effected by the movement. The lowest class continues to look to the political extreme of Communist principles which, it feels, offers the only possible and practical way to deliver the goods i.e., the land. Voluntary method of sharing land through Gramdan has failed to come to grips with the central elements in Kerala's agrarian problems. The gap between the paper right holder and the actual cultivator is as wide. The unit of production continues to be small. The landless population stands where it was. That a number of persons owning above 3 acres of land in a number of places (like Pallikara) later backed out shows that people were carried away by the atmosphere created by the movement and by the vague feeling that Gramdan may usher in material benefits and social prestige. There is little sharing at places without any change in proprietary rights. Gramdan, as such, has failed to offer the impetus to economic reorganization in agriculture and could make no direct assault on the land problem of this problem state. It is difficult to state as such whether the ideology of Gramdan has practically matured in Kerala or not, since as Prof. Gadgil says, "A Gramdan village in which resumption and redistribution of land are not active possibilities would cease in fact to be a Gramdan village."*

The reasons for stagnation of the movement are varied, some of them are outward and some of them inward. Let us take up the former first.

Outward Causes of Stagnation

Mr. Daniel Thorner reviewing the agrarian conditions of

* *Gramdan: Implications and Possibilities*, by D. R. Gadgil.

Kerala* observes that the state "can boast of the most intricate agrarian structure in the whole of India. In this region a many tiered edifice of interests in the lands — Janmis, Kanamdars, Virumpattamdars — rests on a mass of landless labourers known as Cherumas, Puliyas or Poliyars. The pressure on land is so intense that one cent (*i.e.*, one hundredth of an acre) of good double crop paddy land is in some areas worth as much as Rs. 200.00." The title of land ownership is widely dispersed from the state downward into the landlord, sub-landlord, non-cultivating tenant, cultivating tenant and the hut owner with interests of all burdening the land. The movement brought into its fold only the lowest strata of landless people or holders upto 1 acre and failed to make any appeal to the actual landed interests.

The joint family system in its last phase does not determine the clear-cut rights of the persons on land. Where it is breaking up it leads to individualistic type of existence as a matter of relief and reaction from the joint management.

The state's complex rural setting of dispersed housing is another strong factor against social integration. People by their distinct culture and temperament are individualistic.

The desperation and belief that problems of their state are beyond solution is another challenge. Political attitudes are equally important.

Attitude of The Political Parties

Higher echelons of the Congress which are never tired of verbal sympathies with the movement and its founder could not exert on its local ranks to support the movement. In spite of Yelwal and other utterances in that direction, Kerala Congress could not be conscious of anything but its fall from power in the State. "Ever since its discredited politicians found themselves cheated of power which was theirs for ten troubled years and found moreover that they could not muster up courage or votes to dislodge a government subsisting on a two-vote majority and found also to their dismay that the ruling party was carrying out bold measures of reform and incidentally

* *The Agrarian Prospect in India*, by Daniel Thorner

strengthening the party cadre the furies have been let loose," observes 'Witness' in *Indian Express* dated 25th May, 1959.

Other parties too, even though approached by Vinoba during the Kerala tour on 11th July 1957 at Kozhikode, could not think of anything else but desperation and consequent reaction and uproar against the Communist party. They were invariably haunted by phantoms of insecurity and could hardly contribute anything to the growth of the movement. Same holds true about Nairs, Christians and other groups in Kerala who promised their support to the founder of the movement during his trek through the state.

Communists too could not see eye to eye with the movement due to their ideological differences even though Shri E. M. S. is stated to have told Vinoba after Yelwal, "Bhoodan and Gramdan can prove as an alternative to Communism if the former can be implemented.* The attitude of the Kerala ministry to the Gramdan work had not been hostile like that of Mahtab ministry in Orissa, but it has not equally been encouraging. In his book *Mahatma and the Ism* Shri E. M. S. Nambudiripad, Chief Minister of Kerala's Communist run Government has devoted a few pages to Gramdan wherein he states : "The objective which Bhawe placed before the people is as revolutionary as any Socialist or Communist would have . . . However, this objective is to be realized not through prolonged process of political struggle by the working people under the leadership of the working class but through persuasion and change of heart. This is the essence of Gramdan or Gandhism at its latest phase and it is here that it differs from Marxism." The book concludes with the following words : "As for the Communists, it is clear to them that political power is an essential factor in the struggle for socio-economic transformation. They will, therefore, certainly wish Bhawe and his colleagues well, do all that is within their power to help the propagation of the ideals of the Gramdan movement, but will never give up their struggle for political power."

The whole thread of thought throbs with thirst for power. Except good wishes to Vinoba no genuine interest was shown

* *Bhoodan*, www.vinoba.in English Weekly dated 20-5-1959

to the movement by the politicians of this troubled state. Nor could the movement itself improve the tone of political life in the state through genuine consistent constructive work. The stagnation of the movement becomes more apparent when we look to the Experimental Area of Krumbranad.

Inward Causes of Stagnation

This region, (Krumbranad) soon after its selection as an experimental area, attracted a large number of workers with profundity and integrity like Shri R. K. Menon of Ramnatkara. But the whole thing crashed for lack of any purposeful planning, fool-proof organization, proper assignments and co-ordination amongst workers that had gathered from different parts of Kerala at the call of Vinobaji. The hopes withered as quickly as they had bloomed. For lack of a far-sighted planning for the area, nobody knew what he was to do. It was a 'free-for-all' affair. The whole approach had no edge to it. Study of the felt need of the people, their local resources and indigenous industries was not attended to. Overthrow of the middleman-ship through a well-conceived co-operative activity in the field of credit, production, processing and marketing was not even remotely contemplated. All that came from the leadership was ideological trash. Khadi became the main 'mantram' and the major plank of approach, whereas people deserved to be led into the sound organization of coir industry, coconut marketing and processing and relief from usury through private credit. Without any zeal from the people the patent approach was to direct them to apply for funds from the Khadi Board and Commission on the basis of the leadership's own outdated assumptions of village work that Khadi was the only panacea for all the village ills. Moreover, people who could not be content by sheer oratory demanded workers who could stay put, see through the experiment and lead them fight the inertia step by step. There was hardly any cadre available beyond orators and the inevitable followed. The Gramdan office in Krumbranad was finally wound up and lodged in Calicut to mark the retreat and strengthen the conclusion that Sarvodaya lacks the masons of the new order envisaged under the concept of Gramdan. As such the promise and hope held out by Gram-

dan almost petered out. At best it could be called a short lived emotional outburst. Further, the entire body of Sarvodaya Mandal revolves around Shri Kelappan who, in spite of his pledge to devote himself entirely to the cause of Gramdan has not yet weaned himself away from politics — his life long game which he so sincerely and selflessly played. With his feet in Sarvodaya, his head is as yet in politics.

With due respect for his sincerity one can't help the necessary evaluation of his role in the new assignment of Sarvodaya leadership in the 'problem' state of Kerala. Actually Shri Kelappan at this age has taken on himself much more than he can carry. The result is obvious. While Gramdan work was a full fledged assignment he took up the Shanti Sena affair also on himself. When Shanti Sena failed to be effective and could not bring in more than a dozen adherents, he came out with his idea of Shanti Mandal with an elastic code of conduct. But, surprisingly enough, the same personnel is shuffled and reshuffled to raise a mess of denominations which all end in smoke. When Gramdan work got the tempo the diversion to Shanti Sena provided a consoling escape. When that did not click, Sarvodaya Patra was flung, then came Shanti Mandal and then the fast that also misfired and did not change the situation in the state challenged by reactionary elements.

The whole trend speaks of some deep rooted frustration in Sarvodaya circles in Kerala, particularly where the challenge is greater. A more well-knit organization of the Communists with a sound economic programme and stability in its ministerial position had, perhaps, obsessed and blurred the vision of Sarvodaya leadership. Nevertheless, had the Sarvodaya leaders devoted themselves fully to grapple with the field problems, their moral leadership in the state would have been more soundly established even on the then present ruling party. But one regrets that it did not happen.

One only wishes that there was more of attention to the Gramdan work. A little realism could show much better results in the field. The pity is that very few adherents have been 'through the mill' regarding agrarian aspect of rural work and rural community handling. Even then, if some agronomists and experts in community organization were brought in to act-

vise Gramdan units and co-ordinate the activities of different organizations and government agencies for some effective pioneering work in this sector, things would have been quite different.

The meetings of the Kerala Sarvodaya Mandal are equally listless. They are ideology inspired rather than action inspired. There is lack of discussion and a cozy demonstration of pious platitudes. Everybody says 'Allah-O-Akbar' after the Imam (the Muslim priest) as the saying goes. Every one competes with the other to show more lip-reverence to Vinoba but lack of audacity to face the real problems posed by the movement. Bull-sessions and red-hot debates are perhaps unimaginable in the history of Sarvodaya.

Koraput and Kerala

That there was lack of proper organization, competent leadership and consistent planning becomes clearer when we compare the Sarvodaya approach at Koraput in Orissa where things were on a bigger scale and were handled at an all-India level through Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh under the command of Shri A. W. Sahasrabudhe. It will have to be kept in view that although Koraput work started in 1955 under the patronage of Shri N. K. Chaudhury — the then Chief Minister — but later it proceeded in spite of all the possible hurdles put by Shri Mahtab. The latter on resumption of power fell on Bhoodan and Gramdan and transferred all pro-Gramdan officials and unleashed the worst lot to hunt out the ghosts of Gramdan from Koraput and finally from Orissa.

In spite of Yelwal meeting which did not bring any improvement except in statements a number of criminal cases were lodged against Gramdan workers (like Shri Nagin who had studied at Oxford) under Section 447 I.P.C. (trespass). Section 379 (theft) was used against Shri Alekh Patra (although the court found it all fishy and brushed the case out) who, as a head of the marketing section dealing in direct purchase of produce from Gramdan villages through an investment of about 6 lakhs, was actively consolidating the tribal economy against moneylenders and traders. The villagers were equally harassed. The settlement staff (Koraput being under the

Maharaja till recently was without any land settlement) refused to accept community ownership of the village lands and forced people to individual ownership pattern. Legally the State did not accept anything as Gramdan but the State Co-operative Department (with no District Bank operating in Koraput) presumed it and refused credit. On the other hand, moneylenders were encouraged to lodge cases against Gramdan villagers who had already paid many times more than the principal and had been deprived of a good chunk of their lands.

It was against this background that Koraput Gramdans were activated. The attitude of Sarvodaya camp led by Shri A. W. Sahasrabudhe has been steady, unruffled and exploratory in spite of all the administrative and political adversity. Seen comparatively, Kerala had a much less hostile or much more favourable political atmosphere for Gramdan. Physically Kerala has an area $1\frac{1}{2}$ times, population 11 times, density of population 8 times that of Koraput. In the latter, the tribals form 80 per cent of the total population, in the former they are only 10 per cent. The position regarding different aspects of Gramdan work in the case of the two regions is as under :

Item	Kerala	Koraput*
1. Number of Gramdans	543	1,483
2. Number of families involved	12,084	20,324
3. Percentage of population of Adivasis in these Gramdans	10%	80%
4. Total land donated under Gramdans	Not calculated by any agency	219, 106 acres.
5. No. of Gramdans where land has been redistributed	—	741
6. Land kept for community cultivation in item 5	—	2,695 acres.
7. Landless families benefited under item 5	—	3,982 (population 17,689)
8. Gramdan defined	Any 20 families in a compact area.	Entire population of a hamlet or a village.

* Figures taken from 'Gramdan in Koraput' — Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh publication.

It is clear that in Kerala the movement though it aims at solution of the land problem has hardly touched the fringe of it. Negligible landless population has been affected by the movement here.

Leadership

The person at the helm in Koraput Gramdams, as already stated, has been Shri A. W. Sahasrabudhe who all through his career has been mostly confined to the back-waters of rural economy or occasionally to the jail during national struggle. He is perhaps the hardest nut among Sarvodaya leadership who stuck totally to Gramdan work and never cared to bother about Shanti Sēna, Sarvodaya Patra etc. Genuinely interested in the field-work he has that 'down-to-earth' attitude which really counts but is lacking in Sarvodaya leadership in general and Kerala in particular.

But divided in two forces, the Sarvodaya ballast with out-moded monastic concepts on one side and the eagerness to get quick results for the benefit of the villagers on the other — Shri Anna (A. W. Sahasrabudhe) favours the use of electricity, has genuine faith in experts and loves to learn through constructive aspects of Communism in China or the capital intensive but decentralised industries in Japan with its labour intensive small farms which impressed him much during his visit to Japan. Well, one feels sorry to say but it has to be said that Kerala leadership is no match for Shri Anna in implementing Gramdan.

Technicians

Aware of the important role of technicians Shri Anna could draw a good team of technicians who were responsive to the implications of integrated approach involved in Gramdan work. Mr. Albert Mayer rightly says, "Engineers are spiritually and professionally a sort of closed fraternity whose main interest is in large and complicated projects and who don't in a really vital way and in their daily work feel or act as friends of the people." But Shri K. R. Datye, Executive Engineer, Central Water and Power Commission proved an exception. He got two years leave to put Koraput work on its feet. In all, during the peak season of Koraput work the development team had:—

(a) Engineering graduates (including Shri K. R. Datye)	= 3
(b) Agriculture "	= 3
(c) B. Sc. Technology "	= 1
(d) Science graduates	= 3
(e) Law "	= 1
(f) Anthropology, Economics, Public Administration and Planning etc. graduates	= 6
(g) Field workers, with experience in agriculture, qualified under post basic course at Sevagram and elsewhere	= 5
(h) Cottage industries and social welfare personnel, field and clerical staff	=200

Vast avenues of integrated rural development and high social idealism drew workers from all parts of India. But all this team co-ordinated under an administrative set-up comprised of different sections like, Ideology, Engineering, Agriculture, Marketing, Cottage industries etc., made Shri Mahtab suspicious about the motives of the Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh which, at a stage, was accused of running a parallel administration. Against this fine pageant, Kerala had almost nothing to present in Gramdan field. There was no planning, or executive set-up, no youthful team. There was little to stimulate the imagination; no bull sessions, no cock fights between the utopians and the 'down-to-earth' fellows, between expansionists and the integrationists, softies and hardies. No challenge from the young to the old, or from the ascetic to the bureaucrat and *vice versa*. No tapping of the talent either. It was all a drift.

The Approach

To make the influence felt all over the Gramdan areas in Koraput a chain of consumers' stores was spread even into the far flung areas along with land distribution followed by minor irrigation, land improvement and soil conservation programmes. Marketing was also taken up on a large scale and a few pilot projects were taken for supervised credit operations. Legal aid which was not forthcoming from the state was arranged through the Sarva Seva Sangh. This comprehensive approach reasonably brought the following remarks about the overall working of Koraput from Mr. Maurice Zinkin an ex I.C.S.,

who had served as a District Magistrate in Bombay State during the British days. In a B.B.C. talk reported in the *Listener* dated September 26, 1957, he says about his visit to Koraput :

"In Koraput many of the villages form themselves into co-operatives, where all the land is owned by the village as a whole though it is worked by individuals. Workers have come from all over India to help the aboriginals make a success of this new experiment. There are about 150 of them for the 300 villages on which they are concentrating. Many of them are much less skilled than the regular officers of government departments, but there are many more than there could possibly be of government officials for that number of villages, and to some extent they make up in devotion for what they lack in skill. I found that they had seen clearly the need to tackle everything at once."

Actually, critical observers to Koraput have made positive contributions to development work there. But Gramdan appears to be a sealed book in Kerala. All this is being discussed here to show that Sarvodaya can come upto any challenge if the steering is properly done. Undoubtedly, all is not well at Koraput but it will be irrelevant to touch on that subject here. However, lack of militancy, abundance of inner conflicts, inconsistencies, divided loyalties, quick shifting of emphases, and hostile attitude of administration brought about a situation which somewhat necessitated the co-ordination with the C.P.A. This is being put on trial at Koraput through a pilot project to be launched at Limbaguda on October 2, 1959 where the development personnel is to be provided by the Sarva Seva Sangh and the material resources are to be mobilized by the C.P.A. which is a new venture, full of hope. It equally needs a trial elsewhere to blend the social idealism of Sarvodaya with the vast material resources of C.P.A. But Gandhi Smarak Nidhi, the organization of Shri G. Ramachandran — a great exponent of co-ordination — is merely sitting on the fence in Kerala.

First two years of work in Koraput had convinced the leadership to have priority of agriculture over cottage industries programme. The open mind of the planners made co-

operation operative in so many respects even in the absence of any satisfactory official co-operative set up in the district. Although it has not come up to the expectations, but still the said approach had its impact on the Koraput economy. Money-lenders did retreat from certain areas. Garanda village showed remarkable results in agricultural production through Gramdan approach where Shri Reddy came out as the topmost pioneer, made a mark on the planners and won high admiration from persons like Shri R. K. Patil and Mr. Evelyn Wood. What has Kerala to show? Its isolated experiments may be gasping for life if the area of operation is not extended and experiments are not reinforced by an all round approach.

If Sarvodaya leadership at Koraput could do this much in spite of all the ideological, organizational, regional and administrative hurdles it could have certainly faced the challenge in Kerala!

Silver Lining

However, the movement in Kerala can claim partial success that can be stated as under :

1. The movement reveals that a section of the rural population feels the necessity of a non-official approach to their problems and is eager to break the stalemate.
2. The people respond well if the work starts from the felt needs of the people and they get sentimentally closer to face the common blockade to their economic growth (as seen at Naduvattam in Bamboo work).
3. Denied a proper organization at the top, capable workers showed lot of initiative in the field and guided by their own light could show partial successes in their ventures.
4. The movement is fortunate to have Shri R. K. Menon, Shri K. Poduwal, Sarva Shri Oommen, Velayudhan, M. V. Krishnan and T. Gopalan who have the pioneering tendencies and consequent dash and drive to break in new inroads into rural development and with or without the help of state agencies have taken up independent co-operative ventures.
5. The co-operative ventures wherever taken up have a peculiarity of a better human relationship where people unlike the official co-operatives are sincerely trying to rise above self-

interest. These ventures due to their agility provide an encouraging educational atmosphere in co-operation in a sharp contrast to government-raised target-whipped co-operatives about which Mr. Albert Mayer has remarked with a punch of satire. "The Government will continue to run the co-operatives, they will continue not to belong to the people, the people will continue uninterested."

6. The workers leading a number of experiments don't lack in sincerity of purpose and have been instrumental in bringing about the necessary social cohesion. They have challenged the inertia of individual members and altered the agencies and interests well-entrenched in land, trade or credit.

7. The trusteeship concept at Vellinezhi, although a partial success on a small scale, is almost entirely a new venture and shows some hope for the solution of the vexed problem about agrarian relationship.

Now we will study the practical results in the experiments carried out in the agrarian sector dealt with in Part 3 with reference to production, management costs, capital investments, manner of distribution, etc. The reader will do well to refer to the table and the introductory note given in the beginning of Part 3 for a comparative picture of all the 5 experiments to be evaluated in the next chapter.

CHAPTER 26

Practical Results

(A) AGRICULTURE SECTOR

AS ALREADY stated, the performance in agriculture sector in different cases varies with the agencies which finance and the persons who execute them. Three of them *i.e.*, Nilambur, Paryaram and Nediyrippu are new settlements of former tenants and landless labourers. The remaining two at Vellinezhi and Thachancode have been under peasant proprietorship; at Vellinezhi the trusteeship concept and at the latter the comprehensive scientific co-operation are on trial.

Three new settlements have a total area of 2691 acres with 800 acres only under cultivation by 197 landless families through 9 buffalo pairs costing Rs. 1700.00 but mostly through hand cultivation. Out of this 380 acres are under co-operative cultivation and 420 acres are outside it. Rights of landless people have been individually established on 50 acres and collectively on 750 acres.

62.07 acres of the area under the phase of Gramdan have previously been under peasant proprietorship out of which 53.07 acres are under cultivation through 8 buffalo pairs. 32.97 acres are under co-operative cultivation and 20.10 acres are outside it. 23 families are involved herein which include 9 landless families also but without any legal right on land.

The Sarva Seva Sangh, the Sarvodaya Mandal (and to some extent Gandhi Smarak Nidhi also) the state, one indi-

vidual landlord as a trustee and one group of peasant proprietors are the agencies involved.

In all Rs. 370528.00 are being invested on the settlements out of which Rs. 239180.00 flow from the state (including Rs. 82280.00 for Nediirippu colony). The rest i.e., Rs. 131348.00 are from private agencies (Sarvodaya Mandal 6100.00, Sarva Seva Sangh 3600.00, Gandhi Smarak Nidhi 600.00 and other personal and miscellaneous donations including the forest yield come up to Rs. 121048.00). This latter sum formed the initial investment. Out of all this Rs. 137000.00 have been spent on reclamation, Rs. 99280.00 have been spent on housing, Rs. 4500.00 have been spent on drinking wells and Rs. 8700.00 have been spent on tools, etc. The yield varies from 5 maunds to 36½ maunds of paddy per acre. Grouping ranges from 8 to 100 families. Paddy area ranges from 6.97 to 175 acres. Now we will study the performance under particular heads beginning with production.

Production

The production is highest in an individually managed joint-farm at Vellinezhi with the yield of 36½ maunds of paddy per acre due to the factor of personal interest by Shri Poduwal, the primary owner. The trusteeship concept has brought more income to Shri Poduwal than he used to get as an individual owner before this socio-psychological shift in his relationship with property as well as the farm hands. Equally more income has been ensured to the farm hands whose personal interest has been drawn and initiative released as a result of the new bonds.

At Thachancode under co-operative management, the production is medium i.e., 9 maunds 8 seers but is as low as 5 maunds at Nilambur which has large scale management on a new settlement under collective farming where the worker is connected with the wage and not the produce which forms one half of Thachancode and one-seventh of Vellinezhi. The paddy cultivation at Nediirippu and Paryaram is negligible.

The Management Costs

With management as yet least effective, the management costs are going to be the highest at Nediirippu i.e., Rs. 6.00

as compared to Rs. 3.6 per acre per annum at Nilambur. The managerial costs per family per annum at Nediirippu will be Rs. 53.5 and at Nilambur they will be Rs. 36.00. With no costs involved, the management is quite effective at Thachancode. The costs of management at Vellinezhi can't be assessed due to the undefined relationship of Shri Poduwal with the farm, its operations and yields. At Paryaram Rs. 41.00 per month seems to be the cost of mismanagement rather than management.

Capital Investment

The sources of capital investment at Vellinezhi are personal and out of the pocket and the profits are being ploughed back in the farm development like irrigation facilities being introduced for double cropping on a larger area. At Thachancode the capital comes from a parental co-operative body—the the Gramdan Co-operative Society. At Paryaram the sources are both official and non-official but the investment has been scanty, unsustained and haphazard. At Nediirippu the sources have been both official and non-official but the grants etc., have been lapsing for want of leadership to mobilize the popular zeal amongst the settlers for collective development.

At Nilambur there is going to be considerably liberal capital investment out of the exploitation of forest as well as the state which is advancing sums in lakhs for various development operations. This has partly led to the introduction of the wage system in that settlement.

Manner of Distribution

All the three places that have introduced co-operative farming have different manners of distribution. The principle of egalitarian equality has prevailed at Thachancode due to the personality of Shri Velayudhan. The principle of 'according to the needs' is working due to the easy availability of funds at Nilambur. And the bonus in kind, in addition to the wages is paid at Vellinezhi due to the high idealism of Shri Poduwal and practical utility of the trusteeship concept. At Thachancode the yield is distributed on the basis of family members. At Nilambur wage system with additional allowance provisions for more members is in practice. Here the rates of wages

vary with the nature and not the output of work. At Vellinezhi wage system is buttressed by the bonus in kind, out of the total yield.

Best Economic Use

Labour and land have been put to best economic use at Vellinezhi with direct effect on the economic conditions of the participants. The production and income figures before this new experimentation could not be available to calculate the actual benefits. But the intensity of labour has increased due to more of personal interest by farm hands.

At Nilambur the economy of scales has not shown tangible results in production, although use of surplus labour in direct capital formation through bunding and soil conservation is operative. House building in that connection is also a prospective study within the next few years there.

At Thachancode intensity of labour has been lacking due to lack of incentives, hence the low output.

At Nediyrrippu or Paryaram no animal power is in use. Man power with necessary implements has replaced the same to meet the paucity of capital.

Nilambur has the highest acreage i.e., 20 acres per buffalo pair under paddy cultivation. Vellinezhi had $1\frac{1}{2}$ acres and Thachancode had $2\frac{1}{3}$ acres per buffalo pair.

Higher Techniques

Paradoxically enough, the higher scientific techniques of production which are generally said to accompany large scale farming have been neglected at Nilambur. But improved implements, and seeds, rational application of manure and fertilizers, diversified crop economy, deep ploughing, thin planting, more weeding and better facilities for irrigation have been patronized most at Vellinezhi and to a lesser degree at Thachancode. Nilambur with its large scale operations based on collective footing could easily afford to maintain an expert for advice in crop planning, layout and farm operations but it has so far avoided it for unknown reasons whereas an expert attached to the Nediyrrippu colony by the State is unfortunately looking to his own neighbouring estate rather than the colony.

Elimination of the Middlemen

The nature of co-operation being more comprehensive at Thachancode the middlemen have been totally eliminated out of the field of credit. The debts of the members of the Gramdan co-operative society have been brought down from Rs. 26,000.00 to Rs. 5,000.00 during the last four years of co-operative credit operations, it was stated. In marketing, purchase and processing also, the middlemen here are being thrown out of the ring, but their menace has rather increased at Nedi-yirippu. The co-operative store gives only a partial service at Nilambur where co-operation seems out of compulsion. At Thachancode co-operation in purchase and marketing etc. is based on understanding and natural urge to draw the benefits that accrue out of it.

Miscellaneous

The output at Nilambar shows a loss of Rs. 30.00 per acre. But at Vellinezhi each farm hand family got 5 bags of paddy in addition to the wages earned. At Thachancode 187 work days are shown to have been put in each acre under paddy cultivation possibly due to lack of enforcement of working hours and the consequent wage system. But only 62.8 work days per acre of paddy were put in at Nilambur which had half the yield per acre as compared to Thachancode and one-seventh to that of Vellinezhi for which work days per acre are not available.

Social services like child welfare, medical aid, general hygiene and adult education are neglected almost everywhere.

Social objectives involved in Gramdan are followed more thoroughly at Thachancode, less at Vellinezhi still less at Nilambur but least at Paryaram.

The working is more democratic at Thachancode, more personal and human at Vellinezhi, despotic and routinised at Nilambur, individualistic at Nedi-yirippu and both despotic and individualistic at Paryaram.

Apart from Bhoodan lands, nowhere in Gramdan villages has land been redistributed or ownership changed hands as aimed at by the movement.

There is no centre to educate Gramdan workers in agricultural operations, farm accounting and general agricultural economics. Nor is there any agronomist, planner or social scientist engaged by the various organizations for Gramdan follow up work. Any advisory committee of experts on such matters was also found missing.

(B) NON-AGRICULTURE SECTOR

In non-agricultural sector one factor is quite obvious. The success of the experiment has not been due to the agency concerned or the availability of the material like bamboo, coir or cotton, but mainly due to the man behind the whole effort who could bring about the necessary emotional integration to break up the traditional hurdles and shake up the general inertia. The agencies involved have, however, been Gandhi Smarak Nidhi in Bamboo work, Intense Area Scheme in coir work and Khadi Commission, Khadi Board or Khadi Gramodyog Sangh in Khadi.

In other ventures at Ramnatkara and Vinoba Niketan, all the organizations have been integrated but with different results. Now we will take these non-agricultural ventures one by one.

I. Bamboo

If in agricultural sector Shri Velayudhan's work is on a firm scientific footing towards a sound socio-economic transformation, Shri P. C. Oommen leads in the non-agricultural side on that account. Through organization of the bamboo industry and the allied co-operative activities by ramming through all the hurdles created by the well-entrenched middlemen and vested interests, Shri Oommen has brought employment to 100 persons, respect and stature to the people, to the movement and to social engineering. Working on a more democratic footing he has led the people to harness local leadership. His socio-economic venture has brought about a thorough emotional integration among the people. His work is an indicator perhaps in the right direction. But his Gandhi Smarak Nidhi backed co-operative venture, starved of capital,



has at a later stage to find out ways to link itself up with the main co-operative framework of the state as already done by Shri Velayudhan Pillai at Thachancode in his own sphere of activity. The sphere of operation equally needs extension for such militant co-operative ventures in the surrounding Gramdan pockets to dislodge and rout the exploiting agencies for good and bring about the required unity in the rural producers for mutual progress.

II. Coir

The break-through, by Shri T. Gopalan at Tikkoti, of the cordon of the Intensive Area Scheme at Mudadi is another experiment full of hope which through healthy co-operative community organization of 42 families provides a corrective to the conventional approach and is an equally bright hint of the possible new approaches through such rigid agencies. Tied up merely with Khadi programme and divorced from the indigenous industries and local initiative the schemes will certainly collapse like the castles of cards. The community spirit roused in any constructive manner shall have to be harnessed by such development agencies if they hope to be operative in the rural sphere, and necessary finance, advice and aid shall have to be provided for such ventures. The field agencies will do well to initiate such ventures and later serve as liaison between the people and the state superstructure rather than tell people at the very outset to contact some such agencies as the Coir Board which exist only in the rarefied air of ivory towers at the metropolis or big cities.

III. Khadi

Almost in all the official undertakings about Khadi work the same rubber-stamp approach with a pre-fab structure of financing, training and then closing the eyes towards the follow-up is visible. Excepting the work of Gramodyog Khadi Sangh — a non-official organization at Balusseri under Shri M. V. Krishnan — there is lack of perspective, agility and initiative in the Khadi work executed by the Mudadi Intensive Area (Khadi Commission) Pantalayini and Neeleshwaram Gramdan Co-operative Societies (both under the Kerala Khadi Board patronage) and Balusseri N.E.S. Block. At most of the places

the approach is sectional, the trainees are recruited mostly from the middle class. Those for whom the programme is actually meant generally keep away. The emphasis is more on training and publicity less on production and least on social objectives. The economic impact of the Ambar training on rural economy of Gramdans is negligible. Compared to the costs to the Government, the ratio of gains to the village people is depressingly low. There is an easy availability of funds for Khadi work but at places the Khadi Board staff was found unpaid for number of months thereby affecting the quality of training. There is a general lack of sentimental cohesion among the zealots of Khadi and the people because of an attitude of neglect to study the local conditions. Ready-made solutions presented from some metropolitan centre are pushed down the field. As such the programmes seem lifeless and are carried out listlessly. The work and the workers remain confined to the premises of the training centres losing all valuable contact with the field and the prevailing sentiment there. More obligation is felt towards the organization at the top, less towards the people down on soil. It appears to be a drift in a blind alley.

The working hours at the training centres are not strictly observed. The training proved insufficient. No provision for servicing is made and the blacksmiths and carpenters of the village are not persuaded to handle the mechanism of the Ambar, etc.

To develop an aptitude for skilled work, the unskilled hands are not first trained at the Kisan Charkha. Instead, Ambar Charkha is introduced at the very outset which proves embarrassing for the trainee, the moment it is taken home. As a result, soon after the training programme the thawing starts. A *'laissez faire'* attitude sets in and the line of least resistance is accepted. Mass contact is feared, as such Ambar yarn could not be made popular with hand-loom weavers. So also even with poor production, marketing becomes a problem. There is so much of isolation around Khadi work that all other forces at work in the rural sector clearly exposed by the Rural Credit Survey Report are not at all grappled with but are comfortably taken for granted. As a result, the artisan finds his allies

effeminate and deserts. Even the weavers trained in Ambar weaving retreated back to mill yarn at places because of the lack of integrated programme as worked out by the handloom industry in these parts.

New ways and means have to be found as Shri Oommen did to bring about the emotional integration of the exploited and stranded mass of workers and the issues have to be fought with a stubborn, militant attitude to overthrow the middlemanship by strengthening the co-operative spirit which alone can restore confidence and raise dignity of the artisans and craftsmen by socially dethroning money and the money class which still rules the rural roost. With a view to stabilizing the rural economy and ensuring employment to the needy the social idealism involved in Khadi and village industries work has to be roused among rural consumers who are naturally inclined towards simple living and neighbourliness. For that the sector needs perhaps more of Krishnans, Oommens, Velayudhans and T. Gopalans.

The Intensive Area Scheme which is considered to be the main spearhead of the Khadi work has failed to deliver the goods at Mudadi. Figures speak for themselves. Mudadi Intensive Area, Gramodyog Khadi Sangh at Balusseri and Vinoba Niketan at Malayadi have an equal amount of yarn production per month i.e., 5000 hanks but establishment charges at Mudadi are Rs. 1000 p.m., at Vinoba Niketan they are about Rs. 600.00 (4 Khadi workers and 3 Gram Sahayaks). But at G. K. Sangh (Gramodyog Khadi Sangh) of Shri M. V. Krishnan, the establishment costs are about Rs. 300.00 p.m. (4 workers). The building costs at Mudadi are at the highest, at Vinoba Niketan they are moderate but G. K. Sangh has not invested on buildings. Mudadi Intensive Area sends part of its yarn to Madras for weaving in spite of the Area headquarters being surrounded by weavers. Vinoba Niketan sends it 60 miles away to Nagarcoil but G. K. Sangh does everything locally.

On the whole, more of objectivity and impartial evaluation of work is necessary to create the necessary alertness in performance and end the '*laissez faire*' attitude. Better salesmanship of ideas and awareness of the general business management, introduction of graphs, charts and targets, study of other

ventures in the similar field under similar circumstances could equally be helpful to whip up the activity on all counters. Workers have to be told about Acharya J. B. Kriplani's work in U.P. and Bihar where Khadi clicks so well as to employ nearly two lakhs of people. Even the neighbouring state Tamilnad has much to teach on that account.

IV. Integrated Approach

Shri R. K. Menon at Ramnatkara, correlates the functions of so many organizations in his work of building up an industrial (cottage)-cum-educational village where the spirit of fellow-feeling has resulted in sharing of incomes. The educational programme allied with the essential social services missing elsewhere throughout the Gramdan sphere in Kerala is a compliment to Shri R. K. Menon. Capital formation through Shramdan contributed in the construction of buildings like the houses, school, the community store and the cottage industries barracks is a sound venture at Ramnatkara. This place has all the wherewithals except agricultural land to serve as a good educational and research centre to grasp the muse, lore, humour and social habits of the rural folk on which to base the approach to the rural mind and thus have a better overall tone of the village work.

V. Institutions for Rural Work

This institution has also integrated in its working, the role of different organizations and has received the patronage of the state ministry as well in the shape of allotment of 10 acres of land. Khadi Commission, Kerala Khadi Board, Social Welfare Board, Gandhi Smarak Nidhi and Sarva Seva Sangh are found to be instrumental in activising this institution. As such, it is caught up more in the financial strains and obligations. It is facing less towards the people due to the inherent weaknesses of such institutions. Sarvodaya leadership will do well to revise its policy of running such institutions in the light of new demands on the movement.

Smt. Rajamma's quest for leadership seems to have stood in her way to build up a strong base of rural work at Vinoba Niketan. Shri Velayudhan Pillai seems to have a far greater vision of both agricultural and non-agricultural work than any



of the leaders and workers in Gramdan circles but his attitude towards this rural centre seems to have been of 'wait and watch'. With the control of the institution passing on to Shri Velayudhan Pillai there is a great possibility of partial realization of hopes laid on the institution by the neighbouring villages for activating co-operative community life.

Now we pass on to crystallize the role of agencies excepting Sarvodaya Mandal which has been fairly treated in the preceding discussion about the success or stagnation of the movement.

CHAPTER 27

The Role of Agencies

OBJECTIVES OF the agencies working in the Gramdan field are almost identical in that all of them propose to revitalise the rural economy through cottage industries and better human relationship. Coming to grips with the total outlay for the Gramdan villages by all the agencies (excluding the state's straight grants for soil conservation and housing etc.) the picture is as under for the year 1958-59.

	Lakhs
(a) Khadi Commission through Kerala	
Khadi Board Grants	2.58
Loans	3.45
(b) Khadi Commission through	
Intensive Area Scheme Mudadi Grants	.20
(c) Gandhi Smarak Nidhi	.81*
(d) Sarvodaya Mandal	.33
(e) Sarva Seva Sangh	N.A.*
TOTAL	7.37

With this 7.37 lakhs of outlays mainly in Khadi and Cottage Industries, the results in the field have already been

* Gandhi Smarak Nidhi deprived of perspective and personnel has curtailed it to .32 lakhs. The Sarva Seva Sangh outlays could not be available. (The work of Sarva Seva Sangh mainly centred around Parli in Palghat District which could not be covered since things were reported in quite a formative stage there.)

evaluated. The benefits to the people can be stated to be meagre. Financial outlays being enough, the personnel and effective planning have been the weakest point with every agency. Wherever a right type of person is available the results are tangible, elsewhere it is a mere spending programme with no plan allied to the region.

The leadership, executive and advisory bodies of all the above provincial agencies are constituted more or less by the same persons who consciously or unconsciously exercise a co-ordinating influence but the programmes seem to have proved less effective. The total approach is just a gamble, lacking in any deliberate effort to wrestle with the issues. There is a lesser liking for the rigours of regional planning as was expected of these agencies.

It appears the people in these agencies have come in not duly enlightened about a planned economy in the village sector but have somehow escaped into these bodies. The public interest in these agencies is equally dull. Majority of the people feel Khadi or Cottage work is a mere charity and in contrast with the national waste going on elsewhere this charity is quite negligible and hence tolerable. Now we will take up the agencies individually.

Kerala Gandhi Smarak Nidhi

As is clear from the facts laid down in Chapter 11 the Gandhi Smarak Nidhi funds are to be exhausted by 1965. Consequently, there is a sort of haphazard activity. The Nidhi remains on the lookout for channels of expenditure and its programmes are mostly spending programmes but, since the amounts sanctioned for village work lie unspent and some centres lie unmanned, the village centres are being drastically reduced. As such, the Nidhi is receding from village work and by trying to specialize in opening study circles and talking centres in the cities it is endeavouring to convince people that Gandhiji stood for the cities more than the villages and preferred preaching to living.

The only centre activated so far in the Gramdan sphere is at Naduvattam (in Kaladi pocket) worked out by Shri P. C. Oommen for which the credit goes to the ability and courage

of Shri P. C. Oommen rather than the organization since things are at the lowest ebb in Balusseri which is also operating under Gandhi Smarak Nidhi.

It is surprising that the Nidhi has not found any fit person to take up work in the Balusseri Gramdan units which were bagged solely by the orators and preachers of the Nidhi itself. It should have been clear to the organization that signatures by the people for Gramdan entailed an equal responsibility on its own cadre and were the test of their ability and talent. Not that those at the helm of Gandhi Smarak Nidhi are unconscious of it. Shri G. Ramachandran who is now the All India chief of the Gandhi Smarak Nidhi, writing in '*Gandhi Marg*', January 1958 under 'Gramdan and the Community Development programme' states: "The dynamics of Gramdan is that it must lead to Gram-Nirman (Reconstruction of the village). No village can pass the test of Gramdan and fail in the test of Gram-Nirman. If there is failure in Gram-Nirman, it only means that there has not been the reality of Gramdan."

This he should bring to the mind of the whole ballast of the organization of Gandhi Smarak Nidhi which he is leading. The irony is that Shri G. Ramachandran is himself running an Ashram at Gandhigram in Madurai to train workers for such assignments and the Kerala branch of the Nidhi is spending one to two lakhs of rupees on study circles and youth camps. Those holding the reins of the organizations have to see why they have failed to inspire and train the youth for such responsibilities as the Gramdan entails. The organization has to ask its personnel if they have any grain of faith in the ideology before they start haranguing about it to the lamp posts and trees in the cities.

Shri G. Ramachandran, in the same article quoted above convincingly discussing the issue of co-ordination of the Gramdan Movement with Community Development states, "The achievement of the unity of Sarvodaya workers and those engaged in the community development programme is one of the urgent and needed tasks in India today" and concludes, "The practical idealism and selfless devotion of the Sarvodaya workers must now combine with the tremendous personnel and material resources available to the community development

programme. If this does not happen we shall be turning away foolishly from one of the greatest possibilities in the India of today."

The folly is to be shared merely by the Gandhi Smarak Nidhi whose workers having netted these Gramdans are expected to be a liaison between the people and the state agencies if they have to play a positive rôle in village development. But the whole approach of the Nidhi seems to be emotional, oratorical, evasive, ineffective and non-comprehensive.

The convener of the Kerala branch of the Gandhi Smarak Nidhi is working on all the various bodies in an advisory capacity as if all is well with his own organization and talent can be spared for others. The experiment carried out by Shri P. C. Oommen needs further consolidation and fully integrated programme for marketing, processing, etc. along with the improvement of agriculture but the financial outlays by the Nidhi intend only a piecemeal solution and not a comprehensive approach; as such the battle may be lost. If the piloting could be properly done at Naduvattam, valuable data might be available for wider application and further radiation but one doubts if the Nidhi has at all gauged the possible impact of such adventures.

It is really deplorable that out of the members of this body none excepting Shri R. K. Menon is a man of the field. As such, the steering of the organization may not in the long run be in the interest of a sound pioneering work towards rural community organization. The main drift in the organization is to show more of verbal and intellectual output than some sound results in the field. It also takes on itself to finance and convene the meetings of Shanti Mandal, Shanti Sena, etc.; as such the whole effort is diffused. The seminar held at Alwaye in the last three days of December 1958 under the auspices of Gandhi Nidhi was quite illustrative of the prevalent tendencies in the body. The leaders invariably left after delivering speeches, taking 70 per cent of the time. By the time Gramdan came up for discussion there was no Gramdan worker except Shri Poduwal to actively participate. Very few out of the organization have tasted the flavour of field work hence the jarring routinized approach to things prevails. That is the fate of the organization handling Gandhiji's money.

Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh

This All India organization is the main vehicle to propagate Sarvodaya; it also finances and executes Bhoodan and Gramdan. In Kerala, as elsewhere, it has been active mainly in Khadi sphere. As such, it has an impressive role in Khadi work but poor performance in agricultural management which is apparent from the conditions at Paryaram compared to Shri M. V. Krishnan's work at Ballusseri (affiliated to Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh).

The pace of distribution of Bhoodan lands has been rather disappointingly slow. As already stated, only 2126 acres have been distributed out of 29021 acres received by the end of 1958.

Except that the figures in lakhs of acres have served the purpose of a few idealists for propapanda use and prestige value of the movement, the landless have not yet been allowed access to them nor have the lands been put to best economic use. Both the social and economic objectives of the movement are thereby lost by its very sponsors. And critics get a handle to accuse the movement of blunting the edge of an economic upsurge and slacken drastic legislative measures.

If Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh or Sarvodaya Mandal can't do the distribution work it would be wiser to seek the co-operation of the state in final disposal or distribution of these lands. Otherwise, Bhoodan becomes another privileged form of absentee landlordism. Practical steps are required to be taken to make a study of all these donations and the nature of land. If no other agency can take up this task on itself, the title of these lands may be passed on to the Panchayats to use them for pastures, plantations and afforestation, in case the lands are found unfit for cultivation. But something has to be done to end the present attitude of neglect towards these lands which are being regularly encroached upon in certain parts of the state by shrewd persons rather than the deserving ones as was reported in Wynad taluk.

The role of the organization in rural development is mostly Khadi confined. New objectives of a comprehensive village development as envisaged by the concept of Gramdan have not been grasped by its workers here. As such, the band wagon

of the organization moves in the same old conventional rut. But there is a new jolt.

With a view to stop the annual drain of about 3 lakhs of rupees that usually passed on to the central body out of the profits of Khadi work, the Tamilnad branch severed its relationship during the last year with the A.B.S.S.S. (Akhil, Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh). The latter, finding its Kerala Branch a liability to the extent Tamilnad was an asset, has disaffiliated the Kerala Branch and wants it to stand on an independent footing. This is an additional trial for the Khadi work in the state.

Lastly, the nomination of Smt. Rajamma as a member of the A.B.S.S.S., even though there are more capable workers active in the village sphere, has seriously affected the stature of this all-India body among constructive workers who want drastic changes in it to meet the situation created by new responsibilities in the field work.

Now we take up the role of official organizations like Khadi Commission and Kerala Khadi Board.

Khadi Commission

A good percentage of personnel of Akhil Bharat Charkha Sangh (Sarva Seva Sangh) walked into the services of the Commission after its formation at the centre. Some stuck to their work in the Sangh and the rest finding a new hope in Bhoodan and Gramdan plunged into these movements. The field lost much in this change over. The ranks lay divided. The austerities forced on the lower strata of workers undermined the whole morale.

At present, the constructive spirit that was once at the back of Khadi, stands bestrided by the bureaucratic centralized structure of Khadi Commission and the building up of heavy industries which, it is feared, will at a later stage create an atmosphere uncongenial to Khadi. The urban sector it is felt will gain a sound footing leaving the village in the same deplorable ditch or still worse.

The personnel too in the services of the Commission is an odd mixture of the sophisticated and the simple, official and the non-official but dominantly urban. Commission, in fact

is a strange freak of Nehru regime. Khadi workers feel that Khadi is kept as a relic in the museum of Indian economics but not in the thoroughfares of Indian planning. Shri Kelappan, member of the Kerala Khadi Board and an Honorary Organizer of the Mudadi Intensive Area Scheme ventilated partially this sense of defeat in his presidential address at the Eleventh Sarvodaya Sammelan at Ajmer on 27th February 1959 when he stated : "Our Governments are attempting an impossible task. They want to help all industries including village and large scale industries. The Government is unwilling to define the sphere of each. The consequence is we have big mechanized industries and cottage industries competing with each other. The result is waste of funds and the ruin of the weaker industry. The government will tax the mill industry to help the handloom industry. They want to help Khadi also, and therefore, subsidise Khadi a little more liberally with the pious hope that it will enable Khadi to compete with both mill cloth and handloom cloth. The result is, in this three cornered fight, Khadi goes to the wall and handloom has a precarious existence. The Government, if they feel that Khadi and Village Industries are the only solution of the unemployment in the village, have to stop this unequal competition. To be frank, this acceptance of help when the Government is not prepared to stop this unequal competition, has a baneful demoralizing effect on the movement itself. It blunts the edge of the revolutionary urge which the movement will otherwise develop and reduces Sarvodaya to a reform movement."

One feels inclined to politely ask : why are Shri Kelappan and his colleagues working out the Intensive Areas or holding the membership of the Kerala Khadi Board when they are perpetually aware of this demoralization? Unfortunately, pessimism is having a corrosive effect on the activities in the cottage sector. The challenge of the situation is not accepted. People's felt needs are not explored. Their heart-sores against major exploiters are not cured, and plans hardly click. If production is boosted, marketing becomes a problem. What market needs is not produced. Thinking is almost jammed and conditioned. Why? Most of the old fighters amongst rank and file, sick of the endless struggle against odds, are now secure in

the jobs under the Commission or the Boards. If power has corrupted the Congressites, the security offered by the Khadi Commission or Board and the sense of self-righteousness through the Gramdan movement has equally corrupted the constructive workers in the cottage sector. Money is cheaply available, offices are well set and the job is over. A few who have stayed out like Shri N. V. Krishnan and Shri Oommen have results to show, others have their history sheets spoiled by collapse of conscience. The programmes are far from being people's programmes. The plans come from above, allocations of funds are blindly made and there is no building from below as such. The Intensive Areas are even worse than the ordinary areas.

Borkhadi Village Plan at work — a Khadi and Village Industries Commission publication reveals that things could click only when the first thing was done first *i.e.*, the issues were settled with the exploiting landlord which helped the emotional integration of the people. Consequently, economic survey of the village had some meaning for the villagers and made the whole village plan conscious and economy conscious. Planning there at Borkhadi went deep to grapple (through new skills and promising leadership) with the economy of each family. The total economy too was linked up with the agencies of credit, technical advice and normal administration. The institutions at Borkhadi came to life and community services were introduced through income from the community land gifted by individual out of their holdings. The conventions and traditions that kept the economy backward were studied and fought patiently.

But not even 10 per cent of all this has been done anywhere in all the ventures taken up by the Commission directly or through the Provincial Board here. Obviously, this haphazard way of spending money and routinised, rubber stamp approaches are fast liquidating the whole idealism and importance attached to the development of the cottage sector of industries.

In what way the one year's training of Gram Sahayaks undertaken by Kora Gramodyog Kendra Bombay, is going to help the Gramdan villages, it is premature to judge at this stage but no organization without a basis of agriculture can serve or survive in the sphere of rural economy. No worker on the pay

rolls of such bodies as the Commission can easily keep up his dash. Moreover, in this atmosphere of defeatist mentality no better results can be expected. The field worker has a dual task to keep up his dignity and save the people's morale as well. The growing bureaucratic control in all the spheres of activity has to be checked. Only those who can challenge the major exploiters and can go in for bold independent ventures in regional planning can bring about the emotional integration of the people for a solid constructive programme at the village level. Social revolutions have never found patrons amongst bureaucracy. Only those 'down to earth' fellows who work independently and fearlessly at the lowest level and not merely the free flow of finances can turn the corner.

Locally, Kerala Khadi Board, active in non-intensive areas but relying on the funds and schemes from the Khadi Commission has its performance not much different from the latter. Since those executing the Intensive Areas constitute almost half the membership of the Kerala Khadi Board as also the Sarvodaya Mandal, the change in denomination of the agency does not change the performance to any tangible degree.

About N. E. S. Block approach only this much would be enough to state here. It would have been better for Pandit Nehru to call Mr. Wolf Ladejinsky (MacArthur's adviser on land reforms in Japan) to Anand Bhavan before he invited Mr. Albert Mayer for advice on rural development through Community Projects.

CHAPTER 28

Role of The State

THE STATE, apart from its Intensive Area Schemes and cottage industries programmes, has come up with financial help at Nilambur, taken over the Nediyruppu colony and given a little relief at Paryaram. Loans and grants have mainly flowed for soil conservation and house and well construction in new settlements. 10 acres of land have been gifted to Vinoba Niketan.

Bye-laws of the Gramdan Co-operative Societies have been shaped on the model provided by those of the Madras State. Beyond this, legal recognition has not been given to the Gramdan aspect for lack of its loose definition in the context of Kerala's rural setting.

These Gramdan Co-operative Societies could be eligible for state aid from all the different heads of development and regular co-operative financing agencies, but they have not advanced in that direction and are understood to be registered mainly for drawing Khadi Board grants and loans (Thachancode is the only exception because, it had started working earlier than Vinoba's trek in the State).

There was found not much give and take or mutual understanding arrived at between the Gramdan workers and the normal state agencies. Bound up with the concept of the withering away of the State and lack of faith in the principles of organizational approach (*Tantra-mukti*), the leadership did not exert much to draw the interest of the state in the work. There was

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an undercurrent of grumbling against the state government amidst the top leadership. Whenever approached, the ministry had been trying to meet the needs of the movement in a general way but no particular interest was shown by the ministry in the movement or the follow-up work. The main point of dispute was to make the state co-operative banks agree to issue loans 20 times the share money of the Gramdan societies. The banks, however, were found reluctant to work on these terms regarding the maximum credit limit. The authorities in the Co-operative Department were assured at the stage, when the necessary bye-laws were being formulated, that the credit will not be drawn from the regular co-operative agencies on the terms of 20 times the share money but after registration of the said societies the demands were said to be forthcoming.

The party in power did not feel Gramdan as such to be a solution. It paid more attention to pass necessary legislation about ceiling. A few words need be stated about the land reforms policy of the State Government.

The Communist Ministry in Kerala took the recommendations of the Land Reform Panel of the Planning Commission rather too seriously* and caught the time rudely by the tuft. Prior to them except that the Congress Ministry which followed the P.S.P. Ministry had ended the four freehold estates (Zamindaris) with a total area of 1,04,925 acres, the slate was almost clean regarding land reforms. On 11th April, 1957, just one week after the formation of the ministry came the ordinance to stay all evictions, followed by the Kerala Stay of Eviction Act, ordering the present occupiers and cultivators to be left undisturbed. The execution was fool-proof. There was nothing like 'voluntary surrenders' as seen in other states; no saving clauses were inserted because the Communists meant business unlike the Congress which was just playing the farce in other states. The Kerala Agrarian Relations Bill which was enacted during the June 1959 session fixes the following ceilings on ownership of land.

* And paid a heavy price by infuriating the feudal interests in the state concentrated in Nair Service Society which in alliance with the disgruntled Christian elements raised a statewide agitation to overthrow the constitutionally established government.

Quality of land	Area for ceiling
1. Coconut, arecanut garden and double crop paddy	15 acres
2. Single crop paddy	22 ½ „
3. Pepper, orange and graft mango garden	30 ½ „
4. Cashew nut or Tharису lands	37 ½ „

Figures are not available as to how much land is actually to change hands through the ceiling. The data provided in Kerala's Second Five Year Plan shows that there are 39,000 holdings above 25 acres covering 25.40 lakhs of acres which forms 31.8 per cent of the total area. Allowing roughly 25 acres per holding after the axe of ceiling falls, these 39,000 holders will have only 10 lakhs of acres with them. Out of the surplus of 15 lakh acres a substantial part goes to the previous tenants who will own it by paying the sum 16 times the rent in 16 equal annual instalments and little goes to the population of landless labourers numbering 29 lakhs forming 39.8 per cent of the total agricultural population (about 72.7 lakhs) and 21.1 per cent of the entire population in the state. Obviously a larger section of the landless population will still be left without land, while others will be swelling the ranks of those with un-economic holdings.

It is quite understandable why the Communist Government here had decided to distribute the surplus lands to the landless on an individual basis and not on co-operative lines as resolved by the Congress. Apart from political grounds and seen from a practical angle the Communists did not have the required constructive cadre within the party or the administration that could shoulder this rigorous task of co-operative ventures on meagre surplus lands. As such, they have been shrewd enough to state it on the floor of the provincial assembly, "The approach of Government is not economic but of distributing land to the landless." But it remains to be seen how the bulk of landless labourers are affected by this legislation which is undoubtedly progressive otherwise. Individual land distribution to a section of the landless population raises fresh issues of providing credit

and other resources to the grantees if they have not to change their masters from the big landlords to money lenders and traders as seen at Nediirippu colony. This section may no doubt have the land hunger appeased a bit but the new problem of small uneconomic holdings takes up a larger magnitude. Obviously, the pattern does not change in favour of agrarian development in the state and the ceiling does not lessen but rather enhances the necessity of the community ownership of land for the best economic use either through individual or co-operative or both types of land management with a margin of periodic redistribution of village lands. With the landless having some land to their credit, their participation in the community effort becomes more positive and assertive. Acquisitive tendencies get a curb and the market value of land comes down since it is made freely available to the lowest section of landless people. Detachment from land increases in general because previously, to be landless was a problem for the lowest section; now the ownership of uneconomic holdings becomes a problem as seen in Paryaram.

As such ceiling may be considered as the first step towards agricultural organization and not the last. Shri R. K. Patil aptly states* "The revolutionary significance of the Gramdan movement appears to be not only that it insists on a more equitable distribution of land but also that it focusses attention on the immediate need of the village by completely eliminating the concept of private ownership in land and treating land as a source to be utilized in the interest of the whole village community. After Gramdan, not only does the entire village land become available for replanning, reorganization and re-allotment but it continues to be so for all times. This is the prime need of the village to-day."

As stated by Vinoba in his manifesto on Gramdan (Chapter 6) nothing can alter the pressure on land. But Gramdan does help in land development through joint effort if once a healthy relationship is struck between the working hands and the ownership as has been found at Vellinezhi. More than 80 per cent holdings being uneconomic (with a due

* *Land Reform in Co-operative Farming in India* by R. K. Patil



margin of increase in percentage after ceiling) the cultivating families in Kerala shall have to come to some such understanding as envisaged by Gramdan if there is an earnest effort to reach at a solution of socio-economic problems in the state. To quote Prof. D. R. Gadgil, a member of the Rural Credit Survey Committee, "the size of the farming business of at least half the cultivating families in India is such that it is futile to consider them as independent units of land exploitation. Therefore, a land policy for a developing economy must face up to the serious problem of the reorganization of these units. This recognition must be more explicit and must lead on to a realization of the inability of any supply or credit reorganization to deal with fundamental defects of the small size and turnover of the existing basic units and the large numbers involved in any scheme of reorganization."

It is clear that the existing pattern of ownership is a hurdle in every way to an all round development of the agrarian economy. The axe of ceiling will only multiply the heads of this hydra-headed demon rather than chop them off.

CHAPTER 29

Epilogue

It is a historically established fact that asceticism has always been practically useful in moulding the Indian masses to a new way of life. To that extent, Vinoba has reaffirmed the faith of the masses in enlightened asceticism. And the people, and for that reason the parties too, in India, have unanimously accepted his line of thought. It is a different matter that the emotional upsurge generated by Vinoba in the Indian masses needs practical realistic men for its effective channelization. Vinoba is a Marx who needs a Lenin in the Indian context. It is unfortunate that aged politicians have made Sarvodaya a retirement camp, which talented youth avoids to join. All appeals made to the youth to join the movement fail since Vinoba, they feel, is surrounded by the political and monastic junk of India. This, as such, is the first breach in the lines of communication between Vinoba and the people. Confined all his life to scholastic pursuits and consequent upon the high spiritual basis of the personality, Vinoba has proved a poor judge of persons and indirectly harmed his own cause which requires equally a master mind to heal.

Well, it may sound surprising but it is a fact that most of the workers would be ignorant about their colleagues' work and its implication before they go through the contents of these pages. A doesn't know what B is doing and B doesn't know what A is doing even though they may have the occasion to meet each other often at camps and conferences. The author

felt rather embarrassed when, at a meeting, he was complimented for knowing much more about Gramdan in Kerala than any or all the workers or leaders of the State. Not that the Sarvodaya Mandal doesn't have its provincial paper; '*Bhoodan Kahlam*', a Malayalam weekly published from Calicut, has a circulation of about 2,000 copies but, as is usual with Sarvodaya journalism, it doesn't go beyond publishing the translations of Vinoba's or J. P.'s speeches or extracts from *Bhoodan Yagna* — a Hindi weekly of Banaras. At best, it flashes Kelappanji's speeches in original and that is the limit below which it can't step down. There appears to be a self-imposed moral ban which can be broken only to run the risk of the wrath of leadership. It is presumed that workers' role has no significance; only the leaders have to be heard and read. The journal is running under a precarious financial condition. As also referred to by Vinoba in his Kerala tour, even the wrappers are not torn by the subscribers. They can by now successfully presume what stuff there will be in it.

The field study is not carried out through the journal. The workers who realize themselves fully and deeply through the village work develop an aversion towards publicity which could be cured by visiting them through journal's representative but that seems too much to plan. All this bars the worker from helping others in the field through his own experience and *vice versa*. This lack of radiation results in loss of self-confidence and thereby vitiates the morale of field work. Moreover, in the face of a flood of ideological trash everywhere around him, the worker feels ashamed, rather than proud, of his realistic approach.

Workers' meetings in Sarvodaya here don't seem to serve their purpose of inter-communication and are not a fit atmosphere for crystallizing the issues and posing fresh problems. The bandwagon of retired leadership is naturally consoled to meet the tame audiences. So the audacious ones who have profundity too, retreat to their field and avoid the displeasure of complacent leadership which seems to have lost the sense of urgency in action due to so many factors inherent in the very foundation of Sarvodaya platform. Sarvodaya, as it works at present, infuses more faith in leadership, less of self-confidence

and least faith in the people. The atmosphere of All India Sarvodaya Session percolates down to meetings almost at all levels where elders speak and the youth audiences listen to the patent sermon of :

‘Their’s not to make reply
Their’s not to reason why
Their’s but to do and die.’

Consequently, workers who constitute the real salt of the movement keep mum or keep away and the meetings mostly misfire. Met personally they are a game, a challenge, but in meetings they have been found terribly handicapped by the atmosphere prevalent there.

Scores of youth camps held mostly by G. S. Nidhi (Gandhi Smarak Nidhi) to indoctrinate and draw the youth for constructive activities in Gramdan villages have equally failed to serve the required purpose. Orators, whose own experience has been so partial and little don’t inspire the adventurous and the inquisitive young minds. Most of the campers come to study the prospects of employment by the organization. Right type out of the young blood which feels “old deeds for old people, new deeds for new” generally keeps away and develops certain aversions too against the movement due to certain visible contradictions in the conduct of Sarvodaya leadership which has yet to wean itself away from the lure of conspicuousness and attachment to prestige and property.

Out of about 12,000 families who came forward to sign for Gramdan, roughly 1200 have so far been approached rightly or wrongly through the activities going on in Gramdans. The rest lie cordoned, nick-named and deprived of the contact of an advanced opinion on reorganization work. Except a vague altruism, the imagination of the villager is not roused to fight the inertia. Without channelizing his motive powers into constructive activities, the villager through the new indoctrination is lulled to take up an attitude of indifference towards the state, the elections and general public bodies of Gram Panchayats and co-operatives. Khadi is forced down the throat of the people without creating the necessary atmosphere for the villagers to convey their felt needs and the activities that

will run best through self propulsion. Mr. Evelyn Wood makes a very pertinent observation when he states* that Vinoba provides a 'conscious channel of emotional communication downwards or inwards to village people (but) the inverse flow of communication from the village folk along the channel so opened still remains an unsolved problem for every development worker.' Further he states ".....a new social pattern, more motivated by emotional love for one's neighbours, might conceivably grow from Gramdan. This happy outcome is only possible provided the fullest use be made of the upward and outward channels of communication from the revolutionized village-folk."

Since Sarvodaya leadership couldn't imagine the possibilities of regulating the outward channels of communications it has kept these village units pocketed and isolated from the expert advice on socio-economic planning and reorganization and has not itself thrown the necessary flood of light on the problems facing them so as to invite the interest of social scientists and agronomists. Left to do the job by themselves out of their vain pride and self-righteousness they have almost smashed immense possibilities for a healthy experiment in co-operative planning and that moral fervour too is getting lost. To quote Prof. Dantwala "..... in the process of devising the institutional framework of the Sarvodaya society there is as much need to re-examine the inherited patterns of thought and belief of the preceptors as of the technicians. The process of experimentation must be conducted in a climate of understanding tolerance, with the technicians providing the know-how and the preceptor the frame of moral reference."**

It is unjust at this stage to pass any judgement about the future possibilities about the movement in the state but a few observations are necessary.

Gramdan holds the potentialities as a powerful ideology to mobilize the scattered village population of Kerala where, out of 26.7 lakh holdings, 14.84 lakhs or about 55.6 per cent are less than one acre in size. This section particularly and

* "Bhoodan as Communication" *Gandhi Marg*, January, 1958.

** *Gandhi Marg*, January, 1958.

the next below 5 acres generally are in dire need of group planning to have an efficient management of small uneconomic holdings and planned use of surplus man-power through land improvement and local industries. Trusteeship by bigger owners as seen at Vellinezhi, equally holds immense possibilities of gearing up production and delivering social justice. Gramdan, if it comes in the right spirit, has the additional advantage of mutual trust and emotional integration which is generally missing in the co-operatives raised under the rush of accomplishing the plan targets. Without any binding sentiment, every human congregation is a mere crowd so also the so-called co-operatives. Gramdan adds the throbs of the sentiment and adds a soul to the co-operative effort.

But villagers, being practical steel-minded people, lack the imaginative ability of the sponsors and orators of the plans and movements. They would like to see a demonstration of what they may be asked to do. As such, more of renunciation of property and prestige on the part of the sponsors, with an increased amount of intensive piloting work, seems necessary and the one already going on needs a close study, prompt technical guidance and finances to see through the game since, as Dr. Gyan Chand says, "These (Gramdan) villages are pilot projects not only for the villagers themselves, but for the national economy, the system of administration and the whole policy." *

In the context of Kerala's rural setting and sociology Gramdan, if wielded properly, can be a good measure to mobilize small neighbourhood groups for social and economic solidarity and to fully revitalize the rural economy. These small mutual aid groups and units can gradually merge for further co-operative planning. But how to make it operative?

For that the focus of activities in the Sarvodaya circles must be field studies and not the sermons. Vinoba through his burning idealism wedded to the severest asceticism has conveyed throughout the length and breadth of India to every village, home and hamlet, the required message by using the simplest conveyance of his two august firm legs which have by now

* *Gandhi Marg*, January, 1958.

Epilogue

marched more than the length of the equator. He alone is enough for publicity and spread of the ideology. But the fickle camp-followers will do well not to deceive themselves by preaching. People in India had enough of it. Deeds are the needs, not the words. Oratory must stop and mere orators must be disbanded forthwith. It must be clear by now that the success of all plans and movements in India depends upon the workers in the field who can go to the core of problems, enter the people's heart and carry them along to the well-defined objectives. The non-realistic, spineless, old and ineffective lot must be forced to retire. The press and platform of the movement must be in the hands of those who are in the field wrestling with the issues and battling with the vested elements. In short, men who walk on hard earth must take up the reins of the movement, improve the tone of administering affairs and sincerely enlighten the laity and experts about the concrete situations to mutually spark and be sparked.

At the spiritual heights which Vinoba has attained, every thing withers; the state and the society, the family, property and ego all dissolve into thin air. But those who have not achieved those heights must not talk of the withering away of the state and should have the grain of realism to accept the importance and existence of the state, political parties and the whole democratic set-up. They will do well to stick to the field, educate the masses and co-ordinate the role of all official and non-official agencies at the field level to see through the integrated rural development and, if necessary, raise a strong public opinion against the inadequacy of certain state measures. For all this, the state must be accepted as a reality but the role must remain educational and not political even towards politics. Sarvodaya, for lack of positive attitude in such matters, has not unreasonably been labelled as an effeminate philosophy which compromises more than it captures, professes more than it performs and snatches more than it offers. Since there is no alternative to the state, the right step will be to purify and educate the cadre of political parties about the field by pioneering ever-fresh approaches to the people and their problems. The right step at the present moment will be to rouse the political heads for coalition at the centre than

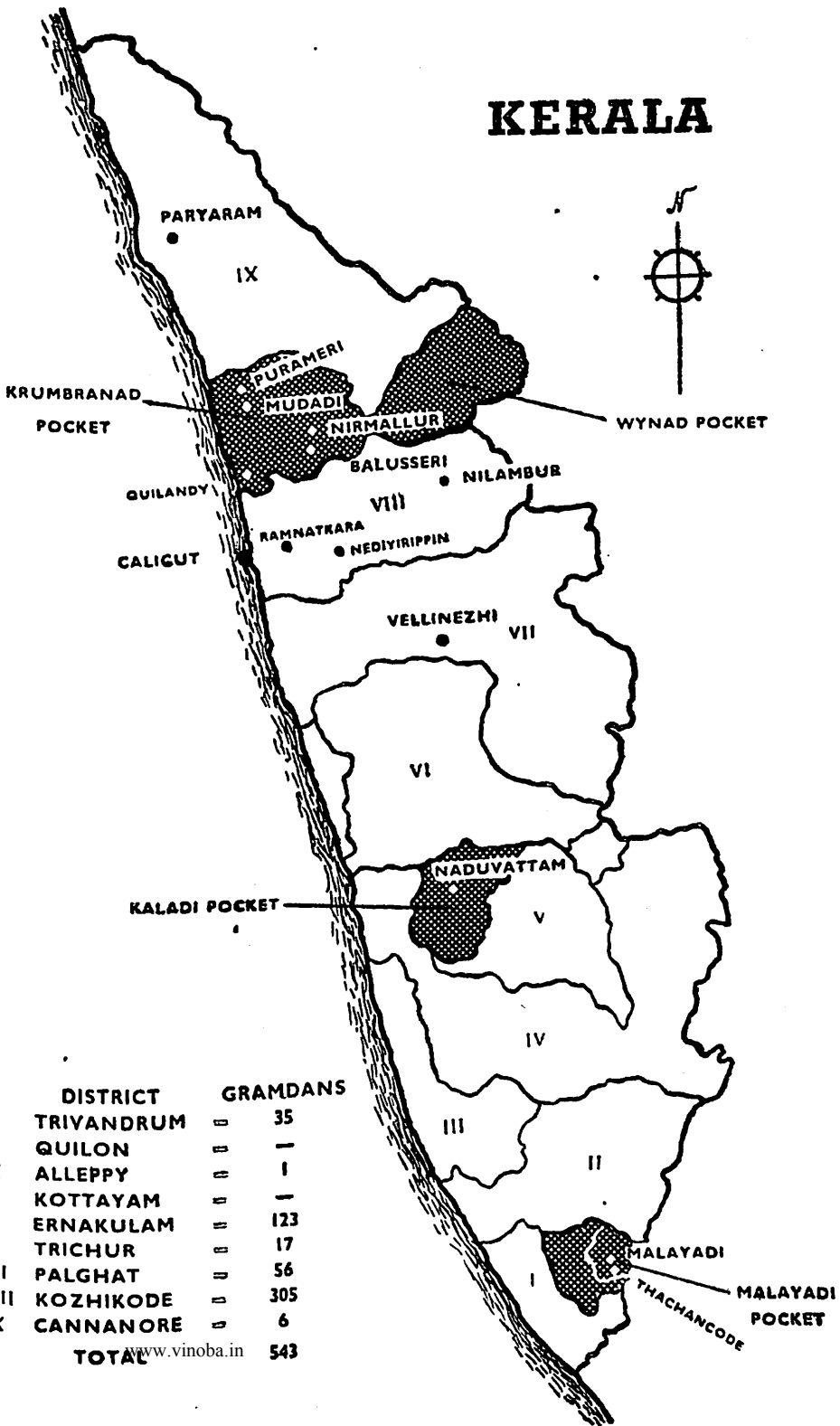
strike at the very root of national existence by demanding the withering of the state. For that matter, coining of new stunts like Shanti Mandals, Shanti Senas, Sarvodaya Patra and Sevaks shall have to be stopped and a single, sound, well-knit and effective organization of field workers with perfectly clear well-defined objectives shall have to be rebuilt to smash the prevalent atmosphere of a retirement camp.

The danger to the movement is unfortunately more from inside. A worker feels sorry for the leaders when faithful people expose on his face the glaring contradictions of the leaders. People won't mind the use of ultra-modern gadgets if the leaders could stop their farce of insisting on hand pounded rice, hand-milled flour and cow's milk and butter, in season and out of season. Leaders are a menace to the simple hosts; as such all the emotional ties created by the workers towards an ideology among the people, particularly the youth, break earlier than they are forged. This sort of conspicuousness is equally disliked by the people and rural communities particularly are very very sensitive about such issues. The Sarvodaya leaders have made a fetish of cottage industries and Khadi and thus killed rather than kindled the very spirit at their back.

Self-criticism could cure half the maladies of Sarvodaya but if it does not come, literary men have a job through criticism to make Sarvodaya a more practical philosophy. History has it on record that people have shown a high spirit of sacrifice if once they have been thoroughly convinced of the cause. And to fight poverty, crippling a large mass of people, is not a less noble cause.

The achievements of any movement will always be proportionate to the enlightened service, practical effectiveness and sincerity of its leaders. It is better that the leadership stops cashing any more on the austerities of Vinoba. There is a limit to it.

KERALA



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